The Heart of Dhamma Practice 3.10

Restoration of the Buddha's Original Teaching Based on the Suttas of the Pali Canon

Current version here

The ascetic Gotama taught only one thing: dukkha*, the cause of* dukkha*, the cessation of* dukkha*, and the path to the cessation of* dukkha*.*

"Whatever is subject to arising is subject to cessation."

This English translation was produced with the assistance of AI and subsequently reviewed and edited by the author. It is not a professional translation and may still contain linguistic or interpretive inaccuracies.

In case of discrepancies, the original Russian version should be regarded as authoritative.

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How to Read This Document

This document is an attempt to restore the Buddha's Original Teaching on the basis of the suttas of the Pali Canon and direct investigation of experience.

The aim of the path is to see what is happening as it actually is: to see every conditioned process as impermanent (*anicca*), unsatisfactory (*dukkha*), not-self (*anattā*), compounded, and dependent on causes and conditions. To see how it arises, what sustains it, and how it ceases.

This applies to the mind itself: one must recognize craving (*taṇhā*), clinging (*upādāna*), ignorance (*avijjā*), becoming (*bhava*), and the arising "I." Recognize defilements, avoid deceiving oneself, and do not force experience to fit the image of a "proper practitioner." Do not cultivate defilements; rather, see their causes and cease sustaining them.

This document does not claim to be 100% accurate or complete. It may contain errors and imprecise formulations.

Pali terms are retained where translation can easily distort their meaning. For example, *dukkha* means more than "suffering," *taṇhā* is not simply any desire, *upādāna* is more than strong attachment, *bhava* means more than "existence," and *anattā* is not a declaration that "there is no me."

The best way to use this text is to take one passage at a time and test it in daily life. If the practice becomes a source of tension, contempt, pride, or fear, something has been misunderstood. If it leads to greater clarity, gentleness, sobriety, letting go, and reduced reactivity, the direction is sound.

0. Preliminary Foundation: Health, Sobriety, and Values

The practice of Dhamma does not take place in a vacuum. The body, the psyche, trauma, habits, social environment, and values substantially affect the conditions of practice. Before engaging in subtler work with *dukkha*, *taṇhā*, and *anattā*, it is therefore useful to examine this foundation honestly.

Area	What matters here	Practical criterion
Psychiatry and neurology	Severe disorders, neurological conditions, and states requiring medical care.	When there is a risk of self-harm, psychosis, severe insomnia, panic, or sudden deterioration, professional help is needed, rather than an attempt to endure heroically through practice.
Psychological health	Trauma, attachments, emotions, and the capacity for kindness and connection.	Practice makes behavior gentler, more honest, and more responsible, not colder, prouder, or more detached.
Cognitive sobriety	The ability to notice patterns and errors in thinking, projections, and self-deception.	Less dogmatism and fewer abrupt conclusions; more consistency and clarity.
Values	A shift away from personal gain toward what is beneficial, toward simplicity, and toward the Dhamma as the highest value.	Less preoccupation with status and pleasure, and greater interest in practice.
Self-observation	The skill of seeing body, feelings, mind, and *dhammā* as processes.	Instead of "I am like this," there appears: "a condition, feeling, craving, and impulse arose."

The body and mind are closely interconnected, so it is important to care for one's health: eat a nutritious diet, get enough sleep, move, and maintain physical fitness. But without extremes, chasing achievements, or exertion that leads to injury.

Adequate sleep is especially important. Most adults need 7–9 hours of sleep per day, around eight on average. Irreplaceable physiological processes take place during sleep: recovery of the body, consolidation of memory, regulation of metabolism, and functioning of the nervous and immune systems. Meditation does not replace sleep, even if it provides deep rest. Most likely, stories that the Buddha slept only four hours are inventions. Sleep deprivation impairs clarity of mind, attention, and the ability to practice.

There is no point in deliberately restricting oneself to an ascetic diet. If a monotonous diet led to liberation, horses would have become arahants long ago.

Moderation is also needed in caring for one's health. One should not worry about every minor ailment or seek medical attention without need. It is important to investigate bodily sensations, their causes, and the mental reactions that arise, while not neglecting necessary treatment.

The main thing is for one's way of life to create favorable conditions for practice, without care for the body becoming another object of craving and clinging.

Not every form of meditation is automatically a practice of liberation. Meditation may be used for stability, clarity, and reducing anxiety. In this document, the main criterion is rather this: does the practice weaken *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *avijjā*, and lead toward the cessation of *dukkha*?

Meditation is better understood not as a mechanical algorithm, but as a living and, in some respects, creative process. The Buddha gave a method, a direction, and verifiable conditions: *sīla*, *sati*, *samādhi*, *paññā*, the abandoning of *taṇhā*, and the cultivation of *magga*. But there is no single precisely established sequence that leads to *Nibbāna*. The path cultivates conditions for the ending of craving and clinging. *Nibbāna* is not produced by a technique and is not a conditioned result.

Caution: meditation should not replace treatment where medical care is needed. If practice intensifies alienation, insomnia, fear, obsession, or contempt for others, that is a warning sign.

1. Testing the Dhamma: Eight Criteria from AN 8.53

A good safeguard against spiritual self-deception is to look beyond appealing words to their results. AN 8.53 provides a filter: what leads to dispassion, freedom, simplicity, and less strain may be recognized as being in accordance with the Dhamma and Vinaya (*Dhamma-Vinaya*).

Criterion	Meaning	Question for checking
virāga, not *sarāga*	Toward dispassion, not passion.	After practice, is there less attraction, passion, and dependence?
visaṃyoga, not *saṃyoga*	Toward release from bonds, not bondage.	Is there less of "I must obtain/prove/hold on to this"?
apacaya, not *ācaya*	Toward reduction, not accumulation.	Is there less mental proliferation, statuses, and concepts?
appicchatā, not *mahicchatā*	Toward having few wishes, not many.	Is there less desire for reinforcement, recognition, stimulation, or special status?
santuṭṭhi, not *asantuṭṭhi*	Toward contentment, not discontentment.	Does the need to keep improving conditions and seeking new experiences decrease?
paviveka, not *saṅgaṇikā*	Toward seclusion, not constant company.	Is there less of a pull toward noise, argument, confirmation, and novelty?
vīriyārambha, not *kosajja*	Toward arousing energy, not laziness.	Is there energetic and steady effort without violence toward oneself?

Criterion	Meaning	Question for checking
subharatā, not *dubbharatā*	Toward being easy to support, not demanding or fastidious.	Is the person becoming simpler in daily life and interactions?

If a teaching or practice increases dependence, fear, craving for status, harshness, a sense of specialness, or contempt for others, it should be thoroughly re-examined.

The complexity of a system does not prove that it leads closer to liberation. The criterion remains practical: are *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *māna* becoming weaker?

How to Evaluate the Transmission of the Dhamma

The early suttas are the primary basis of this document. However, the authority of a source does not by itself make a text true.

In MN 95, faith, preference, oral tradition, reasoning, and a view accepted after reflection may accord with the truth or may not. Until there is direct knowledge, it is more accurate to state honestly the basis of one's understanding and not declare it the only possible view.

In AN 4.180, a report attributed to the Buddha, the Saṅgha, or learned elders is not to be accepted or rejected immediately, but compared with the suttas and Vinaya. It is also important to consider possible errors in transmission, later editing and interpolation, context, parallels in other canons, the intent of the sutta, the influence of tradition, distortions in translation, and so forth. One's own experience helps test the practical meaning.

2. Doctrinal Core

This chapter provides a brief overview of the teaching before the following chapters examine its individual parts in greater detail.

The Four *ariyasacca*

1. *dukkha* - the unsatisfactory nature of conditioned experience.
2. *samudaya* - the cause of *dukkha*: *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna*.
3. *nirodha* - the cessation of *dukkha*: clinging is absent, *taṇhā* has faded away, and *avijjā* has been fully recognized.
4. *magga* - the path leading to the cessation of *dukkha*: the Noble Eightfold Path.

Dependent Origination: *paṭiccasamuppāda*

The twelve-link chain shows how some processes condition others:

$$\begin{aligned} &\textit{avijjā} \rightarrow \textit{saṅkhārā} \rightarrow \textit{viññāṇa} \rightleftarrows \textit{nāma-rūpa} \\ &\quad \rightarrow \textit{saḷāyatana} \rightarrow \textit{phassa} \rightarrow \textit{vedanā} \\ &\quad \rightarrow \textit{taṇhā} \rightarrow \textit{upādāna} \rightarrow \textit{bhava} \rightarrow \textit{jāti} \rightarrow \textit{jarāmaraṇa}, \ \textit{dukkha}. \end{aligned}$$

The Six Sense Fields (*āyatana*)

Experience unfolds through six internal sense fields and their corresponding objects:

- the eye and forms;
- the ear and sounds;

- the nose and odors;
- the tongue and tastes;
- the body and tactile objects;
- the mind and mental phenomena.

The general pattern of a sensory event is:

$$\text{sense field} + \text{object} \rightarrow \textit{viññāṇa} \rightarrow \textit{phassa} \rightarrow \textit{vedanā}.$$

This is how the twelve-link chain connects with immediate experience: what is seen, heard, felt, and thought.

The Five *khandhā*

What is experienced and can be appropriated as "I" and "mine" is examined in the suttas through five aggregates:

- *rūpa* - body, form;
- *vedanā* - feeling;
- *saññā* - recognition, perception;
- *saṅkhārā* - formative activities;
- *viññāṇa* - consciousness.

The problem is not these processes themselves, but clinging to them and appropriating them as "I" and "mine." It is this clinging that sustains *dukkha*.

The Noble Eightfold Path (*ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga*)

Group	Factors
paññā - wisdom	*sammā-diṭṭhi* - right view; *sammā-saṅkappa* - right intention.
sīla - ethical conduct	*sammā-vācā* - right speech; *sammā-kammanta* - right action; *sammā-ājīva* - right livelihood.
samādhi - development of collectedness	*sammā-vāyāma* - right effort; *sammā-sati* - right recollection/awareness; *sammā-samādhi* - right collectedness, defined in the standard formula as the four *jhānas*.

The factors of the path support and strengthen one another.

Eight Factors of the Path and Two Culminating Factors

In MN 117, two further factors are given:

9. *sammā-ñāṇa* - right knowledge;
10. *sammā-vimutti* - right liberation.

In this discourse, eight factors are named for a disciple on the path, while ten are named for one who has reached perfection. The final two should be understood as the culmination of the path:

$$\textit{sammā-samādhi} \rightarrow \textit{sammā-ñāṇa} \rightarrow \textit{sammā-vimutti}.$$

A Map of *samādhi*: Jhānas, Formless Dimensions, and Cessation

1. the first *jhāna*;
2. the second *jhāna*;
3. the third *jhāna*;
4. the fourth *jhāna*;
5. the dimension of boundless space;
6. the dimension of infinite consciousness;
7. the dimension of nothingness;
8. the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception;
9. the cessation of perception and feeling (*saññāvedayitanirodha*).

What matters is the depth of each attainment, recognition of its conditioned nature, and relinquishment of the corresponding support. Simply passing through all the attainments without wisdom and the cessation of clinging is not liberation.

The Five Hindrances (*nīvaraṇa*)

- *kāmacchanda* - sensual desire;
- *vyāpāda* - ill will, irritation;
- *thīna-middha* - lethargy and drowsiness;
- *uddhacca-kukkucca* - restlessness and regret;
- *vicikicchā* - doubt that obstructs practice.

The Seven Factors of Awakening (*bojjhaṅgā*)

- *sati* - recollection;
- *dhammavicaya* - investigation of phenomena;
- *viriya* - enthusiasm, diligence;
- *pīti* - joy, rapture;
- *passaddhi* - tranquility;
- *samādhi* - collectedness;
- *upekkhā* - equanimity.

The Three Unwholesome Roots

Iti 50 names three roots of the unwholesome:

- *lobha* - greed, passionate attraction;
- *dosa* - aversion, hostility;

- *moha* - delusion, mental obscuration.

Lobha, *dosa*, and *moha* describe the roots of the unwholesome, whereas *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna* describe different conditions in the unfolding of *dukkha*. One triad should therefore not be used as a direct substitute for the other.

Additional Supports

- *mettā* - goodwill;
- *asubha* - contemplation of unattractiveness;
- *yoniso manasikāra* - wise direction of attention;
- *indriya-saṃvara* - restraint of the sense faculties.

3. The Field of Experience: *sabba* and the Six Sense Fields

In SN 35.23, "the all" is limited to the six sense fields: the eye and forms, the ear and sounds, the nose and odors, the tongue and tastes, the body and tangibles, and the mind and mental phenomena.

For practice, this means beginning with what is experienced right now: what is seen, heard, or felt in the body, as well as feelings, thoughts, images, intentions, and reactions. There is no need first to settle whether "the world exists in itself," and so forth. The practical question is simpler and more concrete: how does feeling arise from contact, how does craving arise from feeling, how does clinging arise from craving, and how can the chain be left unsupported?

The Six Sense Fields (*āyatana*)

Sense field	Object	Consciousness	Contact
Eye	form	visual consciousness	visual *phassa*
Ear	sound	auditory consciousness	auditory *phassa*
Nose	odor	olfactory consciousness	olfactory *phassa*
Tongue	taste	gustatory consciousness	gustatory *phassa*
Body	tangible object	bodily consciousness	bodily *phassa*
Mind	ideas, images, memories	mental consciousness	mental *phassa*

An important practical conclusion follows: a thought, concept, image, memory, or fantasy is just as much an object of practice as a sound or a bodily sensation. Clinging can arise toward them as well.

Here "the eye" means more than the anatomical organ or a fixed bodily entity. It is a changing, conditioned sense faculty participating in the process of seeing. In dependence on the eye and visible form, visual consciousness arises; the conjunction of these three is called contact, and contact conditions feeling. The other sense fields work in the same way.

In MN 38, consciousness is compared to a fire that is named after its fuel: a wood fire, grass fire, or straw fire. Likewise, consciousness is designated according to the conditions on

which it arises: visual consciousness arises in dependence on the eye and forms, auditory consciousness on the ear and sounds, and mental consciousness on the mind and mental objects. Consciousness here is not an independent bearer of experience; each type arises when the relevant conditions are present.

Mind as an Internal Sense Field

Within this map of experience, mind is neither a hidden master nor an eternal observer. It is one of the six internal sense fields. The eye encounters visible forms; the ear, sounds; the nose, odors; the tongue, tastes; the body, tactile objects; and the mind, mental phenomena.

Thoughts, images, memories, and concepts connected with what was seen, heard, or felt may become objects of the mental sense field. An already arisen mental process may itself become an object of *mano*: a feeling, recognition, intention, a state of *citta*, or other *dhammā*. A sensory episode can therefore continue as an inner story: "this is a danger," "this is about me," "I must respond." Here it is useful to distinguish contexts. *Mano* denotes mind as the sixth internal sense field; *viññāṇa*, consciousness of an object that arises dependent on conditions. It is useful to observe *citta* not as a permanent "mind," but as a process that changes with conditions and always has a particular coloration. These terms do not denote three separate entities, but describe interrelated processes from different angles.

The mind, too, arises and changes according to conditions. Discontent, fear, craving, ignorance, clarity, calm, and the observer are conditioned processes of mind.

To see mind as mind is to recognize their arising, change, and cessation, without appropriating either defilement, purity, or the very act of seeing.

How "a Being" and "the World" Are Constructed

What we call "the world" is experienced through the six sense fields. What we call "a being" is constructed from the five aggregates: body, feeling, recognition, formations, and consciousness.

The visible becomes "what I see." A feeling becomes "my feeling." A thought becomes "my opinion." A memory becomes "my story." Under ignorance, "I," "mine," and "for me" are added to what is seen, heard, felt, and thought. Conditioned experience thus becomes the basis of a personal story and further clinging.

Memory is a conditioned process of mind. Attention, the state of mind, and underlying tendencies influence what is remembered and how past experience is perceived.

From memories, a story of "my life" and the idea of a continuous "I" supposedly remaining the same are formed. Yet memories and the sense that "this happened to me" also arise and cease according to conditions.

Practice does not require denying what is seen, heard, or felt. It teaches one to see how "I" and "mine" are added to experience.

In practice, "I" can be observed as the very process of clinging, appropriation, and identification. A feeling becomes "my feeling," an intention becomes "I want," an action becomes "I do," and conditioned processes come together as "I am like this" or "I am in this situation."

"I" can also manifest as a controlling process: "this must happen this way," "this state must be preserved," "this must not be." What is happening is then no longer seen as it is, but is sorted, held, and fitted to a pre-established picture.

The five *khandhā* continue to function without a separate owner. "I" too can arise through conditions, but when the aggregates are no longer identified with, it does not become a basis

for further clinging and *bhava*.

The sense of "I" also arises and ceases according to conditions.

Dukkha arises when identification with this "I" occurs and experience is appropriated: "this is mine", "I must hold on to this", "this must not happen to me".

It is important to see "I," craving, and clinging as conditioned, impermanent processes. When they are neither appropriated nor held on to, their fading becomes visible, and the further proliferation of *bhava* receives no support.

The experienced world is made up of conditioned processes of the mind and the six sense fields. In SN 35.82, the Buddha explains the "world" through the sense faculties, their objects, the corresponding consciousness, contact, and feeling. All these processes are impermanent and subject to dissolution.

With ignorance, formations (*saṅkhārā*), craving, clinging, and becoming (*bhava*) arise, sustaining the continuation of *saṃsāra*. Thus the experienced world is formed and reproduced, and within it the notion of "I" and "mine" arises.

The mind itself is also conditioned. It is important to see how experience comes together, what processes sustain it, how appropriation arises, and what happens when craving and clinging cease to receive nourishment.

4. The Horizon of Practice: *Nibbāna* as *asaṅkhata*

Nibbāna should not be reduced to a trance, non-being, the Absolute, a blank screen, a pleasant state, dissociation, or a meditative attainment that can be maintained. It is *asaṅkhata*: the unmade, the unconditioned, not arisen as a composite process. The Pali texts Iti 43 and Ud 8.3 speak of the unborn, the unarisen, and the unmade, by virtue of which release from the born and made is possible.

In *Nibbāna* there is no *avijjā*, no *taṇhā*, and no *upādāna*. What matters here is precisely their absence, even potentially.

It is important to distinguish the following:

- Calming the mind is a valuable condition, but not liberation itself.
- The cessation of a particular chain is a useful small-scale experience of *nirodha*, but is not necessarily *Nibbāna*.
- Deep states of *samādhi* can support wisdom, but if one clings to them, they become a subtle form of *bhava*.
- *Nibbāna* is not appropriated as "my attainment." If a new identity forms around liberation, this is reason to check whether new clinging has arisen.

Nibbāna Is Not a "True Self"

A misunderstanding may arise: the body is not "self," feelings are not "self," recognition, formations, and consciousness are not "self," so there must be a real "self" somewhere behind them. *Nibbāna* is then understood as a true essence, pure consciousness, and so forth. This is often conditioned by craving for existence.

But the Buddha examined the five *khandhā* not so that they could be rejected and another "self" found, but in order to recognize the mechanism of clinging itself. The five aggregates encompass the entire field of conditioned experience that can be appropriated as "I" and "mine": body, feeling, perception/recognition, formative activities, and consciousness.

Nibbāna is therefore neither an eternal "self" nor the annihilation of a "self." There is nothing to annihilate: an independent self is found neither in any aggregate nor outside them. *Nibbāna* does not mean the cessation of the five *khandhā*. During life they continue to function through conditions, but are not appropriated as "I" and "mine": the aggregates are fully let go.

The absence of an explicit sense of "I" or a separate observer does not in itself prove the cessation of *avijjā*. The temporary absence of appropriation and the complete exhaustion of its conditions are not the same thing.

Sometimes the coarse role "I act" disappears, but a subtler one arises: "I observe," "I know," "I have attained the absence of self." The very sense of an observer is also conditioned, and clinging can arise to it as well.

Appropriation in the form "this is mine" is not eliminated simply by replacing it with "this is not mine." Aversion and a new "not-I" that rejects experience or even awareness may also lie hidden behind such denial.

Feeling, attention, and awareness are conditioned processes that arise and cease according to conditions. There is no separate "I" that owns or controls them. The very sense "I feel" or "I observe" is also an arising process of mind.

It is important to see each process as it is, including appropriation as it arises. There is no need to suppress feelings or stop attention and awareness. With clear seeing, clinging to them is let go, while the processes themselves continue to arise and fade according to conditions.

Nibbāna should not be understood as a conditioned state of consciousness produced by a technique, maintained by effort, and then brought to an end. The early texts connect it with the abandoning of *taṇhā*, dispassion, and the unconditioned, without introducing a new entity, a "true observer," or a subtler mode of existence.

Beyond Existence and Non-existence

The Buddha did not reduce liberation to the statement "I exist" or to the statement "I do not exist." Both formulas still revolve around "I." In the first, clinging to existence remains; in the second, clinging to non-existence.

Practice goes deeper. It shows how the very framework "I am" arises from ignorance, craving, clinging, and becoming. When ignorance is recognized as ignorance, this framework loses its nourishment. There is then no longer a need to seek salvation in either existence or non-existence.

Stages of Awakening and the Ten *saṃyojana*

In the suttas, stages of awakening are described primarily through the weakening or cutting of fetters (*saṃyojana*), not through the experience of unusual states. This is a map of release from clinging, not a set of titles and not a reason to build an identity around "my attainment."

The Path and Fruit of Stream-entry In SN 55.5, the "stream" is the Noble Eightfold Path. A *sotāpanna* is one who has entered this stream and realized the fruit of stream-entry.

In MN 142, *sotāpattiphalasacchikiriyāya paṭipanna* is one who practices for the realization of the fruit of stream-entry. In SN 25.1, *saddhānusārī* and *dhammānusārī* have not yet realized the fruit of stream-entry, but they cannot die without realizing it.

The fruit of stream-entry is characterized by the abandoning of the first three fetters: *sakkāya-diṭṭhi*, *vicikicchā*, and *sīlabbata-parāmāsa*.

Three Foundations of *saṃsāra* and the Stages of the Path At the basis of *saṃsāra* lie three interconnected processes: *upādāna*, *taṇhā*, and *avijjā*.

At different stages of the path, different layers of this mechanism are uncovered:

- *sotāpanna* — direct recognition of "I" as a process of clinging and disidentification from it;
- the path from *sotāpanna* to *sakadāgāmin* — penetrating *taṇhā* as the fuel of clinging;
- the path from *sakadāgāmin* to *anāgāmin* — the further fading of subtler manifestations of *taṇhā* and clinging;
- the path to *arahant* — complete recognition of *avijjā*.

Upādāna, *taṇhā*, and *avijjā* mutually support one another. *Taṇhā* leads to clinging, clinging strengthens *taṇhā* and leads to *bhava*, while craving and clinging sustain *avijjā*. Ignorance in turn creates conditions for craving and clinging.

Stage	What changes	Practical meaning
sotāpanna - stream-enterer	The first three fetters are cut: *sakkāya-diṭṭhi*, *vicikicchā*, and *sīlabbata-parāmāsa*.	The view that the self is identical with one or more of the five aggregates, possesses them, contains them, or is contained in them; doubt concerning the Buddha, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and the path of practice; clinging to rules, vows, and rituals.
sakadāgāmin - once-returner	The first three fetters are cut; sensual desire and ill will are noticeably weakened.	Reactions are still possible, but arise less often, are weaker, and to a lesser extent determine subsequent behavior.
anāgāmin - non-returner	The five lower fetters are cut, including *kāmacchanda* and *vyāpāda*.	Craving for sensual pleasures and the tendency toward aversion have completely ceased.

Stage	What changes	Practical meaning
arahant - fully liberated	All ten fetters are cut, including *rūparāga*, *arūparāga*, *māna*, *uddhacca*, and *avijjā*.	Craving, clinging to *rūpa* and *arūpa*, conceit, restlessness, and ignorance have ceased; experience is no longer appropriated as "I" and "mine."

Vicikicchā here refers to doubt concerning the liberating path, not to questions and investigation of the Dhamma. *Sīlabbata-parāmāsa* refers to clinging to rules and vows as a sufficient means of purification.

The first three fetters cannot be considered cut on the basis of judgments alone: "I do not believe in a permanent 'self'," "I believe in the Buddha," "I am European, what rites and rituals could I possibly have?" This is not enough.

In MN 64, the absence of an overt manifestation of a fetter does not mean that it has been finally removed. The corresponding underlying tendency (*anusaya*) may remain and manifest when suitable conditions arise. This is illustrated by the example of an infant: a fully formed identity view, doubt, sensual desire, or hostility does not yet arise in the infant, but the corresponding tendencies have not been removed.

The term *saṃyojana* describes a defilement as a condition that sustains clinging and further becoming. The term *anusaya* denotes an unremoved predisposition that may temporarily remain unmanifest. The terms are closely related but not fully interchangeable. AN 10.13 lists ten fetters, whereas AN 7.11 lists seven underlying tendencies. The temporary absence of desire, hostility, or doubt therefore does not yet mean freedom from them.

A *sotāpanna* is described as one in whom the first three fetters have been cut. In practical terms, this may be understood as a profound and irreversible undermining of the footing on which "I" is built in experience. *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* loses its power: the *khandhā* are no longer taken in the same naive way as "I," "mine," or "this is what I am."

Avijjā, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *māna* arise through conditions, but can be recognized and cease without being developed further. After complete liberation, the conditioned processes of the five *khandhā* continue to arise through conditions, but are not appropriated as "I" and "mine."

What Ceases in an Arahant

The cessation of *dukkha* in an arahant does not mean the disappearance of the body, sense faculties, contact, and feeling. As long as the arahant's life continues, the five *khandhā* continue to function: seeing, hearing, bodily sensations, and pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā* can arise. There may be bodily pain, fatigue, hunger, illness, and aging.

Practically, this can be expressed as removing "I" from all processes: body, feeling, recognition, *saṅkhārā*, consciousness, and contacts continue to arise through conditions, but are no longer appropriated as "I" and "mine." An arahant may therefore experience the first arrow, for example bodily pain, but the second does not arise: mental suffering constructed from craving, resistance, fear, resentment, and conceit.

After the realization of arahantship, new *taṇhā* is no longer kindled, while the remaining craving gradually exhausts itself.

An arahant need not appear outwardly unusual, omniscient, blissful, emotionless, or endowed with magical powers. Liberation is not determined by status, way of life, or miracles. What matters is the cessation of *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *māna*, and *bhava*.

No.	*Saṃyojana*	Meaning
1	*sakkāya-diṭṭhi*	identity view based on the five aggregates
2	*vicikicchā*	doubt concerning the Buddha, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and the path.
3	*sīlabbata-parāmāsa*	clinging to rules, vows, and rituals.
4	*kāmacchanda*	sensual desire, attraction to sensual pleasures.
5	*vyāpāda*	ill will, hostility, rejection.
6	*rūparāga*	desire for subtle-material existence, clinging to *rūpa* levels.
7	*arūparāga*	desire for formless existence, clinging to *arūpa* levels.
8	*māna*	conceit, comparison, the subtle "I am."
9	*uddhacca*	restlessness, subtle instability of mind.
10	*avijjā*	ignorance of the four *ariyasacca* and the conditioned arising of *dukkha*.

Conceit (*māna*)

It is useful to distinguish *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* from *māna*. *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* is the view that body, feeling, recognition, formations, or consciousness are "self," belong to a self, are within a self, or contain a self. *Māna* is subtler: it is the habit of centering experience around "I am," "I experience," "I understood," "I am superior," "I am inferior," or "I am equal." One might put it this way: after a flower is removed, its fragrance remains for a time. In the same way, after a coarse view of self has weakened, a subtle trace of "I am" may remain.

In SN 22.89, Khemaka uses a closely related comparison: the residual "I am" is like the scent of a flower, which cannot be attributed separately to its petals, color, or pollen.

In SN 22.49, three directions of comparison are distinguished: "I am superior," "I am equal," and "I am inferior."

In practice, comparison can be very subtle. It appears not only in comparison with others, but also with oneself in the past: "I am doing better," "today is worse," "I have progressed," "they can do it, but I cannot." The same mechanism operates in comparisons of methods, teachers, groups, understanding, or results of practice.

Māna can also manifest through reactions to praise, criticism, and recognition, as well as through assertions such as "I can do it," "I can do everything myself," and similar forms. What matters is not the words "I" and "mine" themselves, but comparison, appropriation, and self-assertion.

In MN 22, the Buddha compares the Dhamma to a raft: the raft is needed for crossing over, not to be carried on one's head after the crossing. In the same discourse, grasping the Dhamma wrongly is compared to seizing a snake by the wrong end. If the teaching is taken up for argument, status, self-assertion, or views, it may cause harm instead of liberation.

Even *sati*, *samādhi*, the *jhānas*, wisdom, and "my path" can become new objects of *upādāna* if an identity forms around them.

In practice, this scheme should be used not to claim stages for oneself or assign them to others, but to check the direction: are identity views, doubt, clinging, sensual craving, ill will, conceit, and ignorance becoming weaker? These criteria are qualitative. Another person's stage cannot be determined infallibly from outward signs, isolated experiences, or declarations. Such an assessment requires the corresponding direct knowledge possessed by the Buddha and some arahants. Statements such as "I am definitely a *sotāpanna*" are not a reliable criterion of attainment and may feed *māna* and *upādāna*, and may indicate clinging to views.

5. The Four *ariyasacca*: Tasks, Not Merely Propositions

The Four Noble Truths matter not merely as propositions, but as practical tasks. In the Pali version of SN 56.11, the knowledge-and-vision of each truth unfolds in three rounds: knowledge of the truth, knowledge of the task appropriate to it, and knowledge that the task has been completed. Together these make twelve aspects.

Truth	What is to be recognized	Task
dukkha ariyasacca	Conditioned experience is unreliable and does not provide final satisfaction.	*pariññeyya* - to be fully understood.
samudaya ariyasacca	*Dukkha* is sustained by *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna*; *taṇhā* is the fuel for further clinging and becoming.	*pahātabba* - to be abandoned.
nirodha ariyasacca	Clinging is absent, *taṇhā* has faded away, and *avijjā* has been fully recognized.	*sacchikātabba* - to be realized.
magga ariyasacca	There is a path of practice leading to cessation.	*bhāvetabba* - to be practiced and realized.

Three Kinds of *dukkha*

It is useful to distinguish three aspects of *dukkha*.

- ***Dukkha-dukkhatā*** - evident painfulness: bodily pain, mental pain, grief, sorrow, dejection, and despair.
- ***Vipariṇāma-dukkhatā*** - the unsatisfactoriness of change. Even a pleasant feeling is not a reliable support: it changes, disappears, and, when clung to, becomes a cause of suffering.
- ***Saṅkhāra-dukkhatā*** - the unreliability of all that is conditioned. Everything composite depends on conditions, is not under full control, and is subject to change and dissolution; it therefore cannot be a final support.

Dukkha is not limited to pain. Pain is its coarsest layer. Deeper lie the unsatisfactoriness of change and the very unreliability of conditioned processes.

Countless Births

In SN 15.3, the Buddha says that over countless births, more tears have been shed than there is water in the four great oceans.

In SN 15.10, it is said that the bones collected from many births over one aeon would form a heap as large as Mount Vepulla.

A practical formula:

- *dukkha* is to be seen so clearly that one stops seeking a final support in anything conditioned;
- *taṇhā* is to be recognized as it arises, rather than noticed only in retrospect;
- *nirodha* is to be tested as the actual cessation of craving and clinging;
- *magga* is to be developed through body, speech, livelihood, attention, and collectedness.

6. *Magga*: the Path as an Integrated Training

The path is not reducible to meditation, philosophy, reading suttas, or special experiences. It is integrated: view shapes intention; intention purifies speech and action; ethics supports freedom from remorse; freedom from remorse facilitates joy, tranquility, and collectedness; and a collected mind becomes fit for knowledge-and-vision. This is well reflected in AN 11.2: wholesome qualities do not operate as isolated components, but support one another as a chain of conditions.

Dhp 19–20 emphasizes that it is better to know a little and live in accordance with the Dhamma than to know many texts without putting them into practice.

It is useful to review *sīla* regularly: speech, actions, livelihood, and one's observance of the precepts. Such review is needed not to generate guilt, but to recognize mistakes clearly, adjust conditions, and refine the practice.

The word *sammā* in the Eightfold Path is usually translated as "right." Here it is not a badge of group membership or a moral label. "Right" means what leads to the cessation of *dukkha*, weakens *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, does not sustain clinging to "I," and accords with the four *ariyasacca*.

The path is called eightfold for a reason: all eight factors support one another. Omitting one factor, or substituting something else for it, compromises the integrity and effectiveness of the training.

The column "Wrong Approaches" lists only a few typical errors, not every possible deviation. Standard definitions of the eight path factors are given in SN 45.8.

Further examples of wrong directions can be found in the suttas: DN 1 examines numerous speculative views; MN 19 distinguishes intentions of sensuality, ill will, and harmfulness from their wholesome opposites; MN 41 lists unwholesome forms of conduct by body, speech, and mind; MN 117 contrasts wrong and right view, intention, speech, action, and livelihood; and AN 5.177 names five kinds of trade a lay follower should avoid.

DN 1 also shows the conditioned nature of views. Memory, reasoning, and meditative experiences themselves arise from conditions. If contact, feeling, craving, and clinging are not recognized, such experience easily becomes a basis for views about the self and the world.

The Eight Factors of the Path

Factor	What *sammā* means	Wrong approaches
sammā-diṭṭhi - right view	Seeing *dukkha*, its arising, its cessation, and the path; understanding *kamma*, *paṭiccasamuppāda*, impermanence, and the impersonal nature of the *khandhā*.	A view of an eternal self, an observing soul, or pure consciousness as an essence; the nihilistic claim "there is no one, so nothing matters"; clinging to an opinion as proof that "I am right."
sammā-saṅkappa - right intention	The intention of renunciation, non-ill-will, and harmlessness; directing the mind toward relinquishment rather than acquisition.	Plans for sensual gratification, revenge, self-assertion, or the suppression of oneself or others; spiritual ambition.
sammā-vācā - right speech	Abstaining from false, divisive, harsh, and idle speech; speech that is timely, truthful, beneficial, and does not nourish *dosa*.	Sarcasm, gossip, pressure, argument for the sake of self-assertion, "truth" used as a weapon, and spiritual labels used to demean.
sammā-kammanta - right action	Bodily actions that do not harm: abstaining from killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct; within a broader ethical foundation, also abstaining from intoxicants; care for living beings.	Harm justified by utility, goals, practice, or emotion; indulgence of impulses; ascetic violence toward the body.
sammā-ājīva - right livelihood	A way of earning a living that is not built on harm, deceit, exploitation, or the intensification of defilements.	Income obtained through violence or deception, by exploiting people's dependence, or by manipulating fear, craving, or spiritual authority.
sammā-vāyāma - right effort	The four efforts: preventing unwholesome states from arising, abandoning arisen unwholesome states, developing wholesome states, and maintaining arisen wholesome states.	Laziness and distraction, but also violence toward oneself, suppressing desires without understanding, and harsh, joyless overexertion.
sammā-sati - right recollection	Recollection of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā* as processes that arise and cease; *satipaṭṭhāna*.	A dissociated observer, a mechanical "came and went," or abiding in *moha* instead of clearly discerning processes.
sammā-samādhi - right collectedness	Collectedness free from the hindrances and supportive of wisdom; in the standard formula, the four *jhānas*.	Pursuing states; intoxication with calm, *moha-samādhi*, pride in attainments, craving for unusual states, and mistaking experiences for liberation.

In AN 4.162, the Buddha explains that practice may be pleasant or difficult, and realization may be quick or slow.

It is not enough merely to feel that one is moving forward: in a forest, one may be certain one is walking toward the way out while still going in circles. Moreover, as long as the mind remains defiled, a person is not always able to assess their own position correctly. The direction of practice therefore cannot be checked by a single inner impression. One must compare one's practice with the Buddha's instructions, observe its effects in behavior and the state of mind, and, when necessary, seek guidance from experienced and trustworthy practitioners. What matters is lasting change over time: are craving, hostility, and ignorance weakening, and are the factors of the path developing?

Right Intention Before an Action

Right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*) directs the mind toward renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness. It does not guarantee that craving, hostility, or fear will disappear immediately. The task is to establish a direction in advance to which one can return when the mind begins to lose clarity.

In MN 21, the Buddha instructs one not to allow the mind to become defiled even in the face of insults. Harsh speech can condition irritation, but it is important to recognize ill will when it arises and not sustain it.

Mettā is not "I wish someone well," but a quality of mind characterized by goodwill, without hostility or appropriation. This does not mean silently enduring insults, but acting without defilement while clearly seeing what is happening.

An intention is not a promise that all subsequent events will be fully under control. Another person may behave harshly, the situation may prove more difficult than expected, and recollection may be lost. Practice consists in noticing the direction of the mind again and returning to the intention.

In MN 61, an action is to be examined three times: before it, during it, and after it. Before acting, one may ask:

- Will this lead to harm for me?
- Will this lead to harm for another?
- Will this lead to harm for both of us?

The same question is asked during the action. Afterward, the actual consequences are assessed. If actions of body, speech, or mind have caused harm, this is to be acknowledged, examined, and not repeated.

In MN 19, thoughts are divided into two directions: sensuality, ill will, and harmfulness on one side; renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness on the other. What the mind frequently returns to gradually becomes its habitual inclination. Right intention must therefore not only be understood, but restored again and again.

The test is whether speech and action are changing, and how they affect the mind.

Sammā-vāyāma: Right Effort in More Detail

Sammā-vāyāma is not a tense struggle against oneself, but the wise shaping of conditions. The classical formula is: prevent unwholesome states from arising, abandon unwholesome states that have arisen, develop wholesome states that have not yet arisen, and maintain wholesome states that have arisen.

In SN 4.4, the path is compressed into two conditions: directing attention wisely and applying effort rightly. This does not replace the Eightfold Path, but reveals its heart.

MN 2 shows that the taints (*āsavā*) are abandoned in different ways: by seeing, restraining, using wisely, enduring, avoiding, removing, and developing. This is an important clue: not every problem should be addressed with the same technique. Sometimes an erroneous view must be seen; sometimes the senses restrained; sometimes an unpleasant feeling endured; sometimes a harmful situation avoided; sometimes an unwholesome thought removed; and sometimes factors of the path developed.

MN 20 gives a practical sequence for working with unwholesome thoughts. If the mind is seized by sensual desire, ill will, or cruelty, one may direct attention to another wholesome object; see the danger and cost of the thought; stop feeding it with attention; examine how it is constructed and calm its formation; and, if the mind remains strongly seized, restrain it firmly. It is better to begin with the gentler methods. Harsher restraint is appropriate as a last resort.

The practical test of right effort is simple: afterward there should be less *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, less inward violence, and more clarity. If effort makes the mind proud, constricted, angry, or dry, the approach should be reconsidered.

Sadness of Renunciation

In MN 44, aspiration toward unsurpassed liberation may be accompanied by *domanassa*: the direction of liberation is seen, and at the same time it is seen that liberation has not yet been realized. Such sadness is unpleasant, but the latent tendency to *paṭigha* does not lie within it.

seeing conditionality → aspiration toward liberation → "not yet liberated" → *domanassa*.

In MN 137, the movement continues:

worldly sadness → sadness of renunciation → joy of renunciation → equanimity of renunciation.

A coarser state is abandoned through a subtler one, and then that subtler state is abandoned as well.

The Three Trainings

1. *sīla* - ethics. It reduces the coarse *dukkha* created through body and speech.
2. *samādhi* - collectedness. It weakens the hindrances and makes the mind fit for seeing subtle processes.
3. *paññā* - wisdom. It sees *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*, and *paṭiccasamuppāda*, and ends clinging.

A Brief Path Check

Before acting, one may ask:

- Does this strengthen *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, or weaken them?
- Does this make the mind clearer or more clouded?
- Does this create a story about "I" and "mine," or release it?
- Does this lead toward simplicity or needless complication?

7. The Five Precepts: *sīla* as Training in Wisdom

The five precepts (*pañca-sīla*) are better understood not as external commandments or reasons for guilt, but as training rules (*sikkhāpada*). They help reveal which actions of body, speech, and mind lead to less harm, greater clarity, and freedom from remorse, and which nourish *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*.

In this sense, *sīla* is not separate from wisdom. Ethical conduct cultivates the ability to distinguish the wholesome from the unwholesome. One may know a great deal and still fail to see harm, falsehood, appropriation, violence, and carelessness. In the Dhamma, wisdom is tested not only by knowledge, but also by one's actions.

Ethical conduct itself can also become an object of clinging. If practice is built around "I am ethical," "I am pure," "I am right," or "I am better than those who do not live this way," wholesome conduct begins to support *māna* and *bhava*.

Precept	Practical meaning	Quality disclosed
Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi	Abstaining from killing and intentionally causing harm.	*ahiṃsā*, *mettā*
Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi	Not taking what has not been given voluntarily.	*santuṭṭhi*
Kāmesu micchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi	Not causing harm through sensual and sexual conduct.	*brahmacariya*, *anurakkhā*
Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi	Abstaining from falsehood and harmful speech.	*sacca*
Surā-meraya-majja-pamāda-ṭṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi	Abstaining from intoxicating substances and causes of heedlessness.	*appamāda*

Not a Commandment, but a Training Rule

A *sikkhāpada* is a rule of training. It does not say, "be perfect right now." It indicates a direction: train conduct of body, speech, and mind that reduces harm and supports the path.

When a precept has been broken, practice does not consist in self-condemnation. It is more useful to see honestly: what condition was present, what intention stood behind the action, what the consequences were, how it affected the mind, what can be repaired, and how recurrence can be prevented.

What to Support and What to Avoid

Unwholesome deeds are intentional actions of body, speech, and mind rooted in craving, ignorance, or clinging. They cause harm and sustain suffering.

Wholesome deeds are intentional actions of body, speech, and mind that do not cause harm and contribute to the lessening of suffering. They are rooted in the absence of greed, hatred, and delusion (*alobha*, *adosa*, *amoha*).

The outward appearance of an action does not always reveal its cause. One should examine the intention that arose, any craving or clinging that was present, and the consequences.

In DN 21, the Buddha examines three areas of practice:

- bodily conduct - *kāyasamācāra*;
- verbal conduct - *vacīsamācāra*;
- seeking and striving - *pariyesanā*.

The criterion is the same in each case. What, when sustained, causes unwholesome qualities to increase and wholesome qualities to decrease should not be sustained. What, when sustained, causes unwholesome qualities to decrease and wholesome qualities to increase should be sustained.

Hiri and *ottappa*: Refraining from the Unwholesome

Hiri is moral conscience, through which an unwholesome act is seen as unworthy and incompatible with the training. *Ottappa* is caution regarding the harm that such an act may cause oneself and others. These qualities are needed to notice a dangerous direction before it becomes speech or action. In AN 7.65, they are named as conditions for guarding the senses, ethical conduct, and the path.

Joy Without Remorse

The suttas say of the Dhamma that it is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end.

When precepts are kept not out of fear or guilt, and not for the image of "I am a good person," they support freedom from remorse. Joy may gradually arise from the reduction of defilements, falsehood, harshness, and heedlessness.

The path leads to a reduction of *dukkha*, although as practice develops it may seem that there is more *dukkha*: defilements, craving, and habitual patterns that previously remained in the background become more noticeable. Yet the overall trend of healthy practice is less craving and *dukkha*, and greater clarity.

1. Not Causing Harm: *ahiṃsā* and *mettā*

The canonical formula of the first precept concerns intentionally depriving a living being of life. Refraining from cruelty in speech, thought, and one's attitude toward oneself is a broader practical development of *adosa* and *mettā*; however, not every arising of anger or a harsh thought is technically a breach of the first precept.

The first precept concerns more than physical killing. Its broader meaning is not to make violence an instrument for solving problems. Violence may be expressed through body, speech, thought, one's treatment of others, and one's treatment of oneself.

A middle way is needed here between indulgence and self-aggression. Indulgence says, "because I want it, I may do it." Self-aggression says, "I am bad; I must break myself." The impulse should be seen and not fed, without hatred of oneself.

Ahiṃsā is non-harming. *Mettā* is a quality of *citta* marked by goodwill, in which there is no hostility, aversion, or intention to cause harm. It is not the personal stance "I wish another person well," but a conditioned coloration of mind.

2. Not Taking What Is Not Given: *santuṭṭhi*

The second precept is not limited to obvious theft. It concerns everything the mind wants to appropriate without explicit permission: objects, money, time, attention, another person's

labor, ideas, credit, or trust.

A subtler violation begins with the thought: "this is not mine, but it ought to be mine." Here *lobha* and the construction of "mine" can be seen. *Santuṭṭhi* is contentment, non-acquisitiveness, and freedom from appropriation.

A separate and subtle subject is the "theft of Dhamma": using the language, ideas, or authority of the Dhamma for status, influence, gain, or a self-image. The issue here is not copyright, but using what is sacred to feed *māna* and *bhava*.

3. Sensual and Sexual Conduct: *brahmacariya* and *anurakkhā*

For a layperson, the third precept usually means abstaining from sexual conduct that causes harm: infidelity, deception, coercion, exploitation, betrayal, using another person merely as an object for one's own pleasure, or taking advantage of weakness or lack of awareness.

In the strict sense, *brahmacariya* means celibacy or abstinence. On the monastic path, this is complete abstention from sexual conduct. For a layperson, honesty, fidelity, care, respect for boundaries, and harmlessness are important. It is therefore useful to place alongside it the word *anurakkhā*: care, protection of trust, and attentiveness in relationships.

4. Speech: *sacca*

The fourth precept is usually formulated as abstaining from falsehood, but it is useful to view speech more broadly: false speech, divisive speech, harsh speech, and idle chatter.

Falsehood is dangerous not only because it may harm someone. It damages wisdom by separating the mind from reality. Lying to others often begins with lying to oneself: excuses, rationalization, emotional reasoning, "it was not my fault," "I was forced," or "it was for the greater good."

Sacca is truthfulness. But truthfulness is not a license for harshness. Speech is examined not only for factual accuracy, but also for intention, timeliness, benefit, and harmlessness.

5. Sobriety: *appamāda*

The canonical formula names *surā*, *meraya*, and *majja* as a basis for *pamāda*. Applying this principle to modern drugs, psychedelics, and microdosing is an expanded practical interpretation.

The fifth precept concerns intoxicating substances and everything that becomes a basis for *pamāda*: heedlessness, distraction, and loss of vigilance. The classical formula refers primarily to substances: *surā*, *meraya*, and *majja*. In practical terms, this includes alcohol, drugs, psychedelics, and other psychoactive substances capable of causing intoxication, stupefaction, loss of control, or a noticeable impairment of clarity.

An important criterion is this: if a substance, at a plausible dose, is capable of causing intoxication or stupefaction, it falls within the scope of this precept. "Microdosing" therefore does not make a substance permissible: the precept concerns not only whether strong intoxication has occurred on a particular occasion, but also the intentional use of a substance that is a basis for *pamāda*. At small doses, intoxication may go unnoticed.

A complete breach can usually be analyzed as follows:

1. an intoxicating substance is present;
2. the person knows or understands what it is;
3. there is an intention to consume it;
4. an action is performed in order to consume it;

5. the substance enters the body;
6. there is no extreme medical necessity in which no reasonable alternative is available.

The medical exception concerns situations in which the substance is used as medicine, no better alternative is available, and refusal could cause serious harm. It is not a justification for seeking experiences, spiritual states, relaxation, or experiments with consciousness.

The point is to maintain clarity. When the mind is clouded, it becomes easier to lie, cause harm, take what is not given, or yield to sensual desire. It also obstructs meditation: *sati* becomes weaker, *samādhi* coarser, and *paññā* is more easily replaced by impressions. Unusual states or insights may sometimes occur under the influence of substances, but they are likely to be chaotic, overvalued, and not conducive to liberation.

Appamāda is sobriety, conscientiousness, attentiveness, and care. This quality guards the entire practice.

Fact and Narrative

The precepts help distinguish a fact from the story by which an action is justified.

- Fact: "I said something untrue." Narrative: "I had no choice; I was forced."
- Fact: "I took what was not given to me." Narrative: "They already have plenty."
- Fact: "I spoke harshly." Narrative: "At least I was honest."
- Fact: "I sought pleasure without considering the consequences." Narrative: "I felt bad" or "That was how I felt."

In this way, *sīla* becomes a practice of recognizing the conditions of action: under *avijjā*, the situation is seen in a distorted way, while *taṇhā* sustains the urge that has arisen.

How Unwholesome Deeds Arise

Unwholesome deeds arise from causes and conditions. They are rooted in ignorance, craving, aversion, and clinging, which can manifest in various combinations. Contact, feelings, perceptions, and underlying tendencies become conditions for the arising of intention, and intention becomes a condition for action of body, speech, or mind.

For example, criticism gives rise to an unpleasant feeling. Craving to be rid of it and clinging to being right can lead to harsh speech or deception. But when these processes are recognized and not sustained, the unwholesome intention can cease.

Observing the precepts reduces *dukkha* and helps develop wisdom by revealing the causes of unwholesome deeds. Yet if *bhava* is built upon this, such as "I am virtuous" or "I am better than others," the precepts become a support for new clinging and obstruct liberation.

Protecting Lay Life

In DN 31, advice to a layperson is not limited to the five precepts. The sutta lists six harmful habits: intoxication, roaming at inappropriate times, absorption in entertainments, gambling, unwholesome companionship, and laziness.

The sutta proposes looking not at the label "good person" or "bad person," but at the processes manifesting in relationships: intentions, tendencies, and deeds. A false friend takes, flatters, makes empty promises, or accompanies one in wastefulness. A true friend helps, does not abandon one in trouble, restrains one from the unwholesome, encourages the wholesome, and shows compassion.

Yet these qualities too are impermanent. When causes and conditions change, even a good friend can begin to cause harm. Clinging to an old image of the person obstructs seeing what

is happening as it is and becomes a cause of *dukkha*.

A Short Daily Review

At the end of the day, one can return to several situations in which defilements arose:

1. What happened, and what feeling arose?
2. Where did craving, aversion, or clinging manifest?
3. What intentions, words, or actions followed? Did they cause harm?
4. Under what conditions did the unwholesome arise, and what helped prevent it from being sustained?
5. What should be changed next time to reduce harm and strengthen the wholesome?

The task is to see the causes and consequences of actions and understand how not to sustain the unwholesome.

8. The Five *khandhā* and the Three Characteristics

The five *khandhā* are not "components of a real self," but groups of processes on the basis of which appropriation as "I" and "mine" arises.

Khandha	What it includes	How clinging arises
rūpa	body, material form, elements	"my body," "I am beautiful," "I am ill," "I must control the body"
vedanā	pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral tone	"I feel good," "I feel bad," "I want this feeling"
saññā	perception and recognition: in a coarse form, distinguishing, recognizing, and identifying an object; in a subtle form (*sukhuma-saññā*), the very definiteness of what is perceived, even before awareness and recognition	coarse: distinguishing a color, recognizing features; subtle: perceiving the character of what is present without identifying it
saṅkhārā	intentions and impulses involved in shaping experience and action	"I decided," "this is what I am like," "this is my character"
viññāṇa	consciousness, awareness of an object	"I am aware," "I am the observer," "I am pure consciousness"

In MN 43, feeling, recognition, and consciousness are said to be conjoined rather than separate.

The five *khandhā* encompass the entire field of conditioned experience. Everything taken to be "I" or "mine" pertains to body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness.

The formula "this is not mine, I am not this, this is not my *attā*" does not mean that another "I" is hidden beyond the five aggregates. In MN 109, a bhikkhu falls into precisely this confusion: if the five aggregates are "not self," then what "self" will be affected by actions performed

by what is "not self"? The Buddha calls him *moghapurisa*, a fool who is ignorant and under the sway of craving. In SN 35.23, "the all" is described through the six sense fields and their objects; one who asserts some other "all" would be unable to give a coherent account if questioned about it. The search for an "I" beyond experience is conditioned by *bhava-taṇhā*.

Conventional designations such as "man," "woman," "parent," or "teacher" are not in themselves the problem. Clinging arises when a designation is appropriated as "I" or becomes a basis for comparison. In SN 5.2, Somā rejects the idea that being a woman obstructs liberation.

Why the Five *khandhā* Are Needed When There Is *paṭiccasamuppāda*

The five *khandhā* and *paṭiccasamuppāda* answer different questions. *Paṭiccasamuppāda* shows how *dukkha* arises and ceases through conditions. The five aggregates show what can be appropriated as "I" and "mine."

The *khandhā* are therefore especially important for seeing *anattā*. They are not five parts that make up a real subject, but five processes that, under *upādāna*, become a field of appropriation. The chain shows how suffering is constructed; the aggregates show the material from which the sense of "me" is constructed.

The five *khandhā* and the twelve sense fields describe the same experience from different angles. The *āyatana* show through which door contact occurs: the eye and the visible, the ear and sound, all the way to mind and *dhammā*. The *khandhā* show the composition of the experience that has arisen: *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa*.

For example, when an apple is seen, the eye and visible form belong to *rūpa*; the arising visual consciousness, to *viññāṇa*; the pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral tone, to *vedanā*; recognition of "an apple," to *saññā*; and the intention to take it, eat it, or walk past, to *saṅkhārā*.

These are two different ways of describing the same event: in the system of *āyatana*, it is examined through the six internal and six external sense fields; in the system of *khandhā*, through the five aggregates.

The three characteristics, *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*, should not be turned into verbal formulas. They are to become a way of seeing.

- *anicca*: what has arisen changes, cannot be held, and disintegrates.
- *dukkha*: what changes and is not subject to control cannot be a final support.
- *anattā*: there is no independent, permanent, governing, controlling self in this.

It is not necessary to encompass all three characteristics at the same time. One process may be disclosed deeply through *anicca*, another through *dukkha* or *anattā*. As seeing deepens, the other aspects of what is occurring also become clearer.

On the path, both the three characteristics and *paṭiccasamuppāda* must be disclosed directly. What matters is not listing characteristics, but the depth of seeing how a process arises through conditions, changes, fades, and does not belong to a separate "I."

Anicca, *dukkha*, and *anattā* reveal themselves differently under different conditions, which makes them more difficult to see.

Anattā should not be turned into the statement "there is no me." Nor should it be confused with depersonalization or derealization, which may involve detachment, emotional numbness, a sense of observing oneself from outside, or a sense that events are unreal. Such states are not in themselves wisdom and are not criteria of liberation.

The practical meaning of *anattā* is to see conditioned processes without appropriation: "this is not mine, this I am not, this is not my essence." The criterion is not how unusual an experience feels, but the weakening of *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, hostility, and conceit. If a sense of unreality becomes persistent, frightening, or disruptive to ordinary life, professional help is needed rather than an attempt to deepen the state through meditation.

9. *Paṭiccasamuppāda*: the Mechanism of *dukkha*

Paṭiccasamuppāda is dependent origination: when conditions are present, a result arises; with the cessation of the conditions, the corresponding result ceases. It is neither merely a theory of rebirth nor merely a psychology of the present moment, but a way of seeing how *dukkha* is constructed when *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna* are present.

In practice, *paṭiccasamuppāda* is needed not as a philosophical map of the world, but to see which conditions sustain the chain and with the cessation of which conditions it opens.

In MN 28 it is said: one who sees *paṭiccasamuppāda* sees the Dhamma; one who sees the Dhamma sees *paṭiccasamuppāda*. In SN 22.87, the Buddha says: "One who sees the Dhamma sees me."

Conditions of *dukkha*

The standard formula identifies specific conditions through which *dukkha* arises and continues, and shows the cessation of the process when those conditions cease.

Beginning the sequence with *avijjā* does not make ignorance first in time. AN 10.61 says that no beginning of it can be discerned, but the conditions that nourish it can be recognized.

Avijjā is not limited to the first link of the formula. Until it is recognized, it permeates the entire saṃsāric process: with it, *saṅkhārā* are formed, seeing of contact and feeling is distorted, *taṇhā* is renewed, and *upādāna* and *bhava* are sustained.

Saṃsāra is a self-sustaining process in which *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava* repeatedly create conditions for birth, aging, and death.

The standard chain:

1. *avijjā* - ignorance.
2. *saṅkhārā* - formative activities.
3. *viññāṇa* - consciousness.
4. *nāma-rūpa* - name-and-form.
5. *saḷāyatana* - the six sense fields.
6. *phassa* - contact.
7. *vedanā* - feeling.
8. *taṇhā* - craving.
9. *upādāna* - clinging.
10. *bhava* - becoming; sensual, form, and formless becoming are distinguished.
11. *jāti* - birth: the appearance of a being, the arising of the aggregates, and the acquisition of sense fields.
12. *jarāmaraṇa* - aging-and-death, together with sorrow, pain, dejection, and despair.

$$\begin{aligned} &\textit{avijjā} \rightarrow \textit{saṅkhārā} \rightarrow \textit{viññāṇa} \rightleftarrows \textit{nāma-rūpa} \rightarrow \textit{saḷāyatana} \rightarrow \textit{phassa} \\ &\quad \rightarrow \textit{vedanā} \rightarrow \textit{taṇhā} \rightarrow \textit{upādāna} \rightarrow \textit{bhava} \rightarrow \textit{jāti} \rightarrow \textit{jarāmaraṇa} \end{aligned}$$

In the twelve-link chain, the craving in question is sensual craving. In a broader sense, *taṇhā*,

together with ignorance, sustains *saṃsāra*.

Dependent arising is not limited to a linear sequence of twelve links. The processes are mutually dependent: craving and clinging can strengthen ignorance, while previous formations create conditions for renewed craving and becoming (*bhava*).

Mutual Conditionality Within the Chain

The twelve-link chain shows how some processes condition others. At the same time, some links condition one another.

In DN 15 and SN 12.67, *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa* are presented as mutually conditioning processes. In SN 12.67, they are compared to two sheaves of reeds that stand by supporting one another:

$$viññāṇa \rightleftarrows nāma\text{-}rūpa.$$

Sensual experience itself is not a defilement. *Vedanā* arises through conditions; when craving is present, *upādāna* may arise: what is happening is held on to and appropriated.

Lobha, *dosa*, and *moha* are unwholesome reactions and colorations of mind. The deeper mechanism of *saṃsāra* consists of *upādāna*, *taṇhā*, and *avijjā*.

Upādāna should not be understood merely as stronger craving. In SN 12.2, craving is analyzed through the six sense fields, while clinging is analyzed through four domains: sensuality, views, rules and observances, and doctrines of self.

In practice, *upādāna* can be recognized when a pleasure, opinion, or rule is held and appropriated as "mine," while an idea of oneself is appropriated as "I."

In practice, *bhava* and *jāti* can be distinguished in this way: *bhava* is a mode of existence that unfolds on the basis of clinging; *jāti* is the particular "I" that arises within this mode of existence.

For example:

- *taṇhā*: approval is wanted, and criticism is not wanted;
- *upādāna*: "approval is necessary," "criticism is unacceptable";
- *bhava*: a mode of defense unfolds - attention, thoughts, and actions become organized around justifying oneself and warding off criticism;
- *jāti*: within this mode, a particular "I" arises - "I am the one who is not respected," "I am offended," "I must defend myself."

The Four Kinds of Nutriment (*āhāra*)

SN 12.11, SN 12.12, and SN 12.64 name four kinds of nutriment sustaining existence and renewed arising:

- physical food (*kabaḷīkārāhāra*);
- contact (*phassāhāra*);
- mental volition (*manosañcetanāhāra*);
- consciousness (*viññāṇāhāra*).

As long as craving for the five *khandhā* remains, consciousness finds a support and sustains new *bhava*. When craving ceases, consciousness loses that support, and new becoming ceases.

In SN 12.12, the Buddha rejects the question "who feeds on consciousness?" Consciousness is not food for a separate "I," but a condition for future becoming.

Wholesome *saṅkhārā* as Supports for the Path

Unwholesome *saṅkhārā* directly nourish *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, and *dukkha*. This does not mean that every formation is simply "bad." There are wholesome intentions, wholesome deeds, ethical conduct, generosity, recollection, collectedness, and wise attention. They create conditions under which coarse reactions and remorse weaken, while what is happening is seen more clearly.

Yet even the wholesome can become an object of appropriation: "I am good," "I practice," "I attained," "I will accumulate merit," or "this is my state." Wholesome qualities should therefore be developed without clinging.

Viññāṇa, *nāma-rūpa*, and *phassa*

In SN 12.2, *nāma* includes feeling, recognition, intention, contact, and attention, while *rūpa* consists of the four elements and the material form dependent on them.

In DN 15, two kinds of contact are distinguished:

- *paṭigha-samphassa* - contact through the physical impact of *rūpa*. For example, hardness directly impinges through the bodily sense field;
- *adhivacana-samphassa* - contact through distinction and designation. Through *nāma*, what is physical is recognized not merely as an impact, but as a particular object, for example, a "table."

Thus *rūpa* makes physical impact possible, while *nāma* makes it possible to distinguish and designate that with which contact occurs. Without *rūpa*, *paṭigha-samphassa* would be impossible; without *nāma*, what is physical would not be discerned as a recognized and designated object.

Also named are *ākāra*, *liṅga*, *nimitta*, and *uddesa* - manifestations, characteristics, signs, and ways of indicating, through which *nāma* and *rūpa* can be distinguished. In other words, each kind of contact is possible only where there are distinguishable signs by which the corresponding side of *nāma-rūpa* can be discerned.

Viññāṇa, the Six Sense Fields, and Contact

In dependent origination, *viññāṇa* should not be considered in isolation, but as part of a complex of interdependent processes. In SN 12.2, *viññāṇa* is analyzed into six classes of consciousness:

1. eye consciousness;
2. ear consciousness;
3. nose consciousness;
4. tongue consciousness;
5. body consciousness;
6. mind consciousness.

In concrete sensory experience, consciousness manifests through the corresponding sense field when an object is present. In MN 148, for example, eye consciousness arises in dependence on the eye and visible form:

$$\text{eye} + \text{visible form} \rightarrow \text{eye consciousness}.$$

The meeting of the eye, visible form, and eye consciousness is called *phassa*, or contact. The same principle applies to the other sense doors.

The chain shows which processes condition other processes, while the account of the six sense fields shows how consciousness manifests in a concrete sensory experience.

One Sensory Episode in Close-Up

Dependent origination can be investigated directly within a single arising process.

For example, when a word is heard:

$$\text{ear} + \text{sound} \rightarrow \text{ear consciousness} \rightarrow \textit{phassa} \rightarrow \textit{vedanā}.$$

In MN 18, the further unfolding of the process is shown through perception, thinking, and conceptual proliferation:

$$\textit{phassa} \rightarrow \textit{vedanā} \rightarrow \textit{saññā} \rightarrow \textit{vitakka} \rightarrow \textit{papañca}.$$

Saññā is included in *nāma-rūpa* and may arise repeatedly over the course of experience. Each new act of recognition occurs within an already changed complex of *nāma-rūpa*, while subsequent experience in turn changes the conditions for later acts of recognition.

Once arisen, *taṇhā* becomes a condition for further experience. Together with it, the direction of attention changes: signs connected with craving are sought and held more often, stand out more strongly in *saññā*, and the next contact arises under already changed conditions.

$$\begin{aligned} \textit{phassa} &\rightarrow \textit{vedanā} \rightarrow \textit{taṇhā} \\ &\rightarrow \text{attention, searching, holding} \\ &\rightarrow \textit{saññā} \rightarrow \text{new conditions} \\ &\rightarrow \textit{phassa} \rightarrow \textit{vedanā}. \end{aligned}$$

Thus *taṇhā* not only arises within experience already formed, but also changes the conditions of subsequent experience. In MN 44, the arising of *sakkāya*, defined through the five *upādānakkhandhā*, is linked to *taṇhā*.

The practical point is to recognize directly that a process arises and changes through conditions and contains no “I.”

In MN 38, the Buddha rejects the view that one and the same consciousness wanders through the round of rebirths. Consciousness arises dependently and is named after the condition on which it arises: with the eye and forms, visual consciousness; with the ear and sounds, auditory consciousness; with the mind and mental objects, mental consciousness.

Tajjo samannāhāro in MN 28

MN 28 says that even when a sense faculty is unimpaired and an object has entered its range, the corresponding kind of consciousness does not manifest without *tajjo samannāhāro*. The phrase may be understood as "corresponding engagement" or "corresponding gathering." In context, it is probably connected with the engagement or direction of attention in relation to the particular object.

Manasikāra is included in *nāma* in SN 12.2 and means directing attention. The exact relationship between *manasikāra* and *tajjo samannāhāro* is not explained in the suttas, so there are no grounds either for identifying them with one another or, conversely, for treating them as two distinct processes.

One may suppose that, in experience, this is connected with the operation of *saṅkhārā* as a kind of filter: some details stand out while others pass unnoticed. For practice, however, it is more important to see the overall conditionality of the process than to determine the exact mechanism of this selection.

Separately, one can observe in experience a moment when an object is perceived and contact occurs, but the process does not unfold further into *vedanā*: no pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling arises, and the subsequent chain does not continue.

Two Scales of Reading

On the broader scale, *avijjā* and *saṅkhārā* sustain a stream that leads to new birth, aging, and death. This describes the continuation of *saṃsāra*.

In a practical analysis, the same mechanism can be noticed within an individual episode: contact conditions feeling; under ignorance, feeling becomes a support for craving, clinging, and a role such as "I am right," "I am offended," or "I must." This role arises, changes, dissolves, and brings *dukkha*.

An arisen state is not yet the same as *bhava*. A bodily illness may remain simply a bodily illness, anxiety simply anxiety, irritation simply irritation. Becoming becomes especially visible when an appropriated story is assembled and sustained around the state: "I am ill," "I am anxious," "I am offended," "this is what I am like."

The language of "becoming a role" and "the birth of an offended self" is a practical analogy. It helps reveal the direction of craving and clinging in present experience, but does not replace the primary meanings of *bhava* and *jāti*.

Even if craving or the notion of "I" has already arisen, it need not be sustained further. Clinging appropriates the experience, maintains the reaction associated with it, and creates conditions for the continuation of *bhava*.

Fear of Death

Fear of death is connected not only with the bodily response to danger, but also with appropriating processes as "I" and "mine": fear arises at the prospect of losing what is taken to be one's own existence. When this appropriation ceases, a bodily response to threat may still arise through conditions, but it does not continue as fear for "me."

Three Ways to Read the Chain

- **Direct reading:** shows how, in the presence of *avijjā*, one condition after another constructs *dukkha*.

- **Reverse diagnostic reading:** begins with already noticeable tension, resentment, fear, or dependence, and asks: what *bhava* is here? What is being clung to through *upādāna*? What *taṇhā* nourishes it? From what *vedanā* did it grow? What was the *phassa*?
- **Reading through cessation:** the chain is not broken by force. When a condition is recognized and not fed, the corresponding process loses its support. In a single episode, craving and clinging may cease; the complete cessation of *avijjā* is the ultimate horizon of the path.

A Liberating Chain of Conditions: from *dukkha* to *vimutti*

SN 12.23 presents not only a saṃsāric sequence but a liberating one. When *dukkha* is understood as the unreliability of the conditioned, it becomes an *upanisā*, a condition for turning toward the path.

Link	Practical meaning
dukkha	A sober recognition that conditioned experience is unreliable, not a reason for despair.
saddhā	Confidence: there is a path worth testing.
pamojja, *pīti*	Joy and energy arising from a wholesome direction.
passaddhi, *sukha*	Tranquility of body and mind, gentle stability.
samādhi	Collectedness capable of seeing subtle conditions.
yathābhūtañāṇadassana	Knowledge-and-vision of processes as conditioned, impermanent, unsatisfactory, and impersonal.
nibbidā	Cooling toward clinging through seeing the impermanence and cessation of conditioned processes and the *dukkha* of clinging.
virāga	Dispassion; the fading of coloration and extinguishing of *taṇhā* itself toward conditioned experience.
vimutti, *āsavakkhayañāṇa*	Liberation from clinging and craving; knowledge of the complete exhaustion of the *āsavā*.

In AN 11.2, the same logic is expressed through *sīla*: wholesome conduct leads to freedom from remorse (*avippaṭisāra*), then to joy, tranquility, *samādhi*, knowledge-and-vision, *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*. The path develops by cultivating supportive conditions, not by suppressing experience.

10. *Saṅkhārā*, *cetanā*, and *bhava*: Formation of Action and Becoming

Saṅkhārā are formations. Depending on context, they may be understood as formative factors that set conditions for subsequent experience, or as formative reactions arising within an already unfolding process. In dependent origination, arising conditioned by *avijjā*, they support the further unfolding of experience; the suttas distinguish bodily, verbal, and mental formations. As one of the five *khandhā*, the term points primarily to intentions (*cetanā*). In direct observation, *saṅkhārā* may appear as impulses, tendencies, and reactions.

Kamma literally means action, but in the Dhamma it primarily means intentional action. In AN 6.63, the Buddha says, “It is intention, bhikkhus, that I call *kamma*.” Having intended, one performs *kamma* through body, speech, and mind.

Kamma is not a general law of causation or a transferable "karmic force." It is intentional action. Its ripening and result (*vipāka*) should be distinguished from the action itself.

The involuntary arising of a thought is not yet identical with an intentional mental action. In practice, it is important to recognize *cetanā*: does an intention arise to support, develop, use, or enact the arisen thought? *Kamma* can be performed through body, speech, and mind.

Phassa, or contact, is identified as a source of *kamma*. Intention does not arise on its own, but in dependence on contact, *vedanā*, recognition, tendencies, and the state of mind. It is therefore important to recognize the conditions for the arising of *cetanā* before it is expressed in action.

The fruit of *kamma* should not be confused with all the consequences of a situation, which are produced by many conditions. An intentional action may bear fruit here and now, later in this life, or in subsequent lives. SN 36.21 rejects the view that every feeling one experiences is caused solely by past *kamma*, while MN 136 cautions against drawing straightforward conclusions from a single observable result.

The practical question is: what intention arose? What action of body, speech, or mind does it lead to, and does it sustain greed, aversion, delusion, or clinging?

Action, Fruit, and Causal Continuity

MN 135 says that beings inherit the consequences of their own actions. This should not be understood as a reference to a permanent owner, a soul, or a separate storehouse of *kamma*. The point is causality: intentional actions enter into a sequence of conditions and may bear fruit.

Even an unintentional mistake can lead to further unwholesome actions if, out of fear of its consequences, a person becomes defiled, lies, shifts blame, or causes harm. The past cannot be changed, but one can acknowledge responsibility, make amends where possible, and refrain from worsening the consequences. Liberation is not an escape from *kamma*.

The weight of a kammic result depends, among other things, on the state of mind. Craving, ignorance, and clinging intensify suffering and may aggravate the consequences of its ripening. Wisdom allows one to see what is happening as it is, without rejecting the fruits of previous actions or generating new unwholesome causes.

No unchanging consciousness or entity passes from one birth to another. The connection between births is causal, not substantial: previous intentional actions, together with craving, clinging, and other conditions, participate in subsequent arising.

In SN 12.38, intention, planning, and persistent mental tendencies are shown as conditions that sustain further arising. *Cetanā* directs action and gives it kammic significance; when craving and clinging are present, such actions can sustain the continuation of becoming and birth.

Until arahantship, even intentional wholesome actions form *kamma*. Once *avijjā* is exhausted, the kammic formation leading to new *bhava* and birth ceases.

In SN 12.51, three kinds of formations arising under ignorance are distinguished: wholesome, unwholesome, and those leading to states of equanimity. Each becomes a condition for further existence.

With the cessation of ignorance, these formations are no longer produced.

How *saṅkhārā* Appear in Experience

In experience, *saṅkhārā* may appear as impulses: to think, speak, act, hold on, push away, prove, hide, continue a storyline, or return to an object.

Saṅkhārā and *taṇhā* are different processes. Craving can nourish the formation of corresponding *saṅkhārā*, while already formed *saṅkhārā* create conditions in which craving manifests again.

Until a *saṅkhāra* is noticed, the reaction unfolds automatically: the arising impulse is appropriated as "I want," "I decided," or "I need." When it is recognized as a conditioned process, it becomes possible not to follow it.

Repeating a habitual reaction does not lead to its cessation. If its mechanism is not recognized, repetition may merely reinforce the same way of reacting.

Conflict Between *saṅkhārā*

Several *saṅkhārā* may arise simultaneously in one person, impelling different actions. Depending on conditions, one may become dominant while another recedes. In interaction, one person's reaction may become a condition that strengthens or weakens another person's *saṅkhārā*.

Saṅkhārā are conditioned formations that influence further experience and action. Under *avijjā*, they may sustain craving, clinging, and subsequent becoming. Through repetition, the corresponding *bhava* becomes established: a role, an identity, a state of "I am like this."

Figuratively, *bhava* is a fortress. Under *avijjā*, various *saṅkhārā* take part in processes of building, repairing, and defending it, proceeding through craving and clinging.

The *Bhava* of "We" and Roles

Bhava can also be built around "we": "our team," "we are like-minded," or "we are better." Around this "we," boundaries, rules, and expectations form, while what lies outside begins to be perceived through the opposition of "us" and "them."

The image of this "we" may differ from one participant to another.

Bhava may also be sustained by a role being confirmed by others. In this way the role arises again and is appropriated as "I." Helping can also sustain *bhava* if clinging arises to the role of a "rescuer."

Bhava may remain latent and manifest only under particular conditions.

A thought should not be reduced to *saṅkhāra* alone: consciousness, recognition, feeling, attention, and intention participate in it. But a thought is conditioned by *saṅkhārā* and may become a condition for new formative reactions if it is picked up, repeated, elaborated, or appropriated. A useful question is not "why did the thought appear?" but "does an impulse arise to continue it, use it, or appropriate it as "mine"?"

Thought and *papañca*

MN 18 shows how experience becomes a basis for mental proliferation. When a faculty, an object, and the corresponding consciousness are present, *phassa* arises. In the mental sense field, the meeting of *mano*, a mental object, and mental consciousness constitutes *mano-samphassa*. From contact, *vedanā* arises; what is felt is recognized; recognition may be followed by *vitakka*, and further proliferation under ignorance becomes *papañca*.

Saññā recognizes and distinguishes what is perceived by its features. Attention may then begin picking out details, *anuvyañjana*: tone of voice, facial expression, implication, comparison, or a past memory. If this is not recognized, *papañca* arises: a story, an argument, an image of "me," an image of "the other," expectation, defense, resentment, or desire.

Papañca may begin not with a chain of thoughts, but with a small lapse in recognizing what is happening. When recollection weakens, an association or supposition that has arisen fills in the missing parts of experience. This construction then becomes a support for further conclusions, and the story begins to proliferate.

Once *papañca* has unfolded into a coherent story, even facts that contradict it may be incorporated into the story as confirmations or simply ignored.

Mental Constructions

Constructions are ways of shaping and interpreting experience. They can arise and disappear. With *upādāna*, a construction is held as "mine": "my story," "my opinion," "my view," "my feeling." This sustains *papañca* and new *saṅkhārā*. Through appropriation as "I" and "mine," separate constructions are linked into an ongoing personal story.

At the same time, a particular image of oneself may collapse while clinging to the very framework of "I" remains. *Bhava-taṇhā* may persist: "some kind of 'I' must exist somewhere." What becomes frightening is no longer only "I will not exist," but the possibility of the complete absence of any "I" at all, even in another being.

Dividing experience into categories can serve as a tool of practice. *Satipaṭṭhāna* operates with the distinctions "body," "feeling," "mind," and "dhamma"; the five *khandhā* likewise become material for investigation. Through these frameworks, conditioned processes, the arising of clinging, and its cessation are investigated.

Papañca takes hold especially easily around "I" and "mine." The constructions then do more than explain what is happening: they also defend an appropriated position, such as "my feelings," "my thoughts," or "how could they do this to me?"

An expansion of perception is not in itself *papañca*. More and more processes may be noticed without a story being built around them. *Papañca* begins when what is happening undergoes further conceptual proliferation: interpretations, comparisons, scenarios, and constructions around "I" and "mine."

A thought may be purely functional: remembering, speaking, going somewhere, preparing something, answering, or correcting an error. Under *avijjā*, however, a thought quickly becomes material for proliferation: "I think," "this is my thought," "I cannot be treated this way," "I must prove this," "I must hold on to this," or "I must get rid of this." The thought then ceases to be merely a mental event and becomes food for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

The practical question is therefore not only "what thought arose?" but also: "how is the thought that has arisen picked up further, what colors it, and where does proliferation around 'I,' 'mine,' and 'for me' begin?"

In DN 21, the further unfolding of this process is shown as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \textit{papañcasaññāsaṅkhā} &\rightarrow \textit{vitakka} \rightarrow \textit{chanda} \\ &\rightarrow \textit{piyāppiya} \rightarrow \textit{issā-macchariya} \\ &\rightarrow \text{enmity, violence, rivalry, and malice.} \end{aligned}$$

Here *papañcasaññāsaṅkhā* means conceptual categories and designations arising from the proliferation of perception; *vitakka*, the direction of thought; *chanda*, desire or inclination toward something; *piyāppiya*, the division into what is "liked" and "disliked"; and *issā-macchariya*, envy and possessive stinginess.

Chanda is interest, desire, or intention to act. It can be wholesome when directed toward *sīla*, *sati*, *samādhi*, and *paññā*, and unwholesome when mixed with craving, self-assertion, or escape. Unlike wholesome *chanda*, *taṇhā* is craving for sensual pleasure, becoming, or non-becoming and serves as a condition for clinging.

A check for *saṅkhārā*: what impulse arises? Where is attention being drawn? What is wanted from this thought, feeling, or situation? Are craving, fear, defense of a self-image, or control present? What conditions this, and where does "mine" arise?

The cessation of the chain does not mean the disappearance of all activities of the aggregates: the body walks, speech occurs, thoughts arise, and perception functions. But if these processes are not appropriated as "I," they do not nourish *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*; old conditioning is exhausted, while no new chain of suffering is built.

Taṇhā may manifest as "I want," "I do not want," "may this continue," or "may this disappear." At a deeper level it is recognized as saṃsāric fuel that sustains the formation of experience and clinging.

With *upādāna*, the arisen experience is held and appropriated as "I" and "mine," and then becomes a basis for *bhava*. *Papañca* may proliferate around this, while sustained appropriation develops into *bhava*.

Three Short Examples

Criticism. An unpleasant *vedanā* may meet old *saṅkhārā*: to defend, justify, attack, fall silent. If *cetanā* is not recognized, it passes into speech, action, or an ongoing inner drama and strengthens the role "I, the offended one" or "I, the one who is right."

Praise. A pleasant *vedanā* may meet a tendency to seek approval: "may they see me this way again." Praise then becomes food for the image "I am valuable," rather than simply a pleasant contact that arose and ended.

Attainment. If a result becomes proof of "what kind of person I am," success strengthens that image, while failure produces a painful reaction. Comparison then feeds *māna*, the urge to fix that image sustains *bhava*, and fear of failure and the search for confirmation feed *papañca*.

11. How *dukkha* Is Constructed from the Unpleasant

An unpleasant *vedanā* is not yet the whole of *dukkha*. Suffering is constructed when feeling becomes a condition for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

Example: a Harsh Comment

Even before the comment, *avijjā* may already be operating: a readiness to perceive experience through "me," the need to be right, and "my worth." The words therefore meet preexisting tendencies.

Link	What it looks like
avijjā, *saṅkhārā*	Experience is already inclined to become personal; there are patterns of defending, attacking, justifying, and taking offense.
viññāṇa, *nāma-rūpa*, *saḷāyatana*, *phassa*	The words are heard or read, the mind recognizes their meaning, psychophysical experience takes shape, and contact occurs.
vedanā	An unpleasant tone: a sting, heat, fear, irritation.
taṇhā	"I want to remove this," "I want to prove it," "I want to reassert that I am right."
upādāna, *bhava*	Clinging to an image and becoming a role: the defender, the offended one, the judge, the victim.
jāti, *jarāmaraṇa*	The "I who was insulted" is born; the role ages through replaying, exhaustion, guilt, or conflict.

With unpleasant *vedanā*, two different processes may arise:

- *paṭigha* and *dosa* - resistance and aversion: *paṭigha* manifests as pushing away what is happening, while *dosa* is a negative coloration of mind;
- *taṇhā* - craving for a different state: "I want this to stop," "I want it to be different."

They may arise almost simultaneously and reinforce each other: the stronger the rejection, the stronger the craving to get rid of the unpleasant; the stronger the craving and the inability to satisfy it immediately, the stronger *dosa* becomes.

Appropriation may then be added: "this is interfering with me," "you cannot treat me this way," "he did this to me," strengthening both processes.

With severe pain, distinct sensations may seem to form one continuous feeling. Yet some sensations arise while others intensify, weaken, and cease.

Knowing that pain is impermanent is not the same as directly seeing these changes.

Practice does not consist in turning the unpleasant into the pleasant. Unpleasant *vedanā* arose through conditions; there is no need to add a story about "I" to it.

An unpleasant bodily feeling may give rise to perceptions of danger, fear, and craving to be rid of it. The tension and anxiety that arise can intensify the pain, conditioning further proliferation of the reaction.

It is important to distinguish the feeling itself, its interpretation, fear, and craving for it to cease. See how they arise, what sustains them, and how they fade, without appropriating them or intensifying them through clinging.

At the same time, pain can have real bodily causes that should not be ignored.

12. How *dukkha* Is Constructed from the Pleasant and the Neutral

A pleasant feeling is not bad in itself. Under *avijjā*, however, it easily becomes a support for "I" and "mine."

The Pleasant: Praise

Phassa: words of praise are heard, or an approving message arrives. *Vedanā*: warmth, joy, lightness. *Taṇhā*: "I want more," "may they see me this way." *Upādāna*: "this proves that I am valuable." *Bhava* and *jāti*: a "successful self," a "loved self," or a "practitioner self" is born. When the praise ends, the image has to be maintained, and anxiety, comparison, or fear of loss arises.

A wise response is to recognize pleasant *vedanā* as pleasant and notice whether *taṇhā* arises toward it through conditions. It may manifest as the urge to prolong, repeat, or retain the pleasant experience.

Neutral *vedanā*: a Hidden Support for *avijjā*

Neutral *vedanā* is not the absence of feeling, but the tone arising from contact that is experienced as neither clearly pleasant nor clearly unpleasant. MN 148 says that the pleasant can nourish the underlying tendency (*anusaya*) to passion, the unpleasant the underlying tendency to aversion, and the neutral, when its arising, cessation, gratification, danger, and conditioned nature are not understood, the underlying tendency to ignorance.

Vedanā itself is not yet craving, aversion, or ignorance. But if the feeling is not clearly understood, the corresponding underlying tendency may manifest: passion toward the pleasant, aversion toward the unpleasant, or ignorance regarding the neutral.

It is therefore important to notice the background of experience: clothing touching the skin, the pressure of the body on a chair, body temperature, the sensation of satiety, sounds from the street, thoughts, plans, and so forth. Pay particular attention to *mano-samphassa*: a thought is also an object of contact and produces *vedanā*. The neutral may provoke either a search for stimulation ("this is boring; I need to turn something on") or fixation ("I will remain in this even state"). In both cases, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava* can be observed.

Neutral *vedanā* should not be confused with *upekkhā*: neutral feeling can be a dull background, whereas *upekkhā* as a factor of the path is clear, sober, and does not obstruct right action.

Checking the Pleasant and the Neutral

What was the *phassa*? What *vedanā* arose? Is there "I want more," "I want to remove this," or "I want to fill the background"? What image is being held through *upādāna*? What mode of *bhava* is taking shape? What will the dissolution of this state be like?

13. Where the Chain Can Be Interrupted

It is not necessary to catch the very first moment of *avijjā*. The chain can be weakened at different points. It is not broken by force. More precisely, when conditions are recognized and no longer fed, the process loses its support and gradually ceases. Practice consists not in suppression, but in clearly seeing exactly where *taṇhā* receives nourishment.

Non-clinging applies to any experience — pleasant, unpleasant, neutral, coarse, or subtle. The task is not to obtain the "right" experience, but not to turn what arises into "I," "mine," or a support for further clinging.

Where it was noticed	What can be done
At *phassa*	Slow down: "there was contact." Do not add a story immediately.

Where it was noticed	What can be done
At *vedanā*	Name the tone: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Feel the body.
At *taṇhā*	See the promise: “if I get/remove this, things will be good.”
At *upādāna*	Find what is being held and appropriated: being right, an image, safety, recognition, control.
At *bhava*	Recognize the role: the offended one, defender, winner, victim, controller, practitioner.
After *jāti*	Acknowledge: “the role has already been born.” Do not feed it through speech, action, and repetition.
At *jarāmaraṇa*	See the cost: exhaustion, guilt, anxiety, dependence, replaying.

Even if *taṇhā* has already arisen, this is not a failure. Even if *upādāna* has begun, this is not the end of practice. What matters more than catching it perfectly early is ending further nourishment.

14. Desire: Do Not Indulge or Suppress It, but Understand It

Desire does not have to be automatically fulfilled. But it should not be crushed either. Suppression often creates an inner dam: prohibition on the surface, accumulated tension underneath. Sooner or later, it bursts.

Three modes:

1. **Indulgence.** A desire arises and is immediately fulfilled. This reinforces the pattern: the pleasant must be prolonged and the unpleasant removed.
2. **Suppression.** A desire arises and is squeezed, condemned, forbidden. The desire is not understood, but driven underground and into shadow.
3. **Not feeding *taṇhā*.** Desire is seen as a process: bodily impulse, image, promise, thought, tension. It can be lived through without automatic fulfillment and without inner conflict.

The struggle against craving easily becomes another form of craving: craving for control, craving to conquer oneself, or craving for non-existence. It is therefore more useful to see the conditions of desire, its flavor, its cost, and the point where it is nourished.

Taṇhā as Saṃsāric Fuel

Taṇhā is not merely a formed “I want,” but saṃsāric fuel that sustains the formation of experience and clinging to the five *khandhā*.

“More,” “hold on,” “continue,” “obtain,” “change,” “remove,” “do not lose,” “become” - these are ways in which *taṇhā* may manifest in experience.

When “I” is already recognized as a process of clinging, the next layer of practice is to see the *taṇhā* that feeds this process.

Craving may be experienced as excitement and acceleration: to act faster, achieve something, or hold on. This may be followed by heaviness, emptiness, and a wish for everything

to stop. In this way, craving for existence and craving for non-existence may alternate, sustaining the same cycle. Craving suppresses vigilance and mindfulness. *Taṇhā* can arise in relation to any experience.

Kinds of *taṇhā*

Three kinds of craving are distinguished:

- *kāma-taṇhā* - craving for sensual pleasures;
- *bhava-taṇhā* - craving for existence and becoming: to continue, become established in a particular state, or become someone;
- *vibhava-taṇhā* - craving for non-existence: "may this not be," "may this disappear," "I do not want to be this."

Pleasant *vedanā* does not necessarily lead to holding on, nor unpleasant *vedanā* to rejection. The pleasant can be rejected, and the unpleasant can be held on to.

In SN 12.2, *taṇhā* is also analyzed according to the six sense fields:

- *rūpataṇhā* - craving for visible forms;
- *saddataṇhā* - craving for sounds;
- *gandhataṇhā* - craving for odors;
- *rasataṇhā* - craving for tastes;
- *phoṭṭhabbataṇhā* - craving for bodily sensations;
- *dhammataṇhā* - craving for mental phenomena.

Taṇhā and *rāga*: Craving and Passion

Taṇhā is saṃsāric fuel that sustains the continuation of clinging and becoming.

Rāga is passion, strong attraction, and sticking to what appears especially attractive.

They may arise together: with *rāga*, an object is experienced as especially desirable, while *taṇhā* manifests as the impulse to obtain it, retain it, or repeat the experience.

Rāga is not only sensual: *rūparāga* and *arūparāga* refer to attachment to subtle form and the formless. *Virāga* is the fading of passion.

Intentional actions arising in this process may become new *kamma* and bring corresponding results.

An unpleasant feeling may become harsh speech; a pleasant one, indulgence; neutral boredom, intoxication; a sense of lack, appropriation; fear, violence. The precepts are not limited to prohibiting particular actions. They help recognize the conditions from which those actions arise.

Nibbidā, *virāga*, and *vimutti*

Nibbidā is cooling toward clinging. It matures when *dukkha*, impermanence, and the cessation of conditioned processes are clearly seen.

From *nibbidā* develops *virāga*: dispassion, the fading of coloration and extinguishing of *taṇhā* itself toward conditioned experience.

Virāga leads to *vimutti*: liberation from craving, clinging, and ignorance.

Vedanā Is Not a Reaction

Vedanā is not an emotion and not a story about what is happening, but the tone of experience: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Emotion is usually formed later, in the course of the subsequent reaction to *vedanā*.

An emotion is usually broader than *vedanā*. Perception, intention, bodily tension, a story, and the state of mind already participate in it. An unpleasant tone of contact is therefore not yet anger, but under ignorance it may quickly become a role: "I am offended," "I am defending myself," "I must respond."

An automatic bodily reaction to contact is not in itself *taṇhā*: the eye blinks, the body pulls away, posture changes. The action itself does not yet show craving.

The sign of *vedanā* does not by itself determine which *taṇhā* will arise. The pleasant can be rejected, and the unpleasant can be held on to.

Practice begins by recognizing feeling as feeling: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, arisen through conditions. Such recognition makes it possible to notice the subsequent reaction, but does not by itself end *taṇhā*. As understanding becomes clearer and guarding the sense doors, right effort, recollection, collectedness, and wisdom grow stronger, clinging to the pleasant, resistance to the unpleasant, and inattention to the neutral arise less and less.

Recognizing an unpleasant *vedanā* does not mean immediately trying to get rid of it. After "this is unpleasant," a new *taṇhā* may arise: "may this disappear," "I need to hide," "I need to guarantee safety," "I understood the chain, so why is the feeling still here?"

The task is not to remove *vedanā* at once, but to notice the subsequent reaction and not pick it up. The feeling itself can be observed as a conditioned and changing process.

Already arisen *dukkha* can become a condition for new *dukkha*: rejection of suffering gives rise to "may this not be," "I want this to stop." Thus *dukkha* arises because of *dukkha*. It is important to see this second layer as well, without reinforcing it with craving for cessation and without turning one instance of suffering into a whole factory of new darts.

Action Without *taṇhā*

Action can occur without craving. One can eat, walk, work, study, or practice without *taṇhā*. The distinction is seen in whether a pull arises to continue, obtain a result, hold on to it, or remove an obstacle.

Taṇhā becomes especially visible when an action is interrupted or does not produce the expected result. Haste, a sense of lack, irritation, inability to stop, and distortion in evaluating what is happening indicate the presence of craving.

Taṇhā may unfold around knowing, awareness, action, constructing, recognition, perception, sensations, jhāna, attainment, and cessation itself.

Taṇhā can also arise in practice: "I am a practitioner," "I need to understand," "I have to enter again," "I want liberation" set the same mechanism of clinging and *bhava* in motion.

How the Chain Unfolds Differently

The ordinary chain proceeds quickly: contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, and *dukkha*. Practice does not destroy contact or feeling. It changes what happens after feeling.

When there are *sati*, clear comprehension, and collectedness, feeling can be recognized as feeling. Instead of the automatic "I want," "I do not want," or "I do not notice," clear see-

ing becomes possible: this arose through conditions, changes, and is not "mine." The link between *vedanā* and *taṇhā* is thereby weakened, and letting go becomes more natural.

Attention may repeatedly return to an unpleasant sensation and its intensification. Fear arises that it will become even worse, together with craving to stop everything immediately. Fear and tension can intensify the experience, causing attention to return to it again. Thus the reaction begins to feed itself.

It is important to distinguish the sensation itself, attention to it, fear, craving for cessation, and tension. See how these processes arise and sustain one another, without suppressing the sensation, deliberately intensifying it, or feeding the reaction with further clinging.

How to Investigate Sensual Pleasure

A pleasant *vedanā* in itself requires neither continuation nor elimination. It arises under the relevant conditions and ceases when the conditions change. *Kāma-taṇhā* appears in the next movement: "I want more," "may this continue," "I want it again."

Trying to exclude pleasant experiences merely because they may become a condition for craving can itself turn into craving to get rid of them. Practice here consists in letting the pleasant remain simply pleasant, without appropriation, craving, or holding on.

Guarding the sense doors is not reducible to avoiding attractive objects or suppression. With contact, it is important not to sustain *papañca* and the further unfolding of defilements.

In AN 6.63, *kāma* is explained not as attractive objects themselves, but as the desire and passion directed toward them.

In MN 13, sensual experience is investigated from three sides:

assāda - gratification, pleasure, and joy,
ādīnava - danger, unreliability, and cost,
nissaraṇa - escape through abandoning desire and passion.

Desire is usefully investigated through its cost: where does repeating this reaction lead, and what way of reacting does it reinforce?

The aim is not to convince oneself that a pleasant object is actually unpleasant. Gratification is to be known as gratification. At the same time, it is important to see what conditions it depends upon, how quickly it changes, what urge arises after it ends, and what the cost of repetition is.

Intentional abstention from sensual pleasure is not in itself *vibhava-taṇhā*: restraint may form part of ethical conduct, guarding the senses, and right effort. The extreme begins with cultivating hatred of the pleasant, attempts to destroy desire by force, or turning practice into a struggle against oneself.

It is especially important to notice that sensual pleasure is often used not for the sake of the object itself, but as an anesthetic for unpleasant *vedanā*: fatigue, loneliness, anxiety, boredom, or inner tension. The practical question is then not only "what is wanted?" but also "what unpleasant state is being numbed by this?"

In a particular episode, the way out may involve pausing, changing the conditions, meeting the actual need in another way, using the object in moderation, or completely abstaining. The deeper way out is that desire and passion lose their power, while pleasant feeling no longer demands continuation, repetition, or retention.

Metaphors for *taṇhā*

The suttas often explain *taṇhā* through images. It frequently appears as a habit, "just a little more," fear of loss, a wish to repeat, a wish to become someone, or a wish that something not exist.

In Dhp 334, craving is compared to a creeping vine: in a heedless person it grows. In the same way, a small concession, if unseen, gradually becomes a direction of mind. A person seized by craving is then compared to a monkey seeking fruit: attention leaps from one object to another, but satisfaction does not come.

In Dhp 335–336, craving is linked to the image of grass that grows again after rain. The outward manifestation can be cut down, but if the root is not recognized, the tendency sprouts again when suitable conditions appear. Practice therefore works not only with the action, but also with *vedanā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and the mind's latent readiness to follow the same familiar route again.

In SN 35.28, the Buddha says that the six sense fields, contact, and feelings burn with the fires of greed, hatred, and delusion. Pleasant feeling promises warmth, but when fed by clinging it becomes fuel for craving. Then what is seen, heard, sensed, and thought becomes not a field of wisdom but a field of burning: "I want," "I do not want," "may it be mine," and "may it disappear."

In AN 6.61, craving is called a seamstress. It stitches separate contacts, feelings, memories, and expectations into a story: "this is me," "this is mine," "I was like this," "I will be like this." A fabric of *bhava* is thus woven from separate conditioned processes.

Craving also sustains the illusion of continuity: separate arising and ceasing processes are taken to be a single stream of experience and a continuous "I."

In MN 75, indulging sensual craving is compared to scratching itchy sores. Scratching brings brief relief, but damages the wounds and strengthens the need to scratch again. Likewise, a pleasant object may genuinely give pleasure or temporarily relieve tension, but it does not remove craving and may strengthen tendencies.

In Dhp 347, beings carried away by passion are compared to a spider caught in its own web. In the same way, expectations, roles, fears, and attachments are formed and sustained, and then become conditions for further *dukkha*.

In SN 36.6, painful feeling is compared to a first dart, and mental suffering to a second. This shows that pain and *dukkha* are not the same. The first dart may arise through conditions, but the second is created by resistance, craving, and mental proliferation.

In SN 35.63, it is said that if craving has not been abandoned, it remains a companion even for one who has gone to the forest. Seclusion by itself therefore does not liberate: one may be physically alone and still live together with craving.

These metaphors point to one thing: *taṇhā* does not cease through satiation. It loses strength when its conditions, its flavor, its danger, and the ways of letting it go are seen.

Example: a Chocolate Bar

Contact: seeing a chocolate bar or remembering its taste.

***Vedanā*:** a pleasant feeling connected with anticipation arises.

***Taṇhā*:** "I want to get it," "I want comfort," "I want a reward."

***Upādāna*:** "I need this," "I deserve it," "the evening is not right without it."

***Bhava*:** "I, the one who needs something pleasant," "I, the tired one entitled to a reward," or, conversely, "I, the practitioner who must not want."

***Jarāmaraṇa*:** the pleasure will end; heaviness, guilt, desire for more, irritation, or renewed tension around control may follow.

The practical choice may differ. Sometimes one may calmly eat a little, without the myth "this will save me." Sometimes it is better not to eat, because it is clear that this is an attempt to cover fatigue, anxiety, or boredom. The problem is not the chocolate, but the chain:

pleasant feeling → "I need it" → "I cannot do without it" → "I must get it."

Three sides of the experience can be distinguished here.

Assāda: the chocolate really has a pleasant taste and provides pleasure and brief relief.

Ādīnava: the pleasure ends quickly and only temporarily masks fatigue, anxiety, boredom, or dissatisfaction. When such a pattern is repeated, the habitual reaction is reinforced. New craving, heaviness, guilt, or a struggle against oneself is added to the initial tension.

Nissaraṇa: seeing the demand and not indulging it automatically. Pleasant feeling arises and ends. The unpleasant can be experienced directly without an immediate attempt to numb it. If the body genuinely needs food, water, or rest, the need is met calmly, without turning it into a reward, salvation, or confirmation of a self-image.

15. *Satipaṭṭhāna*: the Four Foundations of Recollection

Satipaṭṭhāna is not the observation of "everything indiscriminately," but clear recollection of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā* as arising, conditioned, and impersonal processes. This practice operates within the integrated path: *sīla*, *indriya-saṃvara*, *sati*, *samādhi*, and *paññā* support one another.

Sati itself is also conditioned: it arises, strengthens, and weakens depending on causes such as *sīla*, energy, clarity, collectedness, wise attention, and the absence of coarse hindrances. Awakening does not mean permanent "24/7 awareness" as an unchanging state. More important is that experience is no longer appropriated as "I" and no longer feeds *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

Recollection does not mean continuous self-monitoring or trying to track every movement, thought, or feeling. There is no need deliberately to search for *taṇhā*, *bhava*, or other processes at every moment. Such effort easily creates tension and the position of an "observer self."

Foundation	Practice	Error
kāyānupassanā	Body as body: breathing, postures, elements, actions, dissolution.	"This is my body, and I must constantly subject it to my will."
vedanānupassanā	Pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā*.	Immediately turning feeling into a story, or romanticizing it.
cittānupassanā	Qualities of *citta*: *rāga*, *dosa*, *moha*, contraction or distraction, expansiveness, collectedness, and liberation.	Creating an "observer self."

Foundation	Practice	Error
dhammānupassanā	The hindrances, *khandhā*, sense fields, *bojjhaṅgā*, and *ariyasacca*.	Theorizing instead of recognizing.

The formula "body as body" points to contemplation of a specific aspect of bodily experience, such as breathing, posture, parts of the body, or elements. In MN 118, breathing is treated as a bodily process. It can therefore be observed as a distinct object of body contemplation; one need not necessarily encompass every bodily sensation simultaneously.

In contemplating feelings, one distinguishes pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā*, and each of these as *sāmisa* or *nirāmisa*. *Vedanā* means the tone of experience, not emotion in the broad sense.

Sāmisa is feeling with worldly, sensual nourishment; *nirāmisa* is without that nourishment and is connected with renunciation. *Nirāmisa* therefore cannot be reduced only to pleasant feeling or only to *samādhi*. For example, pleasure based on the five strands of sensual pleasure is *sāmisa*, while the pleasure of jhāna is *nirāmisa*; the same distinction is applied to unpleasant and neutral *vedanā* as well.

In practice, it is important to see not only whether *vedanā* is pleasant, but also the conditions from which it arises and whether it continues through *taṇhā* and clinging.

Dhammānupassanā is contemplation of *dhammā* as *dhammā*: hindrances, factors of awakening, and other practical categories of the Dhamma. One recognizes not only whether the relevant phenomenon is present, but also the conditions of its arising and cessation. In the case of a hindrance, one investigates what feeds it and what leads to its abandonment; in the case of a factor of awakening, what promotes its arising and further development.

Observing *citta*

In MN 10 and DN 22, eight pairs are listed:

- *sarāga / vītarāga* - with attraction / without attraction;
- *sadosa / vītadosa* - with aversion / without aversion;
- *samoha / vītamoha* - with delusion / without delusion;
- *saṅkhitta / vikkhitta* - contracted / distracted;
- *mahaggata / amahaggata* - expanded, exalted / unexpanded;
- *sauttara / anuttara* - surpassable / unsurpassed;
- *samāhita / asamāhita* - collected / uncollected;
- *vimutta / avimutta* - liberated / unliberated.

These eight pairs do not form a sequence. They describe qualities of *citta* that are recognized as they arise.

In *cittānupassanā*, it is specifically the state of *citta* that is investigated, not the entirety of mental content. A thought, image, *vedanā*, *saññā*, or intention may be investigated within other frameworks of *satipaṭṭhāna*.

Citta too arises and ceases through conditions.

Citta and *bhava* should not be conflated. *Citta* describes the current state or disposition of mind. *Bhava* concerns becoming, which can become established in an appropriated role. An established role influences subsequent perception and reactions, while repeated reactions can sustain that role.

Practices of *satipaṭṭhāna*

MN 10 and DN 22 list breathing, postures, clear comprehension of actions, parts of the body, elements, cemetery contemplations, feelings, states of mind, and *dhammā*. Their task is to teach one to see body as body, feeling as feeling, mind as mind, and phenomena as phenomena, without appropriation.

It is useful to distinguish directed contemplation from open practice. In the first, attention remains with one field: breathing, elements, *vedanā*, mind, or *dhammā*. In the second, once the mind is stable, processes may appear within a broad field: sound, sensation, thought, feeling, intention. The criterion is the same: are arising, cessation, conditionality, and non-appropriation visible?

In daily life, it is not necessary to track the whole chain constantly. With sufficiently developed mindfulness and wisdom, the process is noticed at the relevant moment.

The conditioned nature of attention does not mean that it should be left to drift. Intention, recollection, and the direction of attention are also developed as conditioned processes. No separate "controller" is needed: it is enough to create conditions under which attention leads to clearer seeing and the cessation of *dukkha*.

Emptiness, Absence, Dissolution, and Fading

Below are three interrelated meditations: emptiness, dissolution, and fading. In the practice of emptiness, absence is distinguished separately. Thus a single process can be examined from four aspects.

Absence. What was previously present in experience is now absent. This concerns present experience itself, not the physical disappearance of an object.

Emptiness. The process is empty of "I," "mine," and a separate owner.

Dissolution. What is composite ceases to be held together as a single whole. The loss of coherence among what had previously been perceived as one is discerned.

Fading. In a process that has already arisen, its fading and cessation are discerned. Attention is directed toward this phase of the process, without trying to produce it intentionally.

The mind is trained to see the process as a whole:

$$\text{arising} \rightarrow \text{change and fading} \rightarrow \text{disappearance} \rightarrow \text{cessation}.$$

Emphasis on fading weakens the habitual intoxication with the arising of an object: instead of "it appeared - therefore it must be continued," it becomes clear that what has arisen will inevitably cease. Craving thereby weakens.

These aspects can unfold together: *composite character* $\rightarrow$ *dissolution* $\rightarrow$ *fading* $\rightarrow$ *cessation* $\rightarrow$ *absence*. Emptiness of "I" and "mine" can be discerned at any stage.

The cessation of one process does not exclude a similar one from arising immediately afterward. It is important to distinguish the cessation of the previous process from a new arising, rather than taking them to be one continuing phenomenon.

With breathing, one can observe not only the end of an in-breath or out-breath, but fading throughout the entire process. One aspect of perception may cease before another: for example, the sensation of air at the nose disappears while the movement of the abdomen remains discernible.

Nothing needs to be deliberately made to "fade." If clinging to the breath, a sensation, or another process arises, the clinging itself is investigated. Tension and the search for residual

sensations also become objects of observation.

The desire "may this cease" is examined in the same way: *phassa* → *vedanā* → *taṇhā* → intention to make it cease → possible *upādāna*.

These meditations are developed regularly alongside *jhāna* and *arūpa-āyatana*. They can be practiced in formal meditation, after *jhāna*, and during the day with the body, *vedanā*, thoughts, *citta*, *saṅkhārā*, *saññā*, *viññāṇa*, *āyatana*, contacts, *jhāna*, and *arūpa-āyatana*.

The Body as Elements

In MN 10, the body is contemplated as consisting of the four great elements. More detailed examples of internal and external elements are given in MN 28. Here the names "earth," "water," "fire," and "air" are best understood not as four separate substances, but as qualities of bodily experience:

- the earth element: hardness, solidity, and resistance;
- the water element: liquidity, moisture, and fluidity;
- the fire element: temperature, warming, aging, and digestion;
- the air element: movement, pressure, expansion, contraction, inhalation, and exhalation.

It is useful first to feel the body as a whole and then notice these qualities in turn. There is no need to seek a "pure" element or imagine particles: several qualities are usually combined in a single experience. In the foot, for example, hardness, pressure, movement, warmth, and moisture may all be present at once.

One may then compare the internal and the external. The hardness of bones and the hardness of the floor, bodily warmth and external warmth, belong to the same kinds of conditioned qualities. In MN 28, internal and external elements are regarded in the same way: as not mine, not me, and not my *attā*.

Practice is not reducible to repeating this formula. One should notice how the qualities arise through conditions, change, and do not submit to complete control. The body is then seen not as a single unchanging thing that belongs to me or is me, but as a combination of conditioned processes.

A Short Sequence

1. Feel the whole body and its contact with its support.
2. Notice hardness, solidity, and resistance.
3. Notice liquids, moisture, and fluidity.
4. Notice warmth, coolness, and changes in temperature.
5. Notice breathing, pressure, expansion, contraction, and other movement.
6. See that the qualities combine, change through conditions, and have no separate owner.

When the mind is simultaneously clouded and agitated, it can sometimes help to begin with the earth element: feel the weight of the body, the feet, and the support beneath them, move attention downward from the head, and then turn to natural breathing. This is a way of grounding and collecting attention, not a practice involving hidden energy.

A Mind Like the Elements

In MN 62, the elements are also used as images of a stable and unshaken mind. Rāhula is instructed to develop a mind like earth, water, fire, air, and space, so that pleasant and unpleasant contacts that arise do not seize the mind or remain in it.

Elements as "Not Self"

Contemplation of the elements does not end with recognizing solidity, fluidity, heat, movement, or space. In MN 62, the internal and external elements are regarded in the same way:

"This is not mine, I am not this, this is not my *attā*."

Six Elements and Eight Attainments

The early suttas explicitly list six elements:

1. earth;
2. water;
3. fire;
4. air;
5. space;
6. consciousness.

The first four describe qualities of form. The space element (*ākāsa-dhātu*) appears as cavities, openings, intervals, and empty space, through which bodily form has internal divisions and boundaries.

The consciousness element (*viññāṇa-dhātu*) means conditioned knowing of an object. It is not an eternal observer, pure, independent consciousness, or a hidden ground of the world: consciousness arises when the relevant conditions are present.

A correspondence may be drawn with the jhānas through earth, water, fire, and air, and with the *arūpa-āyatana* through:

5. space;
6. consciousness;
7. nothingness;
8. neither perception nor non-perception.

The seventh and eighth items are not listed as elements in the suttas.

Contemplation of an element is not identical with a jhāna or an *arūpa-āyatana*. Contemplation of the earth element is not in itself the first jhāna, contemplation of space is not the dimension of boundless space, and recognition of the consciousness element is not the dimension of boundless consciousness.

Contemplating the Body, Its Parts, the Elements, and Death Without Aversion

Contemplation of body parts, elements, and death is not intended to produce disgust toward the body or gloom. Its purpose is sobriety. The body is seen as body: composite, dependent,

vulnerable, and not fully subject to will. This weakens enchantment, fear, and appropriation, but should not turn into aversion. Such practices also often help calm the mind at the beginning of meditation.

Walking Meditation

Walking meditation (*caṅkama*) is not a secondary practice, but a natural continuation of *kāyānupassanā*. MN 10 and DN 22 say explicitly: when a practitioner is walking, they know, "I am walking"; when standing, sitting, or lying down, they know the corresponding bodily posture. Walking helps carry *sati* from motionless sitting into movement and daily life. It is also useful when there is drowsiness, heaviness after eating, or bodily discomfort.

A practical method:

- choose a level path or quiet area with few distractions;
- before beginning, align the body for a moment and establish the intention;
- walk at a natural pace, without turning walking into theatrical slowness;
- keep attention on sensations in the feet and legs, on the movement of the body as a whole, or on breathing; choose what works best;
- when the mind wanders into thought, gently notice this and return to the step;
- see walking as a process: lifting, moving, touching, pressure, shifts of balance, and the intention to walk.

Walking provides a clear way to observe *anattā*: steps occur through many conditions, including intention, balance, muscles, contact with the ground, attention, and habit. No owner can be found in a step; there are conditions, a conditioned process, movement, and knowing movement.

Walking is not limited to contemplation of the body. While walking, one can practice all four *satipaṭṭhāna*:

- *kāyānupassanā*: movements, posture, breathing, and bodily elements;
- *vedanānupassanā*: pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feelings;
- *cittānupassanā*: the state and coloration of mind: clarity, cloudiness, calm, agitation, and the presence or absence of defilements;
- *dhammānupassanā*: processes occurring in the mind: hindrances, craving, clinging, awakening factors, and the conditions of their arising and cessation.

While contemplating body, feelings, and mind, one can also investigate the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (*anicca*), unsatisfactoriness (*dukkha*), and not-self (*anattā*). It is important to see directly how processes arise, change, and cease, why they cannot serve as a reliable basis for satisfaction, and why none of them is "I" or "mine."

It is not necessary to encompass all four areas of contemplation at once. Even jhānas may be practiced while walking, although the depth of absorption will be considerably less than in meditation while sitting or lying down.

If anxiety arises while walking near other people, it is not necessary first to convince oneself that "nothing is wrong" or "nobody cares." It is more useful to see the process itself:

- bodily tension or contraction;
- unpleasant *vedanā*;
- *saññā*: recognition of another person's presence;
- *vitakka*: "they may notice me," "what will they think?";
- *papañca*: further scenarios;

- *taṇhā*: “I want not to be noticed,” “I want to control the situation,” “I want the anxiety to be gone.”

If there is no real need to change anything, it is not necessary to follow the arisen craving immediately by stopping the walk, checking the other person’s facial expression, inventing replies in advance, or trying to remove the anxiety.

Sati-sampajañña: Recollection and Clear Comprehension

In the standard formula of *satipaṭṭhāna*, the practitioner is described as *ātāpī sampajāno satimā*: diligent, clearly comprehending, recollecting.

The formula also includes *vineyya loke abhijjhā-domanassaṁ*: having set aside covetous desire (*abhijjhā*) and distress (*domanassa*) in regard to the world. *Domanassa* here means unpleasant mental feeling, distress, or dejection.

Ātāpī means diligent and ardent. The word is literally associated with heat or burning, but here it is better understood as alert, sustained energy: not becoming distracted, not feeding the unwholesome, and maintaining the conditions for clarity.

Sati is recollection: the ability to remember the object, task, and direction of practice and, when distraction is noticed, return to them.

Sampajañña means clear comprehension: what is happening now, why an action is being performed, whether it is appropriate, and what consequences may follow.

Recollection does not require holding to an object at all costs while ignoring what is happening around one. In formal meditation and daily activity, the object and breadth of attention are chosen according to the task and conditions.

Vigilance

Vigilance means not losing sight of what is happening when a strong feeling or impulse arises. It is important to notice whether it begins to carry the mind along so strongly that the circumstances and consequences of an action are no longer taken into account.

This does not mean constantly “being on guard” or controlling every thought and every sensation, but the ability to notice in time when an impulse begins to turn into action without regard to conditions. With practice, this kind of seeing becomes natural.

Sati and Sensual Desire

The arising of sensual desire does not yet mean that recollection is completely absent. In MN 10, the practitioner recognizes the presence or absence of *kāmacchanda*, the conditions of its arising, its abandonment, and its future non-arising.

Recognizing desire and following it are not the same. Right recollection does not make indulgence in sensuality part of practice. In SN 47.5, the five hindrances, including sensual desire, are called a mass of the unwholesome, while the four establishments of recollection are called a mass of the wholesome.

In MN 22, the bhikkhu Ariṭṭha claims that phenomena called obstructions do not obstruct one who indulges in them. The Buddha rejects this view and emphasizes the danger of sensual pleasures. Observing desire with recollection therefore cannot be confused with justifying or consciously feeding it: *sammā-sati* and indulgence in sensual craving direct the mind in opposite directions.

Right Observation and *anattā*

It is useful, but insufficient, merely to note "it came and went." It is important to see directly how the process arises, changes, dissolves, and ceases. At the same time one can discern: was there *phassa*? What *vedanā* arose? Is there *taṇhā* or *upādāna*? What mode of *bhava* is taking shape? Can this chain be left unfed?

The word "observe" is conventional. It should not be turned into a separate witness: "I am the one who is aware," "I am the one who sees processes." Nor does *anattā* mean the position "there is no me." Ideas such as "I understood that there is no me," "I observe the absence of 'I'," or "there is no me, therefore anything is permitted" may still be subtle *bhava*.

In practice, *anattā* is disclosed in this way: a process is known as a process.

The same applies to recognition itself. An in-breath arises, is recognized, and ceases; an out-breath arises, is recognized, and ceases. There is no separate "observer": recognition itself also arises and ceases through conditions.

There are conditions, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, and becoming. When this is clearly seen as composite, conditioned, impermanent, and subject to dissolution, the process is no longer appropriated as "I" and "mine".

This is especially important with thoughts. A thought may become an object of mental contact (*mano-samphassa*); following contact, *vedanā* arises, and then an urge may appear to continue, retain, prove, or elaborate. The question is: "what intention arises together with this thought?" When this is seen, the thought ceases to be "mine" and is seen as a conditioned process.

Do Not Block What Arises

Frightening, repulsive, aggressive, shameful, or dark thoughts, images, and feelings may arise in practice. They do not need to be suppressed, and they do not need to be developed. They are regarded as conditioned processes: they arise, change, and cease.

If *vedanā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, or fear arise together with them, that process too is recognized. What has arisen manifests and fades without appropriation, holding, or turning it into a new role.

On the path, any experience is let go. Clinging to the exalted, blissful, and "bright" is investigated in the same way as attraction to the dark, painful, and repulsive. All of this arises and fades through conditions, is not "I," and requires neither holding nor suppression.

Sense Fields, Feeling, and Story

In daily life, it is enough to notice through which sense field contact occurred and what *vedanā* arose, before a story is built around it. Instead of "he insulted me," one may notice hearing, unpleasant feeling, aversion, and the impulse to respond. *Papañca* thereby receives less nourishment.

Thinking can itself be attractive. Planning, fantasy, argument, inner commentary, and memory create a sense of movement. This movement may be pleasant or stimulating, and an urge arises to continue it. It is therefore important to see not only the content of thought, but also the feeling that arises through contact with it.

Sometimes the content of individual thoughts is secondary. Craving manifests as the urge to continue mental contact, so that thoughts, images, and other mental objects arise again.

Clinging can arise not only to a thought, but also to the attention directed toward it. Attention returns to the image, the thought unfolds into a story, and craving urges its continuation.

The mind can construct an attractive image and become trapped in craving for it, like a bee in its own honey.

A Method for Working with a Restless Mind

When there is restlessness, further thinking may be experienced as a way to calm down, although it often only sustains the restlessness. One thought arises, then another, followed by a plan, an argument, a memory, a fantasy, an explanation, or a dialogue. It seems that a little more thinking will bring a sense of safety, restore control, or find a solution. Often, however, this merely continues the chain.

A thought, image, plan, or memory may become an object of mental contact. Following *mano-samphassa*, *vedanā* arises; then an urge may arise to continue the thought, remove it, prove something, console oneself with it, or construct a new role from it.

A practical sequence:

1. Slow down and acknowledge: "mental contact has arisen."
2. Recognize *vedanā*: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling.
3. See the thought as a thought: an image, phrase, scenario, or inner argument.
4. Ask: "what intention arises together with this thought?"
5. Find *taṇhā*: the desire to solve, retain, prove, control, remove, or fill emptiness.
6. Find *upādāna*: what is being held and appropriated as "mine" - being right, an image, safety, a plan, anxiety, or the role of a practitioner.
7. Recognize *bhava*: what kind of "I" is taking shape - "I, the anxious one," "I, the controller," "I, the one who must finish thinking this through," "I, the offended one," or "I, the practitioner whose thoughts are interfering."
8. Do not feed the chain further: gently return to the body, breathing, the step, *mettā*, or apply one of the methods in MN 20.

The task is not to switch off thoughts or force the mind to become empty. The desire to get rid of thoughts can itself be *taṇhā*. Practice consists in seeing how a thought becomes food for craving, clinging, and becoming, and ceasing to nourish that process.

Mental contact may also take images, fantasies, memories, or a song or melody stuck in the mind as its object.

16. *Nīvaraṇa* and *bojjhaṅgā*: Diagnosis and Balance

The five *nīvaraṇa* obstruct clarity. The seven *bojjhaṅgā* open the path. It is useful to understand the current situation.

A hindrance is better seen not as "my problem," but as a conditioned process. It is important to notice whether it is present now, how it arose, what sustains it, under what conditions it weakens, and what helps prevent its future arising. Working with hindrances then becomes not a struggle against oneself, but an investigation of conditions.

Diagnosis: Seeing What Is Present and What Is Absent

Work with the *nīvaraṇa* begins with honest recognition. In MN 5, it is emphasized that it is worse to have a stain and not recognize it than to have a stain and recognize it, because seeing it makes removal possible. The same applies to the hindrances: sensual desire, irritation, dullness, restlessness, or doubt must first be recognized as present.

But it is also important to see when a hindrance is absent. Otherwise the mind may again carelessly follow an attractive, irritating, or clouding object. It is therefore useful not only to ask, "which hindrance is present now?" but also to notice, "this hindrance is absent now; what conditions led to its arising, weakening, or absence?"

In MN 9, right view is explained as understanding a phenomenon, its arising, its cessation, and the way leading to its cessation. The same scheme can be applied to the hindrances: what has arisen now, from what conditions, how it ceases, and what factor supports its non-arising.

How to Work with the Five *nīvaraṇa*

The five *nīvaraṇa* arise not only in meditation. They may obstruct clarity in conversation, work, study, and decision-making. In AN 5.51, they are called obstructions of the mind that weaken wisdom and make it difficult to choose wisely for oneself and others.

In contemplation of *dhammā*, it is important to see whether a hindrance is present now; when it is absent, which conditions sustain that absence; how an unarisen hindrance arises; how an arisen hindrance is abandoned; and how an extinguished hindrance is not fed again.

A hindrance need not be defeated through forceful effort. It is often more useful to see what feeds it and stop providing that nourishment.

Hindrance	How it manifests	What to do
kāmacchanda - sensual desire	A pull arises toward a pleasant image, taste, bodily sensation, fantasy, or plan for pleasure. The object appears to promise happiness.	See the attractive image as an image. Recognize *vedanā* and craving. Reduce sensual nourishment and gently return to breathing or the body. *Asubha*, contemplation of the impermanence of the pleasant, and restraint of the sense faculties may be useful.
vyāpāda - ill will	Argument, accusation, rejection, and the urge to punish, prove, or get rid of something arise. Sometimes ill will is directed not at a person but at the meditation object itself: breathing has become tiresome, the body is irritating, or practice seems boring or unbearable.	Recognize unpleasant *vedanā* and the wish to push away. Calm the body, breathing, and face. Develop *mettā*. If the irritation is directed at breathing, there is no need to force oneself to "endure the object": one may gently find a pleasant, beautiful, calming, or subtler aspect of the breath, expand attention to the whole body, or temporarily shift to *mettā*. If there is an unresolved conflict, one may calmly note: "I will deal with this after meditation."

thīna-middha - dullness and drowsiness	Cloudiness, heaviness, sinking, drowsiness, loss of clarity.	Check whether this is bodily fatigue or mental dullness. Sit more upright, open or half-open the eyes, and feel the whole body. If the body is genuinely exhausted or sleep-deprived, rest. If the mind is dull and scattered, apply enlivening conditions: light, movement, a shower, a walk, a clear posture, or recollection of the purpose of practice. During the session, one may use a rapid scan of bodily sensations as they arise and disappear. This restores interest, energy, and clarity, after which it becomes easier to turn to breathing. The absence of noticeable thoughts does not in itself imply clarity: silence may result from dullness and weakened perception.
uddhacca-kukkucca - restlessness and remorse	Rapid switching of attention, planning, checking, arguing, and searching for guarantees arise. With remorse, attention returns again and again to what was done or left undone.	First reduce incoming stimulation and recognize the bodily side of agitation: tension, an impulse to act, and rapid or wavering breathing. If the mind cannot remain with a single breath, there is no need to force it against the object. Simplify the task: only the body, only the breath, only this step. Be content with what is already here and now. One may use a rapid scan of sensations: quickly notice their arising and passing until excess movement and the craving to switch objects are exhausted. Then turn to the body or natural breathing. If agitation returns, repeat the scan temporarily. If there was a real mistake, acknowledge it, resolve to repair what can be repaired at an appropriate time, and release the replaying.

vicikicchā - doubt	"Am I doing this correctly?" "Is this the right method?" "Does it make sense?" "Perhaps I need something else?" Doubt paralyzes practice.	Distinguish useful investigation from doubt that drains energy. Apply *yoniso manasikāra*: what is unwholesome now, what is wholesome, and what leads to the cessation of *dukkha*? After the session, one may consult the suttas, ask an experienced practitioner, or clarify the method. During the session, do not feed doubt or doubt about the doubt itself; observe and let go.

Hindrances do not always appear one at a time. In a single episode the body may be heavy and drowsy while the mind is simultaneously restless, irritated, or seeking stimulation. This is not a new hindrance, but a combination of signs whose conditions should be investigated separately.

A rapid scan is useful when cloudiness and agitation occur together: this way of observing helps increase clarity when there is dullness while also exhausting the need for constant changes of object.

It is useful to ask not only "which hindrance is present now?" but also "from what conditions did it arise?": sleep, food, stress, sensual stimulation, echoes of the previous day, and so forth.

The antidote is therefore not selected by a single label: the body may need movement and light, while the mind needs less stimulation and a softening of irritation.

Restlessness itself can become an object of practice. Instead of analyzing each storyline, it is useful to recognize the quality of mind and its bodily manifestations: inner agitation, tension, an impulse to switch objects immediately, or to continue thinking. One can then investigate what feeds this state and what happens when the impulse is not followed.

The general criterion is this: if the chosen response leaves less *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, less contraction, and more clarity, the direction is sound. If practice makes the mind rigid, proud, clouded, or anxious, the conditions and the manner of effort should be examined.

Important: use an antidote when it is needed, and set it aside once the hindrance has subsided. Discern what is most appropriate now.

Latent Tendencies: *anusaya*

Anusaya is a latent tendency that may remain unmanifest for a long time, yet under suitable conditions influence the further course of the process: the thoughts, perceptions, and reactions that arise.

Seven main tendencies are distinguished:

- *kāmarāgānusaya* - the tendency toward sensual attraction;
- *paṭighānusaya* - the tendency toward aversion;
- *diṭṭhānusaya* - the tendency toward views;
- *vicikicchānusaya* - the tendency toward doubt;
- *mānānusaya* - the tendency toward conceit;

- *bhavarāgānusaya* - the tendency toward becoming;
- *avijjānusaya* - the tendency toward ignorance.

A latent tendency and an already arisen hindrance are not the same thing. Doubt, for example, may remain entirely unmanifest for a long time. Under particular conditions it arises, and details that support it are more readily selected from what is happening; unclear points are filled in with assumptions, and the assumptions are taken as facts.

It is important to see the conditions under which the tendency manifests and not continue the chain that has arisen.

For example, the habit of comparing oneself with others may not manifest for a long time. Later, someone else's success, an image of an attractive life, or one's own failure becomes a condition for new comparison, discontent, and a pressing urge to change something.

Circumstances and the object of desire have changed, but the latent tendency has not necessarily ceased. It is therefore important to see not only the reaction that appears, but also the conditions under which it recurs. The mere absence of an overt reaction does not yet mean that the tendency has been eradicated.

The relation of latent tendencies to *vedanā* is especially clear: pleasant feeling provides conditions for the tendency toward attraction, unpleasant feeling for the tendency toward aversion, and neutral feeling, when clarity is absent, for ignorance.

In practice, the process may be noticed like this:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{latent tendency} &\to \text{suitable conditions} \to \text{habitual bias in perception} \\ &\to \textit{taṇhā}/\text{aversion} \to \textit{papañca} \to \text{sustained } \textit{bhava}.\end{aligned}$$

At the level of a single episode:

- *vedanā* arises;
- under *avijjā*, it is not recognized as conditioned;
- *cetanā* may arise, setting the direction of the subsequent reaction;
- repetition consolidates this way of reacting.

What Nourishes Ignorance

In AN 10.61, ignorance is shown as a conditioned process:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{association with unworthy people} &\to \text{hearing what is not true Dhamma} \\ &\to \text{lack of confidence} \\ &\to \text{improper application of attention} \\ &\to \text{weaker recollection and clear comprehension} \\ &\to \text{lack of sense restraint} \\ &\to \text{unwholesome conduct} \\ &\to \text{the five hindrances} \to \textit{avijjā}.\end{aligned}$$

In the reverse direction, AN 10.61 gives a mirror sequence: association with worthy people leads to hearing the true Dhamma, then to confidence, *yoniso manasikāra*, recollection and clear comprehension, sense restraint, the three kinds of wholesome conduct, the four *satipaṭṭhāna*, the seven factors of awakening, and finally knowledge and liberation.

Balance and the Seven *bojjhaṅgā*

A dull and scattered mind lacks wakefulness, clarity, energy, and liveliness. It holds an object poorly, misses what is happening, and tends toward passivity, daydreaming, cloudiness, or sleepiness. An agitated mind jumps rapidly from one object to another and is accompanied by bodily tension, restlessness, and an impulse to do something immediately. During a single day, or even a single session, these states may alternate or occur together.

Sati is always needed: without recollection, neither a hindrance nor its absence, nor the factors of the path, are recognized. But this is not merely "mindfulness." It is recollection within the framework of the Dhamma: remembering the aim of the path and the present task, discerning what should be developed and what should be abandoned, and recognizing which tool is appropriate now.

For a dull mind, enlivening is useful: *dhammavicaya*, *viriya*, and a gentle *pīti*. Investigation here primarily means directly observing the arising and passing of phenomena. Right effort includes establishing conditions: adequate sleep, moderation in eating, movement, light, a shower, a walk, a comfortable posture, and preserving time for practice. In this context, *pīti* may appear as quiet enlivening joy and relief grounded in a wholesome support.

For an agitated mind, the words "calm down" and "concentrate" are not enough. *Passaddhi*, *samādhi*, and *upekkhā* indicate the direction, but a preliminary tool may first be needed to exhaust the need for constant switching and release the craving for new stimulation. Afterward the transition to the body, breathing, and stable collectedness becomes more natural.

The same method need not work every day. *Mettā* may help with ill will; a rapid scan of sensations may help with cloudiness or agitation; genuine exhaustion calls for rest. Skill consists not in loyalty to a single technique, but in choosing accurately and changing tools at the right time.

Rapid Scanning for a Dull or Agitated Mind

If the mind cannot collect around breathing because of dullness, distraction, or agitation, one may try the following:

1. Sit or lie down and recognize the present state of mind.
2. Notice the most evident bodily sensation: warmth, pressure, tingling, movement, tension, or another signal.
3. Do not penetrate, explain, or hold the sensation. See that it arose, changed, or disappeared.
4. Immediately move to the next sensation that has arisen. Attention moves rapidly through the body following the phenomena themselves.
5. Continue observing arising and passing without selecting a predetermined sequence of body parts.
6. As practice develops, sensations may become subtler and briefer. When interest in constant switching weakens and quiet appears, turn to natural breathing.
7. Know breathing wherever it is clearly felt today, not only at the nostrils.
8. If agitation grows again, return briefly to rapid scanning and then turn back to breathing.

With a dull mind, changing sensations awaken interest, energy, and clarity. With an agitated mind, the practice initially accords with the tendency to switch, but gradually and temporar-

ily satisfies the craving for new objects. Clinging to each signal weakens, and attention can remain more easily with one process of breathing.

The practice may take several minutes, a substantial part of a session, or the whole session. There is no need to set a fixed time or insist that it must be followed by jhāna. If today only a clearer and quieter state arises, that is already good.

It is easiest to begin with bodily sensations. Later, the same approach may be used with a brief thought, image, mood, or melody: it arose, was known, changed, and disappeared. Its content is not analyzed unless it persists and grows stronger.

As a separate variation, one may move through parts of the body from coarser to softer and more fluid, much as in MN 10. The pace should be comfortable, without fuss or haste, but also without prolonged examination as though through a microscope.

When Deeper Investigation Is Needed

If a phenomenon does not disappear, becomes stronger, or repeatedly returns, rapid scanning may be replaced by investigation of causes and conditions. The practitioner recognizes a bodily sensation, feeling, or state of mind, determines whether the feeling is pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, and examines what sustains the process. Its impermanence, conditionality, and the clinging connected with it can then be investigated. This is a different, slower mode of *dhammavicaya*.

Entry into practice need not be identical each time. Today *mettā* may help, tomorrow rapid scanning, and on another day simply breathing. The state of mind after sleep, work, and sensual contacts is formed anew through conditions each time.

17. *Mettā*, *asubha*, *indriya-saṃvara*, and *yoniso manasikāra*

Mettā

Mettā is a quality of *citta* in which hostility, rejection, and the intention to cause harm are absent. It is not a relation of "I" toward another being, nor a feeling that must be deliberately evoked toward someone.

Mettā, like other states of mind, arises and ceases through conditions and has no owner.

For the development of *mettā*, *samādhi* with this quality of *citta* is used. The state opens without contraction or limitation and is not directed toward a separate being.

If "I wish well," "I help," "I save," or an expectation of reciprocity arises, appropriation and *bhava* have already been added to *mettā*.

Craving may take the appearance of *mettā*: the urge to help another person can arise not from goodwill, but from a desire to be rid of fear or an unpleasant feeling.

Other *brahmavihāra* may be distorted in the same way: compassion is replaced by aversion to another's suffering, appreciative joy by the desire to possess the same thing, and equanimity by indifference.

Craving is distorted *mettā*. Where goodwill begins to be appropriated, held on to, and directed toward a desired outcome, craving arises. A free and gentle state of mind gives way to tension and the urge to control, to defend "I" and "mine." As craving and clinging intensify, fear, irritation, anger, and hostility may grow. Craving exhausts the mind and makes it rigid and restless.

Mettā, by contrast, requires nothing to be held on to or appropriated. It arises and spreads freely through conditions, without coercion or any desire to receive something in return. It is characterized by gentleness, ease, goodwill, and the absence of hostility.

It is important to see how craving arises and how goodwill becomes distorted. There is no need to fight craving or to try to create *mettā* by force. With clear recognition, craving and clinging are let go, and *mettā* develops without appropriation or holding on.

The Four *brahmavihāra*

The four *brahmavihāra* are *mettā*, *karuṇā*, *muditā*, and *upekkhā*. These are immeasurable qualities of *citta*: goodwill, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity.

As the mind is purified, the *brahmavihāra* unfold through conditions. Together with them, *samādhi* may deepen. They do not need to be deliberately evoked, held, or repeated. The urge to restore a faded state is already *taṇhā*.

By the level of *anāgāmin*, all four *brahmavihāra* should be unfolded to the fullest. This does not mean a constant positive attitude toward everyone. They arise and cease through conditions and remain impersonal.

In MN 62, the Buddha explains that developing loving-kindness removes ill will, compassion removes cruelty, appreciative joy removes discontent, and equanimity removes aversion.

With craving for non-existence (*vibhavataṇhā*), the mind seeks to get rid of unpleasant feelings, states, or the very experience itself. But this is not liberation; it is rejection that sustains suffering. *Mettā* helps remove hostility toward what is happening, cease fighting experience, and allow processes to arise and fade naturally. Wisdom allows craving to be seen as craving, including its causes and the conditions of its arising and cessation, without appropriating or sustaining it.

The middle way involves developing mindfulness, wisdom, and the four *brahmavihāra* together. None of these directions alone is sufficient for liberation.

Without mindfulness and wisdom, even wholesome states can become objects of craving and clinging, giving rise to new notions of "I" and delusions. Without the *brahmavihāra*, investigation of emptiness and impersonality can turn into rejection of experience and lead to nihilism.

It is important to develop at the same time clear seeing of all processes and a state of mind that is benevolent and free from hostility. Yet mindfulness, wisdom, and the *brahmavihāra* themselves are conditioned. They need to be developed, but not appropriated, held on to, or turned into a new "I."

In SN 4.14, Māra discourages the Buddha from teaching others, warning him against attachment and aversion. The Buddha replies that he teaches out of compassion, for their welfare, without either attachment or aversion.

Compassion (*karuṇā*) is conditioned by seeing the suffering of beings and is expressed in the wish not to cause harm and, where possible, to relieve *dukkha*. Above all, it means refraining from cruelty in intentions, words, and actions.

Help is given not for one's own satisfaction or to sustain the notion "I am a good person." Otherwise craving, clinging, and becoming (*bhava*) become mixed into a wholesome intention.

Equanimity (*upekkhā*) complements compassion with wise understanding of the causes, conditions, and consequences of actions, including *kamma*.

Dosa and *adosa*

Hostility does not cease by adding more hostility. This only feeds the chain: contact becomes unpleasant feeling, unpleasant feeling becomes rejection, and rejection becomes harsh speech, action, or conflict.

> *Na hi verena verāni, sammantīdha kudācanaṁ;*
> *Averena ca sammanti, esa dhammo sanantano.*

Dhp 5 says that hostility is not stilled by hostility (*verena*); it is stilled by non-hostility (*averena*). This clearly shows the practical meaning of *adosa*. The point is not to approve of everything or become helpless, but not to feed *dosa* with new *dosa*. Action may sometimes need to be firm, but the mind does not have to become hostile.

In Snp 1.8, the same principle is expressed practically: do not deceive, despise, or wish suffering upon another out of anger and rejection.

Asubha

Asubha does not mean hatred of the body. It is a sober seeing of the body as body: elements, processes, aging, illness, dissolution. The practice is useful against sensual enchantment and the idealization of form.

Indriya-saṃvara

Restraint of the sense faculties is not hatred of the world, but a wise economy of contacts. If the mind constantly takes in hyperstimulation, content, arguments, news, and gossip, *taṇhā* receives endless food.

Some contacts are deliberately designed to arouse *taṇhā*. Advertising, recommendation feeds, and status imagery connect an object with promises of novelty, belonging, success, or happiness. Repetition of such pairings can sustain habitual patterns, craving, and *bhava*. Sense restraint includes recognizing this mechanism before “I need this” arises.

Sense restraint continues after contact as well: the task is not to sustain the further unfolding of the chain and *papañca*. If the mind is already caught, external conditions can be changed: one may look away, close an app, or end a conversation.

Restraint also applies to the door of mind. A thought, image, memory, idea, or another *dhamma* can be picked up in the same way as a visible form or a sound.

A concept can become a support for *bhava*: it can be held as “mine,” defended against contradictory facts, and used to sustain a particular role. In this sense, a view can be guarded like a fortress: whatever contradicts it is pushed away or not noticed.

Practice is to recognize the process that has arisen and not develop *papañca*, *taṇhā*, clinging, and further *bhava* around it.

For this, it is useful to:

- noticing which signs and details seize attention again;
- not mentally replaying imagined scenarios or inner arguments, and not seeking the next stimulus;
- reducing unnecessary incoming contacts that feed craving and irritation;
- pausing before responding;
- setting aside screen-free periods of silence.

Yoniso manasikāra

In MN 2, wise attention is connected with the non-arising of new taints and the abandonment of those already arisen. In SN 46.51, frequent attention to particular signs is called nourishment for the corresponding hindrances or factors of awakening.

Attention is therefore better understood not as a universal "fuel of mind," but as a condition that strengthens the chosen direction. As a practical distinction, one may say that *sati* helps one not lose the object, task, and framework of practice, while *yoniso manasikāra* directs examination toward causes, consequences, and cessation: not "how can I obtain what I want?" but "what conditions are creating *dukkha* now, and which lead to its cessation?"

In AN 4.49, four *vipallāsa* are described:

- the impermanent is taken as permanent;
- the unsatisfactory as satisfactory;
- *anattā* as "self";
- the unattractive (*asubha*) as beautiful (*subha*).

A distortion can manifest as a ready-made frame through which what is happening is sorted. The frame "everything is good" erases *dukkha*, holds on to the pleasant, and obstructs seeing causes and conditions. The frame "everything is bad" is likewise not seeing *dukkha* as it is and may feed *vibhava-taṇhā*. In both cases, what is happening is fitted to an already constructed picture.

With *yoniso manasikāra*, a phenomenon is examined in terms of its causes and conditions, its arising and cessation, and the consequences of clinging to it.

18. *Samādhi* and the Jhānas

Samādhi is not for accumulating spiritual experiences; it is for making the mind fit for its work. A collected mind is less disturbed by the *nīvaraṇa* and better able to see the sequence *vedanā - taṇhā - upādāna - bhava*. *Samatha* calms and collects the mind; *vipassanā* clarifies conditions and dispels *avijjā*. Without wisdom, even deep peace may become subtle clinging.

In MN 44, *samādhi* is defined as collectedness of mind (*cittassa ekaggatā*). The four *satipaṭṭhāna* are called its bases (*samādhinimitta*), and the four right efforts its necessary supports (*samādhiparikkhāra*). Their repeated practice, development, and cultivation constitute the development of *samādhi*.

Citta and *paññā* are not the same thing. The mind may be calm, pleasant, clear, or deeply collected, but this by itself does not yet mean wisdom. *Paññā* recognizes conditionality, *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*, *taṇhā*, and clinging.

Samatha and *vipassanā* are not two competing paths. In AN 4.170, four possibilities are described: insight preceded by tranquility; tranquility preceded by insight; their development in tandem; and a case in which the mind is initially seized by agitation concerning the Dhamma, but then becomes steady, settles, unifies, and concentrates.

In every case, the criterion is the arising and development of the path, the abandoning of fetters, and the eradication of underlying tendencies.

A practitioner moves toward liberation on two legs: right *samādhi* and wisdom. Without right *samādhi*, wisdom lacks a stable foundation; without wisdom, even deep collectedness remains a conditioned state and may become a basis for clinging.

What Changes at the Level of Mind

The practice of *samādhi* helps one see mind as a conditioned process. In an ordinary state, it seems that "my mind" is simply like this: anxious, heavy, clear, sleepy, or restless. In practice, however, it becomes noticeable that the state of mind changes according to conditions.

The mind can be collected or uncollected, clear or clouded, gentle or tense, calm or agitated. Practice helps reveal that mind is not a permanent self or an owner of experience. It too arises, changes, and calms depending on causes.

With profound calming of the mind, a subtle sense of an observer may remain: "I perceive," "I know," "I am consciousness itself." It can seem as though someone stands behind the experienced processes, aware of them.

Yet the "observer" itself is also a conditioned mental process. The sense of the presence of a knower, the idea of such a knower, and the thought "I observe" arise and cease according to conditions. There is no separate observer outside the mind who perceives what is happening from the sidelines.

Practice is not confined to selectively recognizing the chain of dependent origination. It is important to see every process as it is, without exceptions. There is no need to fit what is happening into a familiar scheme, search for expected links, or recreate what is not currently manifest. The process itself is investigated: how it arises, what conditions it, how it changes, and how it ceases. Wisdom unfolds through directly seeing what is happening, rather than through a mental explanation of what supposedly ought to be happening.

Thus the sense "I observe" is also recognized as a conditioned, impermanent, and impersonal process. When its nature is clearly seen, there is no need either to hold on to the observer or to try to destroy it. It is the appropriation of knowing that is relinquished, not consciousness or perception that is suppressed.

When the mind is collected, contact becomes less chaotic, feelings are recognized more clearly, and the link *vedanā - taṇhā* is not triggered so sharply. Collectedness is therefore needed not for the sake of possessing a state, but to make the mind fit to see.

Jhāna as a Condition for Seeing

Samādhi is useful because the mind becomes collected, less seized by hindrances, and capable of seeing subtle phenomena. Without sufficient collectedness and clarity, blind spots remain: the hindrances not only distort perception, but their influence is itself concealed. Jhāna does not guarantee wisdom, but the temporary abandonment of hindrances makes the mind better suited to a clear investigation of experience.

Jhāna remains a conditioned process. Its factors arise through conditions and cease through conditions. Even deep *samādhi* should therefore be seen in terms of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. If an image is built around jhāna, such as "I attained," "I am special," or "I must hold on to this," it becomes food for *upādāna*, *māna*, and *bhava*.

Depth of Jhāna

Each jhāna is valuable for the depth to which it unfolds, not merely as a step toward the next one. Rapidly passing through the sequence does not mean that the earlier jhānas have been sufficiently deeply mastered. At the same time, one should not turn depth into a competition or a new measure of personal attainment.

Passing through all the attainments without wisdom does not liberate.

Sometimes clarity blurs. This is not a deepening of jhāna, but cloudiness or *moha*. In the suttas, *moha* (delusion, mental obscuration) is named as one of the three unwholesome roots. As *samādhi* deepens, clarity and recollection should not disappear.

Constant evaluation within jhāna interferes with its deepening. Comparison with past sessions, impatience such as "when will the next one come?," and forcing a transition bring unnecessary tension back into the process. It is better to leave evaluation until after emerging.

Moha-samādhi

Moha-samādhi is collectedness in which clarity and wisdom fade. Processes cease to be noticed and recognized; instead of clear seeing, cloudiness, dullness, or other defilements remain.

Another danger is intoxication with jhāna. The practitioner bathes in bliss, seeks to hold on to it and prolong it, without noticing their own craving and clinging. The pleasant state thus becomes a support for attachment, and clarity gives way to *moha*.

Bliss itself is not *moha*. There is no need either to retain it or to push it away: it arises, unfolds, and fades according to conditions. If "I am enjoying this," a wish to prolong the state, or another attitude toward it arises, these processes should be recognized and released, without sustaining clinging.

It is particularly dangerous to mistake the fading of perception for letting go, deep dullness for peace, or the absence of experiences for *Nibbāna*. Suppressing experience does not remove *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, or *upādāna*. On the contrary, clinging to such states sustains ignorance and craving.

Moha-samādhi differs from right collectedness not in the depth of immersion or number of thoughts, but in the loss of clear seeing and awareness. In jhāna the mind settles as awareness increases, whereas in *moha-samādhi* it sinks into obscuration. Pleasantness and a sense of emptiness do not make such a state liberation.

If fogginess arises, it should be recognized as fogginess, neither deliberately intensified nor clung to. Loss of clarity is not progress. What liberates is wisdom, seeing processes as they are and the cessation of clinging, not "switching off" the mind.

If *moha* goes unrecognized in absorption, deepening it further only intensifies the defilement. Such practice does not develop wisdom; it reinforces cloudiness, craving, and clinging, causing harm rather than benefit.

In MN 36, the Buddha says that the happiness of jhāna should not be feared. But he is referring to happiness free from sensuality and unwholesome states, not to intoxication, dullness, or clinging. As long as *moha* remains unrecognized, it is dangerous to deepen such a state.

One cause of this intoxication is the suppression of sensual pleasures. Craving is then redirected toward the bliss of the jhānas. The problem is not feelings themselves, but craving, clinging, and aversion. The happiness of jhāna is also a conditioned feeling arising through mental contact. In itself, it is neither better nor worse than other pleasant feelings. The value of jhāna lies not in bliss, but in the collectedness, awareness, and wisdom that it develops when practiced rightly.

After jhāna, there should be clarity. A good sign is insight during absorption or after emerging from it.

If the mind becomes cloudier after jhāna than it was before, this may indicate *moha* or clinging. In that case, the process should be thoroughly reconsidered.

How to Approach Jhāna

Jhāna (*jhāna*) is not attained through tension. In practice, entry begins with *sīla*, *sati*, the temporary fading of the five *nīvaraṇa*, and a calm support such as breathing or the body. Seclusion in the formula of the first jhāna is not only physical: sensual desire, irritation, lethargy, restlessness, and doubt no longer receive nourishment.

Effort should be neither rigid nor lax. Holding the object too tightly creates tension and quickly tires the mind; holding it too weakly does not allow collectedness to deepen. The appropriate degree of effort is discovered directly in practice: at times attention needs a little support, while at other times one needs instead to stop interfering and let go.

Different Entries into Collectedness

Breathing is not the only path into jhāna. Depending on the state and dispositions of the mind, collectedness may mature on the basis of *mettā*, practice with the elements, or another suitable object.

Breathing may serve as a support for entering *samādhi*, but as it deepens, breathing is left behind. Attention no longer returns to it as the main object: first the factors of jhāna come to the foreground, and in the transition to the formless dimensions, perception of forms is abandoned.

If a habitual impulse arises to check the breathing again or to focus on it, the impulse itself is recognized and not sustained. Breathing does not need to be deliberately suppressed or controlled.

In *ānāpānasati*, the task is not to control breathing, but clearly to know inhalation and exhalation and progressively develop calming of body, feelings, and mind. As practice continues, the mind becomes calmer, clearer, and steadier, while attention is directed toward impermanence, cessation, and relinquishment. Breathing is to be seen not as “my breathing,” but as a process: an inhalation arises and ceases; an exhalation arises and ceases.

Viewed through the chain of conditions, breathing becomes an object of attention. There is the body, the process of inhalation and exhalation, recollection of that process, and clear comprehension of the state of mind. On this basis, mental contact arises, and with it *vedanā*. At first this is often neutral feeling: nothing special seems to be happening. Precisely here, boredom, the search for another object, attempts to control the breath, or irritation with practice easily arise. When there are *sati* and an understanding of conditionality, neutral feeling is recognized as feeling, and the mind does not have to fuss.

As calming develops, breathing becomes subtler and neutral feeling may be replaced by a subtly pleasant one. This is not a goal to chase, but a sign that coarser bodily formations are calming. If unusual images, light, a *nimitta*, or pleasant bodily sensations arise, they should be understood as conditioned processes: do not grasp, retain, or turn them into “my attainment.” They need not appear at all.

The depth of the same jhāna varies from session to session. Sleep deprivation, overeating, fatigue, illness, and intense prior stimulation can make it shallow or clouded. Differences between sessions depend to a large extent on the conditions of practice.

Jhāna has no mandatory duration. A predetermined thought such as “I will stay here for so many minutes and then move on” brings evaluation back into the process itself. When

possible, it is better to set aside enough free time so that practice is not constrained by a predetermined duration.

There is no need to deliberately make breathing "correct." Inhalation and exhalation arise through conditions and are known as a bodily process: not "I produce the breath," but "breathing occurs and is known." Attention need not contract to a single point at the nostrils. It is better to know the whole cycle and its manifestation in the body, while keeping the face relaxed, the posture stable, and clarity awake.

When pleasantness and the first waves of *pīti* arise from seclusion and calming, the task is neither to earn them nor to appropriate an attainment. Such happiness need not be feared, but neither should it be intensified or possessed: it can simply be allowed to be, while doubt and clinging are released.

Pīti-sukha saturates and pervades the whole body. It is important that the pleasantness not remain merely a mental object perceived at a distance, but encompass and permeate the whole body.

The Pleasant in Practice and the Danger of Clinging

When the mind becomes sufficiently calm and collected, *pīti* and *sukha* may arise. Both are pleasant aspects of experience, but they do not mean the same thing. *Pīti* is rapture, joyful enlivening, or inspiration, while *sukha* is happiness, pleasantness, and inner comfort. In the first two jhānas, they are present together; in the third, *pīti* fades while *sukha* remains.

If clinging arises — "I want more," "this is mine," "I attained," or "I must retain it" — the pleasant becomes food for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*. Even meditative happiness then becomes a condition for future *dukkha*: fear of loss, desire to repeat, and comparison with past experience.

If *pīti* and *sukha* are seen as having arisen through conditions, as impermanent and impersonal, they are not appropriated as "I" and "mine." Rapture can then settle into happiness, happiness into quieter collectedness, and collectedness into equanimity. Transitions among the jhānas occur naturally: when the fuel sustaining a coarser state is exhausted, that state is no longer maintained, and the next jhāna matures without the deliberate thought, "I am moving on."

It is more accurate to speak of jhāna not as an event, "I entered a state," but as a form of collectedness that arises when the necessary conditions are present and can be used in practice. It is not an unconscious blackout: clarity and awareness remain, though thinking quiets. Jhāna is a conditioned process; if afterward there arises "I want to repeat this" or "this is my attainment," it becomes a condition for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*. Descriptions of jhāna occur in many suttas, for example MN 119.

After practice, it is important not only to determine which jhāna arose, but also to see what the mind has become like. A deeper unfolding usually leaves behind noticeable clarity, stability, and less inclination to cling to stimulation. Does the drive toward stimulation arise less often, along with irritation at the unpleasant and clinging to the pleasant? Are *vedanā* and *taṇhā* recognized more clearly during the day? If meditation increases pride, hunger for states, fear of losing an experience, or irritation over an "unsuccessful practice," a new *bhava* is already being built around *samādhi*.

The Threshold of Jhāna

At early stages, the first jhāna may be unstable. *Pīti*, *sukha*, clarity, and collectedness may be present, while brief thoughts, doubt, or wariness still arise at the periphery: "is this jhāna?"

"someone may distract me," "I will lose this state." This is either a pre-jhāna state or an entry into the first jhāna followed by being thrown out again, like a yo-yo.

This may be called the threshold of jhāna. It is a stage at which breathing has already become subtle and pleasant, the five hindrances have markedly weakened, and *pīti-sukha* has arisen, but fluctuations remain. Waves of *pīti* may occur even before the first jhāna. Here it is worth letting go, not clinging, trusting, and yielding to the process.

When *pīti* becomes sufficiently stable, attention can be shifted gently toward it: rather than trying to encompass it all at once, attend to its core, as though diving into it, allowing *pīti* gradually to envelop and permeate the whole body. Then *pīti* may increase, a kind of resonance arises, followed by absorption in rapture. At this point, the breath is let go. One should not try to intensify rapture through tension, hold it, or encompass it all at once. If rapture fades, that is all right. One may return to breathing or attend to the residual image of rapture, its afterglow, like the trace left by a lamp that has just been switched off. One may also establish the intention to fill with rapture on the in-breath and spread it through the body on the out-breath. Overall, this is a highly creative process.

In AN 10.72, [external] sound is called a "thorn" for the first jhāna. This may be understood as a warning about the vulnerability of collectedness that has not yet been fully mastered.

It is useful to notice fear of losing the state. The thought "I am about to lose this" reveals subtle *upādāna*: the pleasant state is already being appropriated as "my attainment." Practice here is not a struggle against anxiety, but clear knowing: "fear has arisen," "there is a wish to retain," "this is a conditioned process." This is to be released, and attention gently returns to rapture or its image, breathing, or the body.

Unusual bodily, luminous, or spatial effects are not the main criterion of jhāna. More important are whether the five *nīvaraṇa* have weakened, whether stability, clarity, *pīti*, *sukha*, and collectedness are present, and whether there is less clinging to the state itself. Entry through a nimitta understood as a reflection of a mind purified of the hindrances is not described in the suttas, but is quite possible in practice. It may arise with rapture or without it.

In AN 9.35, a practitioner is compared to a mountain cow that loses its former footing by trying to step farther too soon. Wholesome collectedness that has arisen should be developed, mastered, and strengthened, without trying to force the next state. This is not inaction, but right effort without craving for a result. On the other hand, one should not deliberately hold back either. Jhānas are always different and occur in different ways.

What Can Throw One Out of the First Jhāna

Most often, one of the following occurs:

- recognizing success and grasping it: "great, it worked," "I entered";
- trying to intensify or retain *pīti*;
- fear of unfamiliar intensity or loss of control;
- doubts such as "is this it?" or "perhaps this is not it," and fussing over the factors;
- effort that is too tense or too slack;
- the return of a residual hindrance;
- a hidden prohibition against happiness: "I am unworthy";

- questioning about the future: “what will I do after something like this?”;
- fear of falling after a pleasant peak;
- comparison with past experience.

Absorption Without Unconsciousness

Jhāna is not an unconscious shutdown, but neither is it merely an ordinary pleasant state, such as enjoyment of a beautiful sunset. Awareness and clarity remain and may become very strong, while *pīti-sukha* and unification of mind become the leading current of experience.

An external sound or bodily signal may flicker at the periphery without provoking interest, resistance, or a continuation in thought. Worldly contact passes by because the mind is absorbed in happiness born of seclusion and collectedness. In deeper absorption, the significance of external experience may diminish still further. One should not assume in advance that it will always be possible to switch instantly from deep collectedness to an urgent everyday task. Such practice is therefore best planned for free time.

Unusual Phenomena and *nimitta*

As collectedness deepens, flashes of light, changes in the body image, inner sounds, or mental images may arise. They are not obligatory signs of jhāna.

In the early texts, *nimitta* means a sign, mark, or aspect. A special luminous image used as an object of absorption belongs to a narrower, later use of the term. Some modern methods use a stable luminous or other mental image as a support, but a voice, narrative, melody, or image of a being should not automatically be declared a nimitta.

The First and Second Jhānas: Direction and Self-Sustaining Collectedness

No two jhānas are completely identical. Even a first or second jhāna in the same practitioner may differ in depth, intensity, duration, and in how vividly particular factors appear. One should therefore not demand an exact repetition of a past experience.

The main practical distinction between the first and second jhānas lies not in the character of the waves of *pīti*, but in the presence or absence of *vitakka-vicāra*. In the first jhāna, attention is still directed toward the object and continues to be sustained there. In the second, directed and sustained application subside, while collectedness becomes inwardly unified and self-sustaining.

In the first jhāna, *pīti-sukha* may be experienced as intense waves that still require gentle direction and the mind’s continued abiding with the pleasant experience. A wave may grow, recede, and then rise again.

In the second jhāna, *pīti* may also come in waves. It may be experienced less as rapture and more as joy. The central point is that directing and sustaining attention are no longer required.

The Third and Fourth Jhānas: Calming and Stillness

In the third jhāna, *pīti* calms while *sukha* remains. In practice, this may be experienced as calm, even happiness: pleasant feeling remains, but the waves of rapture characteristic of the first two jhānas are no longer present. Pleasant warmth may spread throughout the body; sometimes it feels as though the whole body is gently smiling. A contented peace arises: everything is well and nothing is required. These images are not obligatory criteria.

Experience of the third jhāna brings an understanding of the difference between *sukha* and *pīti*.

In the fourth jhāna, pleasant and unpleasant feelings have been abandoned. Clarity, one-pointedness, and stillness become prominent. The mind may be experienced as a monolith, ice, a motionless current, crystal, or transparent glass. The whole body remains clearly perceptible. Experiences may include neutral heaviness, transparency, a frozen quality, and clarity. There is firmness and confidence in the unshakability of the mind.

For a more precise assessment of the fourth jhāna, five parameters can be distinguished:

- clarity: how distinctly processes are seen;
- one-pointedness: the mind's unwavering stability on the object;
- absorption: how fully the mind remains immersed without distractions;
- mindfulness: recognition of the processes taking place;
- calm: the degree of tranquility without craving or agitation.

Each parameter can be assessed candidly on a scale of 1 to 10. This helps describe the experience more precisely than judgments of a "good" or "bad" jhāna. It is better to do this after emerging, not during meditation.

Deep peace by itself is not yet the fourth jhāna. The fourth unfolds as the result of the fading of the factors of the preceding jhānas. The first, second, and third may pass very quickly, but the sequence of refinement itself remains.

When Ripples Remain on the Surface

If a separate thought or restlessness remains at the periphery, one may gently try one of three approaches:

1. On a natural in-breath, imagine that the thought or fluctuation becomes joined to the air and, on the out-breath, leaves with the flow.
2. Slowly move attention through the body, evening out the stillness. One may use an image of water dripping onto hot ice while the entire body quietly freezes in the same way. The abdomen remains free for natural breathing; the muscles, face, and eyes are not tensed.
3. Apply discernment through wisdom: "this is not mine, this is not me, this is not my essence." The thought or restlessness is seen as a process arisen through conditions. When appropriation receives no nourishment, the phenomenon may disperse like smoke from a struck match.

If deep collectedness has become excessively concentrated in the head, a sense of imbalance has appeared, or the eyelids have tensed, it is useful to relax the face and gently distribute collectedness throughout the whole body.

A Stable *nimitta*

If the same stable mental sign recurs, one may direct a spotlight of attention toward it, enter it, and become absorbed. The point is not to remain in the stance "I am looking at that," but to follow it with attention and merge with it.

Insights Based on Jhānic Collectedness

Samādhi and wisdom deepen interdependently: collectedness makes subtler clinging visible, while recognizing and letting go of that clinging allows practice to deepen further.

Jhānic collectedness is not an end in itself, but without it insights may remain superficial or even become mentally painful. Fear and terror arise when the collapse of familiar supports of "I" and "mine" is revealed to a mind not yet strengthened by jhāna.

As the jhānas deepen, increasingly subtle supports of clinging and *bhava* may become visible and be relinquished. This is not yet final liberation, but more favorable conditions arise for further seeing.

Insights sometimes arise during jhāna and sometimes afterward, but deliberate investigation is usually better conducted after emerging, while the mind is still fresh and collected. It is also useful after emerging to review the experience and see the conditions on which it depended, how it arose, changed, and ceased. Jhāna too is conditioned and impermanent.

During jhāna, an urge to control the absorption may arise: to evaluate its depth, compare it with previous experiences, or try to retain or prolong the state. It is important to recognize these thoughts, intentions, and the craving that arises, without clinging to them.

If wisdom reveals defilements during jhāna, there is no need to stop investigating in order to preserve the absorption. The jhāna may fade; that is normal. Sometimes it is more important to see processes as they are, together with the causes and conditions of their arising and cessation.

Clinging can also arise to insight itself. After insight, a pleasant feeling appears, then craving to repeat the experience, retain it, or appropriate it as "my attainment."

Dependent Origination After Jhāna

After emerging from deep collectedness, one can examine a process that is clearly present, such as a feeling, bodily sensation, sound, thought, anxiety, or another contact, and trace its conditions.

For example, if a pleasant feeling has arisen, one can see what contact conditioned it, which sense fields were involved, whether craving arises following the feeling, and what happens when the process is not sustained by clinging.

Insight may arise after jhāna, at the boundary of its ending, or during it. Sometimes collectedness weakens for a moment, the process is clearly recognized by wisdom, and then *samādhi* deepens again.

Such understanding may accumulate gradually. The same process is examined from different angles until, at some point, its conditionality, impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and impersonal nature become clear enough for natural letting go.

After emerging, it is useful to see how the state was formed: intention, direction of mind, perception, sustained attention, and one's relation to what arose came together through conditions and supported the attainment. In this sense, jhāna is *saṅkhata*, a compounded and conditioned state. The *saṅkhārā* connected with it are formative processes that arise, perform their function, and cease.

AN 9.36 shows how a jhāna or formless dimension becomes a basis for liberating vision. Relying on the attainment, a practitioner regards the phenomena connected with it as im-

permanent, unsatisfactory, disintegrating, empty, and impersonal. In this way, the conditionality, limitations, and drawbacks even of a very subtle and pleasant state are revealed.

In the same sutta, the development of liberating vision is compared to the training of an archer. At first the archer practices on a straw target or clay figure and, over time, becomes capable of shooting far and accurately. In the same way, contemplation of conditioned phenomena develops through repeated use of a collected mind fit for work.

Then the conditioned is let go. The Deathless is revealed: the calming of all formative activities, the relinquishment of every appropriation, the cessation of craving, dispassion, cessation, and *Nibbāna*. If this work is completed, the defilements cease. If not, it may still result in the ending of the five lower fetters and the attainment of non-returning.

It is therefore useful not only to develop and master jhāna, but also, after emerging, to see it as a process that arose according to conditions. Its happiness need not be rejected, but neither should it be clung to: collectedness is used for liberation from appropriation, not to create a new identity.

Four Purposes of Collectedness

AN 4.41 names four directions in the development of *samādhi*.

Development of collectedness	Practical function
The four jhānas	Pleasant abiding here and now.
Perception of light	Knowledge and vision.
The practitioner knows when feelings, perceptions, and thoughts (*vitakka*) arise, are present, and cease	Recollection and clear comprehension.
Contemplating the arising and cessation of processes belonging to the five clinging-aggregates	Cessation of the *āsavā*.

Collectedness may provide wholesome peace, strengthen clarity, and become a basis for the cessation of defilements. The question “was it pleasant?” is therefore insufficient. It is important to understand what function the practice is serving now and what result it is tending toward.

Impermanence, Dispassion, Cessation, and Relinquishment

In MN 118, the practice of *ānāpānasati* includes contemplation of impermanence, dispassion, cessation, and relinquishment. This is what a rightly collected and clear mind gradually leads toward.

First, impermanence becomes more visible. An inhalation arises and ceases; an exhalation arises and ceases. No two inhalations or exhalations are identical. The feeling associated with breathing changes: the neutral may become subtly pleasant, pleasant feeling may become subtler, and *pīti* and *sukha* also arise and cease. Even calm and collectedness depend on conditions.

As impermanence is seen more deeply, passionate clinging to experience weakens. This is *virāga*: the cooling of greedy grasping at what cannot be held.

Cessation then becomes clearer. What has arisen through conditions ceases when those conditions cease. This becomes clear not merely as an idea, but directly in practice: nothing conditioned can be a reliable support for “I” and “mine.”

From this, relinquishment unfolds more naturally. It is not reducible to the thought "I must let go." Rather, grasping the pleasant, pushing away the unpleasant, and inattention to the neutral arise less often. The chain receives less nourishment.

Temporary Abandonment and Final Cessation

The absence of the five hindrances in deep collectedness is not equivalent to their final eradication. After emerging, the corresponding tendencies may manifest again. AN 4.123 shows that a person may enjoy jhāna, desire its repetition, and thereby obtain a corresponding rebirth without attaining liberation.

The depth and pleasantness of a state are therefore not in themselves measures of liberation. What matters is whether collectedness is used to develop wisdom and weaken *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and ignorance.

Important: *jhāna* does not liberate automatically, and not every pleasant meditative state is jhāna. Jhānas can become objects of clinging, grounds for pride, and causes of new *bhava*: "I am a great practitioner," "I attained a special state," or "I must repeat this." Even deep collectedness should therefore be seen as a conditioned process, not as a possession or a final experience.

19. The Formless Dimensions (*arūpa āyatana*), *nirodha*, and *Nibbāna*

After mastering the fourth jhāna, it is not necessary to move immediately to the formless dimensions. It is useful first to become thoroughly familiar with the fourth jhāna and establish a well-worn path back to it.

As a working metaphor, the reserve of *sati*, clarity, and one-pointedness can be imagined as a "tank." The fourth jhāna serves as its main "refueling" point: accumulated collectedness becomes fuel for further practice and for the opening of the formless dimensions.

The formless dimensions do not refill this "tank"; they use the collectedness already accumulated. If there is not enough fuel, the corresponding element may become discernible, but the *arūpa-āyatana* itself will not open or will quickly fade. When the reserve is depleted, it is therefore useful to return to the fourth jhāna and restore one-pointedness and clarity.

If the reserve of collectedness remains, a transition into a formless dimension may occur even without directly entering the *rūpa* jhānas.

With accumulated collectedness, there is no need to pass through the same sequence every time. In one session an earlier jhāna unfolds more deeply; in another the transition goes farther. There is no need to force transitions: deepening and letting go occur through conditions.

On the basis of the remaining collectedness, one may practice *satipaṭṭhāna*, especially contemplation of the body: its parts, elements, composite character, arising, change, and disintegration. Such practice helps weaken clinging to *rūpa*.

After the four *rūpa* jhānas, the suttas describe four formless dimensions: boundless space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither-perception-nor-non-perception. These are subtle attainments, not *Nibbāna*: they are conditioned and may become a support for *bhava* if clinging arises to their peace, subtlety, or exceptional character. Their value is to reveal the coarseness of sensual experience and *rūpa* and to provide material for seeing *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā* even in such subtle states.

Refining the Basis in the Formless Dimensions

Across the four *arūpa-āyatana*, progressively subtler supports are left behind. Yet each attainment remains conditioned and can become an object of clinging.

Their significance lies not only in the subtlety of collectedness, but also in the opportunity to discover clinging that is not visible during coarser functioning of the senses and consciousness.

The sequence of the formless dimensions is not important for its own sake. Its meaning lies in deepening experience and relinquishing increasingly subtle supports and forms of clinging. What matters here is not the speed of passing through attainments, but the depth with which the corresponding support is recognized and relinquished.

The four *rūpa* jhānas and four *arūpa-āyatana* form a progressive refinement of experience. Each successive stage makes a subtler layer of perception and clinging discernible.

Deeper attainments change how the earlier ones are perceived. After experience of the *arūpa-āyatana*, when returning to *jhāna*, what was previously experienced as extremely subtle and blissful may be found to be coarser.

The *jhānas* and *arūpa-āyatana* themselves can also be investigated as conditioned processes: their composite character, dissolution, fading, and cessation can be discerned.

Forward and Reverse Traversal

AN 9.41 describes nine successive attainments: the four *jhānas*, the four *arūpa-āyatana*, and *saññāvedayitanirodha*. The sutta also describes traversing this sequence in forward and reverse order.

In reverse traversal, *paññā* comes to the fore rather than absorption in *samādhi*. Each stage is fully recognized as impermanent, unsatisfactory, *anattā*, composite, conditioned, and interdependent. Reverse traversal should be distinguished from falling out of an attainment because of instability or a remaining point of clinging. A cycle of "up — down — up again" may also occur.

The task is therefore not a one-time "touch." The attainments need to unfold deeply enough for form, space, consciousness, nothingness, and then extremely subtle perception to be relinquished in succession. It is this depth that brings the practitioner toward direct recognition of the subtlest craving and toward *nirodha*.

The Eight Attainments as a Progressive Refinement of Perception

The usual short names are convenient, but DN 9 shows a more detailed side of the same sequence: at each stage the previous *saññā* ceases and a subtler one arises. For the first seven attainments, the text uses the expression *sukhuma-sacca-saññā*: subtle, genuinely present perception.

1. The first jhāna: subtle, genuinely present perception of rapture and happiness born of seclusion (*vivekaja-pīti-sukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
2. The second jhāna: subtle, genuinely present perception of rapture and happiness born of *samādhi* (*samādhija-pīti-sukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
3. The third jhāna: subtle, genuinely present perception of happiness together with equanimity (*upekkhā-sukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).

4. The fourth jhāna: subtle, genuinely present perception of neither-pleasant-nor-unpleasant (*adukkhamasukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
5. The dimension of boundless space: subtle, genuinely present perception of boundless space (*ākāsānañcāyatana-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
6. The dimension of infinite consciousness: subtle, genuinely present perception of the dimension of infinite consciousness (*viññāṇañcāyatana-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
7. The dimension of nothingness: subtle, genuinely present perception of the absence of anything (*ākiñcaññāyatana-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*). Here it is more precise not to say "the practitioner perceives absence," but rather that the process of subtle perception of absence itself remains.
8. The dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (*nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*): perception has become so subtle that it can no longer be definitely called either perception or the absence of perception. The Chinese parallel DĀ 28 speaks of the arising of perception of this dimension and, in the transition to cessation, calls the remaining perception "subtle" (微妙想): this subtle perception ceases without being replaced by a coarser one.

For the eighth stage, the Pali DN 9 does not give a parallel formula with *sukhuma-sacca-saññā*: the ladder ends with the dimension of nothingness, after which the text speaks of the limit of perception (*saññagga*). The Chinese parallel DĀ 28 continues the sequence with the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.

The cosmological framework can also be understood as indicating levels of clinging. At the sensual level, clinging arises to pleasant objects. In *rūpa* and *arūpa* dimensions, clinging is subtler: not to an object, but to a state such as peace, space, consciousness, the absence of everything, or the subtle sense "it is good to be here." Yet all of this remains conditioned.

From the Fourth Jhāna to the Dimension of Boundless Space

The appropriate moment arises when the fourth jhāna has matured and begins to end naturally: its "fuel" is running out, while clarity and one-pointedness still remain. During the jhāna itself, it is better not to try to switch the mind to something else. The transition becomes natural at the boundary where the fourth jhāna is ending.

Practice with the elements may be used separately as preparation for the transition. Its task is to see more deeply the composite nature of *rūpa* and cultivate a natural letting go of form. When the elements are recognized as conditioned processes and are no longer held on to, the grip on *rūpa* itself also weakens.

The space element can be recognized, for example, through the successive fading of the other elements. Earth, water, fire, and air are regarded as conditioned processes all the way to their cessation.

At first, space may still be perceived specifically as an element. For the transition to the first formless dimension, perceptions of form are completely left behind, and with a light intention to know boundless space, the transition takes place from the space element to the dimension of boundless space.

During the transition, there may be a sense of sudden opening or expansion: previously a bounded form was perceived, and then its boundaries are no longer held.

If contraction, expansion, movement, pressure, or "airiness" are still clearly felt afterward, this may indicate a continuing reliance on *rūpa*, in particular on the air element. In the

established dimension, space no longer needs to be expanded: no boundary is found.

Boundlessness, Unity, and Expansion

The canonical formula describes the transition as follows:

- *sabbaso rūpasaññānaṃ samatikkamā* — with the complete transcendence of perceptions of form;
- *paṭighasaññānaṃ atthaṅgamā* — with the disappearance of perceptions of resistance;
- *nānattasaññānaṃ amanasikārā* — with non-attention to perceptions of multiplicity.

Of practical importance is the connection between leaving multiplicity behind and boundlessness. The first formless dimension can be described in practical terms as a single boundless space: the multiplicity of forms has been left behind, the boundaries separating them are no longer found, and space is known as unified and boundless.

If Space "Freezes"

Sometimes, after coarse form has been left behind, space begins to be experienced as a motionless object that the mind seems to have discovered and is holding. There is no need to break this state by force. It is more useful to notice the holding itself and continue investigating the processes that arise within the attainment.

In AN 9.36, after attaining the dimension of boundless space, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa* are regarded as impermanent, unsatisfactory, disintegrating, empty, and "not self." Boundless space should therefore not become a new support or *attā*.

Residual bodily sensations may remain during the transition. If attention begins turning toward them again, *rūpa* may once more become a support. It is also important to notice tension, the urge to "enter" the dimension, and attempts to accelerate the transition: all of this should be let go.

Sensations do not need to be suppressed or forcibly removed. It is enough not to use them to sustain bodily form and to allow the mind to become established in boundless space.

Similar guidance is given to Moggallāna in SN 40.5.

If the Transition Does Not Come Together

In practice, it is useful to check several points.

1. **The fourth jhāna has not yet matured sufficiently.** If it is unstable, or an attempt to switch begins before its natural ending, the intention to move further turns into tension and disrupts collectedness.
2. **If intention has turned into pressure to achieve a result.** Intention itself does not obstruct practice. The problem arises when the attainment becomes a goal that must be reached as quickly as possible or "at any cost." Then craving and tension appear in place of letting go.
3. ***Rūpa* is not yet being let go naturally.** If attention repeatedly returns to the body, boundaries, pressure, movement, or other signs of form, it is more useful to continue insight into the elements separately than to keep forcing the transition.

4. **A "yo-yo" pattern develops and tension accumulates.** When the mind repeatedly almost lets go of form, then grasps it again and once more tries to make the transition, the practice begins to become tiring. If noticeable tension of mind or body remains after the session, this is a signal to stop pressing the transition, restore collectedness, and return to whatever condition still needs further development.

A Formless Dimension Is Not an Unconscious Shutdown

The formless attainments are not an unconscious shutdown. In AN 9.36, in the examination of the dimension of boundless space, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa* connected with it are listed, whereas *rūpa* is absent from the list.

The complete cessation of perception and feeling comes after the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.

As this dimension is mastered, freedom, lightness, and subtle pleasantness may arise because form has ceased to be the leading support.

Even freedom from form and the experience of boundlessness may support subtle craving and clinging. The dimension should be mastered well, without appropriating it or rushing toward the next one.

A brief touch of the dimension and mastery of it are not the same thing. Repeated entries make it possible to recognize more reliably what belongs to the formless dimension itself and what was a transitional residue of *rūpa*, tension, or clinging. A successful entry does not mean that clinging to *rūpa* has been abandoned once and for all.

The Dimension of All-Pervading Infinite Consciousness

In SN 16.9, the transition is described briefly: having completely transcended the dimension of boundless space and perceiving "consciousness is boundless," the practitioner enters and remains in the dimension of infinite consciousness.

From Space to Consciousness

The dimension of boundless space should first become stable and unfold sufficiently. The transition begins with a turn from space toward the process of knowing itself: it becomes clear that space is known, and attention turns toward awareness itself.

At first, the consciousness element (*viññāṇa-dhātu*) may be recognized. This is not yet the dimension of infinite consciousness: the element may become discernible without a transition into the corresponding *arūpa-āyatana*.

When space ceases to be the support, the process of awareness itself may become discernible. At first this may appear as "awareness of awareness," clarity, radiance, a sphere, or consciousness looping back on itself. When craving is present, consciousness may be experienced as a powerful "thermonuclear reactor." This is still *viññāṇa-dhātu*, or a transition toward *viññāṇañcāyatana*.

One Way of Entering: Catching the Arising of Contact

First, boundless space is clearly recognized as the present support. Then it becomes evident that this support too is conditioned: space is known, which means attention can turn from space itself toward the process of knowing and awareness. The consciousness element

(*viññāṇa-dhātu*) may become discernible. If the transition is sufficiently deep, the stage of "awareness of awareness" may pass quickly and collapse into awareness alone.

Next, one catches the moment just before *phassa* arises and, through perception, enters the very process of contact arising. A vast unified field of contacts, without a center, then opens. This is how entry into the dimension of infinite all-pervading consciousness occurs.

Another Way of Transitioning

In a deeply unfolded dimension of boundless space, a unified field of information may be experienced, while the connections within it are not yet distinguishable. As the transition to the dimension of infinite consciousness proceeds, space fades: first a single mental contact becomes distinguishable, then the entire field of contacts and interconnections. With further deepening, individual contacts cease to stand out, the interconnections are known as a single field, and everything is experienced as all-pervading infinite consciousness.

As the dimension opens, the multitude of contacts is no longer perceived as a set of separate events. The whole field opens simultaneously as a single all-pervading network without center or edge, beyond space and time. Loosely, it can be compared to a mycelium.

There is no division into "my" consciousness and the consciousness of "others": everything opens as one boundless field of contacts.

The intensity of this experience may increase as far as bright radiance or a sense of plasma. This is a figurative description of experience, not a literal account of what is happening. What remains essential is that infinite consciousness opens as an impersonal, conditioned, and interdependent process, not as a separate "I" or entity.

At the beginning of the dimension, *vedanā* may still remain. As it deepens, feeling, including neutral feeling, fades as disengagement from feeling becomes increasingly complete. A contact or external signal may still become distinguishable, but it no longer unfolds further into pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral *vedanā*.

Consciousness Without a Separate Observer

When the fading and conditionality of consciousness itself are seen clearly, the dimension of infinite consciousness can easily be mistaken for *Nibbāna*. Yet describing infinite consciousness itself as an "observer" or a separate *attā* is inaccurate here.

In a deeply unfolded dimension, there is no separate subject looking at the field of consciousness from outside, and no division into a separate "I" and separate "others." One all-pervading network of contacts is experienced: not "my consciousness observes the network," but consciousness itself unfolds as a common field of contacts.

Separateness appears in the further conditioned unfolding of experience. In the chain nourished by *avijjā*, at the level of *nāma-rūpa*, separate entities and processes come to be distinguished, after which they may be appropriated as "I," "mine," and "other." It is therefore important here to see the conditionality both of consciousness itself and of the subsequent arising.

The Dimension of Nothingness

In SN 16.9, after completely transcending the dimension of infinite consciousness, the practitioner perceives "there is nothing" and enters the dimension of nothingness.

From Consciousness to Nothingness

In SN 36.11, the cessation of the perception of the dimension of infinite consciousness is explicitly stated in connection with the dimension of nothingness. In practice, the former support fades, and "there is nothing" becomes predominant.

At the end of *viññāṇañcāyatana*, the unified field of consciousness fades. At first, the *dhātu* of nothingness may be discerned. As *samādhi* deepens with this *dhātu*, *ākiñcaññāyatana* unfolds. At the very beginning of the dimension, a subtle residue of consciousness may still remain, like a film over the nothingness. As the attainment deepens, it fades, leaving only subtle perception of the absence of anything.

Breathing and other processes do not cease here, but cease to be perceived. The absence of anything itself becomes so attractive that there is complete absorption in it, while interest in other processes fades because they are coarser. They may briefly manifest again as coarse phenomena without destroying the attainment. There is therefore no need deliberately to make breathing or other processes cease.

The dimension is experienced as the deepest peace and rest, pleasant in its own way, although *vedanā* is absent.

The transition to the next dimension may occur in different ways.

Sometimes subtle *saṅkhārā* become discernible within the dimension of nothingness. The very fact that they are perceived can serve as a support.

This can be compared to sitting in darkness at the bottom of the Mariana Trench while something passes nearby. Except that in darkness vision still perceives the darkness of closed eyelids, whereas here even that is absent: "whatever one reaches for — there is nothing."

Another route is connected with the subtle perception of absence itself: "there is nothing." This perception is present and can become a support for the transition to *nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*. In this sense, the dimension of nothingness already contains an element of the next dimension: extremely subtle perception.

There is no need to hurry toward the next attainment. In this dimension, the subtle perception of the absence of anything remains. With further deepening and refinement of perception, the transition to *nevasaññānāsaññāyatana* may begin.

Do Not Confuse It with *Nibbāna*

After form, space, and infinite consciousness have been relinquished as supports, the peace may become so deep that "there is nothing" is easily mistaken for final cessation. But the sequence of attainments continues with the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and then with the cessation of perception and feeling. The dimension of nothingness remains a conditioned attainment.

The Dimension of Neither-Perception-nor-Non-Perception

In *nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*, the definiteness "there is nothing" is no longer maintained. Perception becomes extremely subtle. At first, chaotic, primary, impersonal fluctuations are discerned, from which no formed experience has yet taken shape.

With further deepening, these fluctuations almost fade and remain only as potential. This phase is experienced as extraordinarily deep peace, greatly surpassing the peace of *ākiñcaññāyatana*. Perception here is so subtle that it cannot definitely be called either perception or the absence of perception.

What Remains When the Dimension of Neither-Perception-nor-Non-Perception Fades

As the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (*nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*) fades, even the extremely subtle perception ceases. Yet the potential for perception to arise and for further becoming still remains.

The pull toward renewed arising or continuation manifests as *bhava-taṇhā*. It does not necessarily take the form of the thought "I want to exist," but may be an almost imperceptible impulse: "may there be," "may it continue," "may it manifest."

When it is clear that further becoming is conditioned, impermanent, and *dukkha*, the opposite impulse may arise: instead of "may there be," "may there not be." This is how *vibhava-taṇhā* manifests.

If craving turns toward cessation itself - "I want *nirodha*," "may everything cease" - this is *nirodha-taṇhā*.

Why Pass Through All the Attainments

Each subsequent attainment reveals subtler processes in which clinging may still remain. The purpose of passing through them sequentially is to recognize and let go of that clinging.

If appropriation as "I" or "mine" remains at any level, conditions for *bhava* also remain. No attainment is therefore taken to be final liberation.

Asañña-bhava

The mere cessation of perception is not liberation. In *asañña-bhava*, *saññā* ceases, but *bhava* remains: the cessation of perception itself becomes a mode of existence. When perception arises again, clinging that has not been eliminated may continue the previous process.

Nirodha-samāpatti follows the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. In *asañña-bhava*, perception ceases within a persisting *bhava*; in *nirodha-samāpatti*, *saññā* and *vedanā* cease, and this cessation does not become a new mode of existence.

But *nirodha-samāpatti* is not identical with *Nibbāna*. In *nirodha-samāpatti*, *saññā* and *vedanā* cease, whereas *Nibbāna* is the complete absence of clinging to the five *khandhā*. After emergence, processes arise again; with the complete absence of clinging, they are not appropriated as "I" and "mine."

- *asañña-bhava* - perception ceases, while *bhava* remains;
- *nirodha-samāpatti* - *saññā* and *vedanā* cease without *bhava*;
- *Nibbāna* - the complete letting go of clinging to the five *khandhā*.

Nirodha-samāpatti is a temporary cessation of perception and feeling, not a separate field of experience. After emerging, the functioning of the mind resumes. Thus a temporary "switching off" is not *Nibbāna*.

What matters is not how long experience is absent, but wisdom that recognizes all arising processes as conditioned, impersonal, and impermanent. Ignorance and clinging do not disappear merely because experience has ceased for a time.

Three Meanings of *nirodha*

Meaning	What is meant
Cessation in *paṭiccasamuppāda*	With the cessation of a condition, the corresponding part of the chain ceases; for example, without *taṇhā*, *upādāna* is not nourished.
Nibbāna as cessation	The cessation of craving, clinging, greed, hatred, and delusion; not a temporary collapse of experience.
Saññāvedayitanirodha	The meditative cessation of perception and feeling, a subtle attainment that should not be confused with final liberation.

In AN 10.7: "The cessation of becoming is Nibbāna" (*bhavanirodho nibbānaṃ*).

What *nirodha-samāpatti* Gives

Nirodha-samāpatti is not *Nibbāna* and does not itself liberate. One enters and emerges from this attainment, so it remains conditioned.

In MN 44, entry into the cessation of perception and feeling and emergence from it are described. On emerging, the processes arise again, and it can be directly discerned how experience is assembled through conditions.

Nirodha-samāpatti and *Nibbāna* should not be identified with one another. The cessation of perception and feeling itself is not liberation.

Letting go of the five *khandhā* likewise does not mean destroying them. During life, body, feeling, perception/recognition, formations, and consciousness continue to arise through conditions. What matters is the cessation of their appropriation as "I" and "mine," and of the clinging connected with them.

On emerging from *nirodha-samāpatti*, their conditionality and impersonality can be seen especially clearly.

Prolonged abiding in *nirodha-samāpatti* is available only to an *anāgāmin* or an *arahant*; a *puthujjana*, *sotāpanna*, or *sakadāgāmin* can only briefly touch cessation.

Do Not Form Intention Toward Either Existence or Non-existence

MN 140 states the decisive principle: *neva taṃ abhisaṅkharoti, na abhisañcetayati bhavāya vā vibhavāya vā* - not to form and not to direct intention toward either *bhava* or *vibhava*. When the very formation of further becoming ceases, there is nothing left to sustain a new unfolding of experience. *Nirodha* is not attained by trying to make processes cease. Instead, the entire conditioned chain and its impersonal nature are traced and discerned.

This also applies to *taṇhā* itself: there is no need to try to extinguish it. One recognizes how *taṇhā* is sustained by *avijjā*: the conditioned is taken to be something that should be held on to, continued, or eliminated. From this, *upādāna* and *bhava* unfold, while the chain itself sustains *avijjā*.

The cessation of perception and feeling is attained after fully transcending the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. It should not be confused with the broader meaning of *nirodha*, which in the suttas also denotes the cessation of particular processes, craving, or suffering. In MN 43, the cessation of perception and feeling is explicitly distinguished from death: vitality and heat remain, and the faculties are not destroyed.

After any deep state, the criterion is one: are *taṇhā*, *māna*, *dosa*, fear, clinging, and ignorance decreasing?

False *Nibbāna*

Before the first direct contact with *Nibbāna*, a deep conditioned attainment may be mistaken for it: *ākiñcaññāyatana*, *nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*, or *saññāvedayitanirodha*. This is a misidentification of the attainment.

False *Nibbāna* is a mind-constructed state of silence, emptiness, or peace. It may seem like liberation, but processes are not recognized as they are.

If *sati* and *paññā* become dull together with the calm, and the arising, changing, and fading of processes cease to be distinguished, this is a conditioned state, not *Nibbāna*.

Nibbāna therefore cannot be recognized by silence, the absence of thoughts, stillness, or the cessation of perception. All of these are possible in conditioned attainments.

Nibbāna is not a special state of experience, but the cessation of clinging to arising processes. They are no longer appropriated as "I" and "mine" and do not become a basis for further *bhava*.

In *Nibbāna*, the eyes can be opened slightly while preserving the absence of clinging to the arising visual experience. This helps avoid associating *Nibbāna* with closed eyes.

Three Doors to the Unconditioned

SN 43.4 identifies emptiness concentration (*suññata*), signless concentration (*animitta*), and desireless concentration (*appaṇihita*; also undirected) as a path to the unconditioned. In MN 44, after emerging from the cessation of perception and feeling, emptiness, signless, and undirected contacts are listed.

SN 40.9, *animitta-samādhi* is described through *sabba-nimittānaṃ amanasikāra* — not directing attention to any *nimitta*.

In MN 43, conditions for the signless liberation of mind are named: attention is not directed toward the distinguishing marks of phenomena but toward signlessness. Abiding in it also requires a settled intention.

In practice, the three doors can be distinguished as follows:

- *suññata* — arising processes are recognized as empty of "I" and "mine" and as arising through conditions;
- *animitta* — *nimitta* is not grasped: any object that arises does not carry attention away and does not become a basis for further construction;
- *appaṇihita* — no *taṇhā* arises in relation to the arising experience: no urge to retain, continue, change, or end it.

The three doors may manifest separately or simultaneously. At first, it is better to unfold one door fully than to try all three at once. If another door unfolds, it does not need to be hindered. The same experience may be recognized as empty of "I," its *nimitta* may not be grasped, and no *taṇhā* may arise in relation to it.

Emptiness, signless, or desireless *samādhi* may be temporary. After emerging, appropriation, grasping of *nimitta*, or *taṇhā* may arise again.

Even after processes have been recognized as impersonal, a subtle support may remain: the standpoint of "pure seeing." This too is recognized and let go.

A Route to *Nibbāna*

1–4 *jhāna*
↓
5–8 *arūpa-āyatana*
↓
extremely subtle perception
↓
seeing the *taṇhā* that sustains the continuation of experience
↓
seeing with wisdom its conditioning by *avijjā* and its impersonal nature, without trying to extinguish anything
↓
saññāvedayitanirodha
↓
perception resumes
↓
the reverse unfolding of experience
↓
direct seeing of the conditioned and impersonal chain of processes
↓
the last subtle support - "pure seeing"
↓
letting go of "pure seeing"
↓
the emptiness door - *suññata*
↓
Nibbāna.

In practice, the route may differ somewhat, including the door through which it unfolds. What matters is not the mere fact of cessation, but directly seeing with wisdom how experience arises and ceases through conditions, without a separate "I." Stream-entry is connected with direct and deep seeing of the conditionality and impersonality of experience, not merely with understanding this as an idea.

Nibbāna is not paradise, another world, or the "other shore." Any "shore" that is seen, heard, felt, or thought of remains an experience arising in the mind through conditions. Outside the mind, there is no experience.

Liberation unfolds through wisdom: ignorance is seen as ignorance, craving as craving, clinging as clinging, and mind as mind. Their arising, conditionality, impermanence, and cessation are seen. When there is no appropriation or aversion, the nourishment of suffering ceases. Through such seeing, *Nibbāna* becomes accessible, but it does not become a new object or state of mind that can be retained.

After stream-entry, direct contact with *Nibbāna* is also possible through relinquishing clinging to the five *khandhā*, without necessarily repeating the entire sequence of jhānas and formless attainments. The jhānas should continue to be developed. As practice deepens, they unfold with new depth, and subtle points of attachment and blind spots become visible.

With stream-entry, the path is only beginning. Further practice deepens from clinging toward the *taṇhā* that feeds it. First, the arising and fading of clinging to the five *khandhā* are seen, and then the arising and fading of *taṇhā* itself.

Then *avijjā* is investigated: what remains unrecognized, why craving and clinging arise again through conditions, and how ignorance is nourished. It is important to see not just individual defilements, but also what conceals the very fact that they have not been recognized.

After a meditative abiding in *Nibbāna* at an intermediate stage of the path, the mind is temporarily purified, and *paññā* can unfold more freely.

As *paññā* unfolds, processes are recognized ever more deeply and ignorance weakens. In an arahant, wisdom is immeasurable: if a defilement begins to arise, it is immediately recognized together with its conditions and the way it ceases.

20. Formal Practice and Practice in Daily Life

Refuge in the Three Jewels

Taking refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha means consciously choosing the Three Jewels as the central orientation of one's life and practice. The Buddha is seen as the teacher who discovered and fully realized the path; the Dhamma as the teaching and practice leading to the cessation of *dukkha*; and the noble Saṅgha as the example of those who have realized the path. A community of practitioners can provide spiritual support and companionship in practice.

In SN 45.2, good friendship, companionship, and association are called the whole of the spiritual life, because they create favorable conditions for developing the Noble Eightfold Path. A good friend can help one hear the Dhamma, see one's mistakes, and continue practicing, but understanding and walking the path remain each person's own task.

A community can be an important support for practice, but it should not become a new object of *upādāna*.

Refuge strengthens confidence, inspiration, and stability, especially amid fear, doubt, or loss of direction. In SN 11.3, recollection of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha helps overcome fear. In AN 11.11, recollection of the Buddha straightens the mind, followed by joy, tranquility, and collectedness.

The Dhamma and Vinaya as Teacher

In DN 16, the Buddha says that after his departure the Dhamma and Vinaya will be the teacher of his followers. This does not mean blindly following systems or one's own ideas. Practice relies on the Dhamma, discipline, and the testing of fruits: what leads to the reduction of *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, to clarity and gentleness, and to liberation from *dukkha*?

It is therefore useful to observe one's own experience attentively: notice which conditions make the mind clearer, calmer, and kinder, and which lead to heaviness and hindrances. Such investigation remains within the Dhamma: it seeks not a special state, but conditions under which the chain receives less nourishment.

When Explaining the Dhamma Is Appropriate

It is useful to test the depth of one's understanding by the ability to explain the Dhamma clearly and respond to objections. If a question reveals a gap, that gap needs to be investigated rather than defending one's opinion out of pride or irritation.

But it matters not only what to say, but also to whom, when, and how much. Sometimes it is better to remain silent. Sometimes a person sincerely seeks a way out of suffering and is ready to listen; then silence may become an unwholesome action. Explanations should be offered for benefit, not for victory in argument. The listener perceives what is said through their own *saṅkhārā*, notions, and tendencies. They will hear what they are ready or wish to hear.

Technique and the Conditions of Practice

In MN 39, the four jhānas are presented as part of gradual training. Their preparation consists of purity of conduct and livelihood, guarding the sense doors, moderation in eating, wakefulness, recollection and clear comprehension, seclusion, and abandonment of the five hindrances.

This sequence should not be understood as a rigid staircase on which each stage must be fully mastered before the next is approached. It shows that *samādhi* does not arise from a single meditation technique, but rests on one's whole way of life and practice. Many conditions for collectedness are formed outside the meditation session and then support practice within it. Wakefulness and diligence do not mean deliberate sleep deprivation or exhaustion. What matters is moderation, clarity, and a reasonable attitude toward the body, not trying to force collectedness through excessive tension.

When overloaded, after a break in practice, or when prolonged sitting turns into a struggle against oneself, it is wiser to begin with short but regular sessions. Their length can gradually increase as stability develops naturally.

A technique is not an end in itself. Its usefulness is determined by whether *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha* lessen; whether the hindrances and the arising of *taṇhā* after *vedanā* are recognized more clearly; whether collectedness strengthens; and whether clinging to experiences weakens.

Understanding the Idea and Seeing the Process

Intellectually understanding *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā* does not yet mean seeing them directly in experience through wisdom. One may know that a phenomenon is impermanent and impersonal while continuing to cling to it.

What must be seen is the process itself: what it depends on, where *taṇhā* arises, and what happens when clinging is no longer sustained.

Such seeing requires sufficient *sati* and *samādhi*. Without them, investigation easily turns into reasoning about what is already known and becomes a basis for views.

When conditionality, impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and impersonality are seen clearly, letting go follows from that seeing.

Seeing things as they are is not limited to meditation. In conversation, work, decisions, and habitual activities, feelings, intentions, craving, clinging, and arising roles of "I" must also be seen. It is not enough to mentally run through the links of dependent origination; what matters is recognizing processes in life itself, especially when a previous reaction arises again.

Tuning Effort

Meditation should not become the forceful holding of an object, but neither is it passive waiting for calm. In AN 6.55, effort is compared to tuning strings: excessive tension leads to

restlessness, while insufficient energy leads to dullness. Effort is adjusted so that the mind remains alert but not constricted.

Excessive effort may be sustained by craving: the urge to achieve a result more quickly, deepen a state, or hold on to it. But unwillingness to make an effort may also arise from aversion.

It is important to see what conditions tension, lethargy, and the intention to act. There is no need either to force oneself or to indulge defilements. If the body is genuinely tired, it needs rest.

A pleasant bodily sensation may sometimes serve as a support for calming. If relaxation turns into drowsiness, it may help to straighten up or half-open the eyes; if tension arises, relax control and allow breathing to proceed naturally.

A useful image: attention can rest on a bodily sensation as a seal rests on the shore  , steady and relaxed, without trying to squeeze a desired state out of what is happening.

It is not necessary to achieve a complete absence of thoughts. A thought may arise and fade on its own without interfering with practice. As the mind calms naturally and wisdom develops, thoughts arise less often and fade more easily.

Progress is seen in distractions being noticed earlier, pulling less strongly, and the return becoming easier and more natural. A thought is seen simply as a thought, without needing to elaborate it further.

Do Not Measure Practice Only by Attainments

Meditation should not be regarded as unsuccessful merely because no jhāna, rapture, or especially clear state arose. If the right direction was maintained, distractions noticed, hindrances recognized, and attention returned to the meditation object, the session was not fruitless. Sometimes its result lies not in an unusual experience, but in distraction being seen more clearly, a habitual reaction not being continued, or the mind calming even briefly. Experience gradually accumulates, and the hindrances are recognized earlier and more precisely.

Jhānas are conditioned: they arise not merely at the practitioner's wish, but when the necessary conditions come together and the hindrances temporarily subside. A person may work honestly every day without receiving wages after every single hour. Likewise, especially calm and deep meditation may be prepared by many ordinary and sometimes difficult sessions. The task is therefore not to squeeze a desired result out of each meditation, but patiently to cultivate its conditions without craving and frustration.

If exhaustion, severe tension, or deterioration regularly remain after practice, this should not be justified by saying "every session is useful." The duration, object, or method should be reconsidered.

It may also be useful to imagine that this is the last opportunity to practice in this life. If only one hour remained, would it be worth spending it on habitual fantasies, arguments, and plans? This recollection should not produce fear or tension. Its purpose is to cut through what is secondary and return to practice.

In AN 6.19, the Buddha offers an even sharper recollection of death: practice with the understanding that life may last only until the next morsel of food, or the next in-breath and out-breath. The value of this reflection is not gloom, but the development of a sense of urgency and attentiveness.

In AN 8.29, the opportunity to hear the Dhamma leading to *Nibbāna* and to be capable of understanding it is called a rare favorable opportunity.

Dhp 276 reminds us that the Tathāgatas only point out the path; it must be walked by oneself.

While such an opportunity is present, it is more important to practice the Dhamma than endlessly compare teachings, argue, seek entertainment, and accumulate knowledge that does not lead to the cessation of *dukkha*.

Setbacks and the Nonlinearity of the Path

Practice does not always proceed linearly. Periods of clarity and collectedness may be followed by the return of old reactions and clinging.

Sometimes this makes visible a process that had previously remained hidden: a fear, a view, a role, or another point of attachment.

There is no need either to get stuck in that state or to cling to the previous clarity. It is more useful to examine the conditions, see how the arisen process is sustained, and where clinging appears.

Patience Does Not Mean Inaction

When a condition cannot presently be changed without harm, patience helps one not add a second dart to pain. But when danger, overload, or an unwholesome situation can reasonably be changed, such action is also part of practice.

Accepting the fact "this is how it is now" therefore does not mean deciding "let it remain this way." Recollection helps one see what is happening more clearly and choose the less harmful course.

Monasticism and Lay Life

Monasticism can create favorable conditions for practice: simplifying daily life, reducing distractions, and supporting ethical discipline. Monastic status by itself, however, does not liberate and does not replace development of the Noble Eightfold Path.

Taking up monastic life also does not erase previous *kamma* or cancel the possible ripening of its results. Lay life in itself does not obstruct the path. Everyday life and interaction with different people provide many conditions for observation and training. What matters is organizing life so that they support the path rather than crowding it out.

In the society of the Buddha's time, a person's life was determined to a great extent by family, household duties, and social position. Today many people can organize their work, relationships, and way of life more freely, leaving enough space for practice.

Stricter restrictions can support practice when they reduce hindrances and distraction. But a layperson does not need to keep trying to live as a monastic at all times. This can have the opposite effect and become a source of tension and clinging to the image of a "proper practitioner."

An external restriction can remove a condition for habitual clinging, but it does not replace seeing how that clinging arises, is sustained, and ceases.

Liberation does not mean the cessation of sensory experience or a transition to an ascetic way of life. Pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā*, bodily and mental reactions may arise through conditions. Tasty food, music, physical exercise, sex, and other aspects of lay life may likewise occur through conditions.

What cease are *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and the appropriation of experience: what occurs is not held on to, pushed away, or turned into "I" and "mine."

Leaving behind the raft of the Dhamma after the path is complete does not mean rejecting the Dhamma or violating ethical precepts. An outward way of life does not by itself show the presence or absence of liberation. What matters is the abandoning of craving and clinging and seeing phenomena in accordance with the Dhamma.

In AN 9.7, the passage specifically concerns an arahant bhikkhu. For such a person, intentional killing, theft, sexual intercourse, and lying are impossible.

A Lay *Arahant* Does Not Have to Die Within Seven Days

The early suttas do not say that after attaining arahantship a layperson must, within a specified period, enter monastic life or attain *parinibbāna*. In the *Milindapañha*, a later text, a claim appears that such a person must go forth that same day or attain *parinibbāna*. In the later commentarial tradition, the idea of a seven-day limit also occurs.

Liberation does not cut off the conditioned functioning of the body or make monastic status a condition for its continuation. As long as the conditions for the body's continued life remain, conditioned processes continue. Whether one enters monastic life does not determine any such time limit.

There is likewise no basis for treating monasticism as the obligatory outward form of an *arahant*'s life. The early corpus was preserved largely in a monastic environment and predominantly describes monastic practice. This bias in the sources does not turn the absence of detailed accounts of lay *arahants* into a rule that such a life is impossible.

Monasticism can be a favorable condition for practice, but liberation is defined by the cessation of *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *avijjā*, not by clothing, status, or place of residence.

What matters is not the number of restrictions, but whether craving, clinging, and suffering are decreasing.

Not About Sainthood

The cessation of *dukkha* should not be understood as turning into a "saint" in the ordinary religious sense: a special personality, a special spiritual entity, or an ideal image of a practitioner. In the Dhamma, the point is not to create a new spiritual image, but to abandon craving, clinging, becoming, and ignorance.

Ethical conduct is necessary as a condition of the path: without it, the mind is full of remorse, conflict, and agitation. Unwholesome actions create conditions that obstruct practice. But the goal of the path is not to construct a new identity, "I am holy" or "I am realized." The goal is that greed, hatred, and delusion no longer govern the mind and the chain of suffering is no longer fed.

Posture for Sitting Meditation

In MN 10, the Buddha describes the beginning of sitting meditation as follows:

> *araññagato vā rukkhamūlagato vā suññāgāragato vā nisīdati, pallaṅkaṁ ābhujitvā, ujuṁ kāyaṁ paṇidhāya, parimukhaṁ satiṁ upaṭṭhapetvā*

That is, the practitioner goes to a forest, the foot of a tree, or an empty shelter; sits down with the legs folded in *pallaṅka*; holds the body upright; and establishes recollection before oneself / to the fore.

Pallaṅkaṁ ābhujitvā indicates sitting cross-legged; it may be rendered as sitting as in a palanquin. More important, however, are suitable conditions for practice: a quiet or secluded place, a stable and comfortable posture, an upright back, and recollection. If the body does not permit cross-legged sitting without pain and unnecessary tension, another posture may be used, such as sitting on a chair.

Practice in the Moment

When something has caught hold, one can begin with three questions:

1. What *phassa* arose?
2. What *vedanā* arose?
3. What *taṇhā* is manifesting?

Going further:

4. Where does *upādāna* arise?
5. What *bhava* is forming?
6. Where does this chain lead?

Retrospective Practice

Choose a single episode and break it down:

- Contact.
- Feeling.
- Craving.
- Clinging.
- Becoming.
- Birth of a role.
- Cost of the role.
- Where could the chain have been left unfed?

After deep practice, it is useful to write down significant observations at once, before the details fade.

Over time, the chain will be recognized earlier.

21. Ignorance (*avijjā*)

Under ignorance, the conditionality of existence is not seen: how processes arise and cease, why the same reactions recur, and how craving and clinging sustain further births and death.

In SN 15.1, the Buddha says:

> "A beginning of saṃsāra cannot be discovered. Beings, obscured by ignorance and bound by craving, wander again and again from birth to birth."

In SN 12.2, ignorance (*avijjā*) is defined as not knowing the Four Noble Truths: suffering, its arising, its cessation, and the path leading to its cessation.

What Exactly Is Not Seen

Under ignorance, the following remain unrecognized:

- the arising, changing, and cessation of the five aggregates;
- their impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self nature;

- dependent origination: the conditions from which contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, and subsequent birth come together;
- recurring tendencies and reactions that manifest again under similar conditions;
- past births and the cycle of birth, aging, illness, and death common to them;
- ignorance itself: what precisely is not being seen now, and why it remains unseen.

A person may remember the twelve links and yet not see how they operate in a particular experience. Knowing the names does not replace seeing arising and cessation.

Repetition of Tendencies and Not Seeing Past Lives

In MN 79, Udāyin says to the Buddha:

> "I cannot recall in every detail even what I experienced in this very life. How, then, could I recall numerous past births as the Blessed One does?"

Without seeing repeated births, losses, and deaths, the full scale of saṃsāra cannot be recognized.

The causes of present reactions may reach far beyond this life. Present experience is composed of many conditions, including the consequences of previous intentional actions (*kamma*). Seeing previous births helps one understand how actions and formations (*saṅkhārā*) condition subsequent reactions and becoming (*bhava*).

Dependent origination thus becomes clear: how ignorance sustains craving and clinging, how habitual reactions generate new causes and conditions, continuing *dukkha*. Investigating past births develops wisdom, helps recognize the hidden causes of defilements, and removes obstacles on the path.

Yet knowledge of past lives alone does not liberate. There is no need to reconstruct the entire history of births or "work off" all *kamma*. What matters is seeing how conditioned processes arise, what sustains them, and how they cease as ignorance, craving, and clinging fade.

The same tendency manifests in different circumstances: fear of losing the body, the desire to retain what is pleasant, the urge to control, unwillingness to see the unpleasant, or the demand to bring back the past. Circumstances change, but under similar conditions the reaction recurs. Intentional formations (*saṅkhārā*) also arise through conditions and take part in the continuation of dependent origination.

When only the segment of the present life is visible, a new existence seems a desirable continuation, and its cessation seems a loss. Thus even intense pain does not, by itself, eliminate craving for life: without recognizing the recurring cycle of suffering, a being continues to cling to existence.

Ignorance creates a sense of novelty and specialness about the present existence: "I am special," "we humans are special." Each life seems something new and unrepeatable because countless former births remain hidden.

It is not seen that, as bodies and circumstances change, the same craving, fear of loss, and clinging arise again and again. Thus each new existence is perceived as an opportunity finally to find satisfaction, although in reality the previous cycle of *dukkha* continues.

How Ignorance Conceals Dependent Origination

Fear, desire, irritation, fogginess, or a new idea about oneself may be noticed without seeing how, and under what conditions, all this arose. For example, an unpleasant feeling is already present, and a person takes the craving that arises after it to end the unpleasantness as their own will. Clinging seems a necessity, and becoming appears as a stable "I."

Ignorance does not stand outside this chain and does not control it as a separate being. It itself arises through conditions, influences subsequent processes, and receives nourishment from them.

The mind can construct "what if" scenarios, imagining future misfortunes and experiencing them as if they were already happening. Yet nothing happens simply "out of nowhere": everything arises from causes and conditions.

Fear is sustained by ignorance of this interdependence, by craving to avoid what is unpleasant, and by clinging to an imagined future. It is important to see anxiety as a conditioned process, distinguish actual circumstances from assumptions, and act as necessary without feeding defilements.

Ignorance of Ignorance Itself

The first layer: craving, clinging, or the cessation of a process is not seen. The second: it goes unnoticed that this has remained unseen. Then a guess is taken for knowledge, and the loss of clarity for an ordinary state of mind.

As long as the causes of a reaction remain unrecognized, it arises again under similar conditions.

Ignorance does not disappear on its own. Neither time, a change of circumstances, nor prolonged calm of mind can eradicate it. Craving and clinging may temporarily cease to manifest, but that does not mean the causes of their arising have been removed. As long as ignorance remains, they arise again when suitable conditions occur.

Ignorance is eliminated only by wisdom: directly seeing processes as they are. It is important to recognize not just craving or clinging that has arisen, but also why they arise, what sustains them, and how they cease. One must gain insight into ignorance itself, its causes and conditions, rather than merely wait for defilements to pass or achieve temporary calm.

The idea "things are bad here, but they will be good there" can become a support for craving. The place, occupation, or social surroundings change, but craving and clinging that have not been understood arise again. New conditions can aid practice, but changing the scenery does not eliminate ignorance.

Sometimes the mind fears even the cessation of ignorance: "if this fog disappears, I too will disappear." In this way, a familiar defilement is perceived as protection. It is important to see this fear as a process of mind rather than identify with it.

Fog, Blurriness, and Fatigue

Fog.

Clarity is lost. Thoughts, feelings, and reactions continue, but it is difficult to see their causes, connections, and cessation. Mental obscuration (*moha*), lethargy, and drowsiness may manifest in this way.

Blurriness.

Facts are partly visible, yet the missing connections are filled in with assumptions. Attention selects confirmations of a familiar picture and misses what contradicts it. This is how unwise direction of attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*) operates.

Fatigue.

Lack of sleep and physical exhaustion also impair clarity. If the body is exhausted, rest is needed first. But fatigue is not the same as ignorance: it is important to distinguish fatigue from the absence of clear seeing.

In AN 10.61, the five hindrances are called nourishment for ignorance.

Why Separate Processes Seem to Be One "I"

Thoughts, feelings, intentions, and states of mind succeed one another. When their cessation is not noticed and a new experience is perceived as "mine," an impression arises of a continuous "I" to which all this belongs.

In a new situation, the previous appropriation repeats: "I suffer," "I control," "I gain insight," "I must stop this." From clinging, the corresponding becoming (*bhava*) takes shape. What needs to be investigated with wisdom is the arising of this role itself, its conditions, and its cessation.

When Suffering Is Mistaken for Happiness

AN 4.49 names four distortions of perception, mind, and views: taking the impermanent to be permanent, suffering to be happiness, what is not-self to be "self," and the unattractive to be beautiful.

Under ignorance, a habit of constantly comparing what is happening with how it supposedly ought to be may persist: "I do not have enough," "others have it better," "once I get what I want, things will be good."

When ideas are taken for reality, discontent, envy, or aversion arises. Craving urges one to obtain what is missing, change circumstances, or get rid of what is unpleasant.

With clinging comes appropriation: "I lack something," "I am worse than others," "I must achieve more." Thus the image of an "I" that is always lacking something is sustained.

Even obtaining what is desired does not eliminate this tendency. Satisfaction is impermanent, circumstances change, and as long as ignorance remains, comparison, discontent, and craving recur.

It is important to see directly how comparison, the feeling of dissatisfaction, craving, and clinging arise, distinguishing their causes and conditions. There is no need to suppress discontent or try to convince oneself that everything is fine. What is happening must be recognized as it is, without taking notions for reality or sustaining appropriation.

Under ignorance, even suffering can be perceived as satisfactory. Clinging to the continuation of "I" can be so strong that even the most agonizing suffering seems preferable to the cessation of the existence of this "I."

In SN 22.27, the Buddha instructs one to see the attractive aspect of the five aggregates, their danger, and the escape from them. In a painful cycle, one needs to recognize what still seems satisfactory and for the sake of what it is repeated.

When confronted with *dukkha*, the mind seeks to be rid of it as quickly as possible: to distract itself, suppress the unpleasant, shut itself off from what is happening, or convince itself that everything is fine. This may provide temporary relief, but it does not remove the causes of suffering. On the contrary, craving to get rid of the unpleasant and clinging to a desired state sustain further *dukkha*.

It is important to see *dukkha* as *dukkha*, without trying to hide or destroy it. Recognize the unpleasant feeling itself, the aversion that arises, craving for cessation, and appropriation as

"I am suffering." See the causes and conditions of these processes, their arising and fading, without sustaining further clinging.

At the same time, there is no need to endure harm, ignore illness, or refrain from changing unfavorable conditions.

Even satisfaction is a conditioned process: it arises, changes, and ceases. Clinging to satisfaction itself becomes a condition for *dukkha* when the experience changes or ceases.

Influxes, Clinging, and Becoming

In MN 9, the mutual conditionality of the influxes (*āsava*) and ignorance is shown. Under ignorance, the conditions for sensual craving, the desire to continue existing, and clinging to views remain. These processes, in turn, sustain ignorance.

MN 2 names *kāmāsava*, *bhavāsava*, and *avijjāsava*; *diṭṭhāsava* also appears elsewhere. It is important to see *kāmāsava* not in feelings themselves, but in the influx of sensual craving directed toward experience.

A pleasant feeling arises through its own conditions. By itself, it is not yet craving or clinging. But under ignorance, an urge to retain, intensify, or repeat the pleasant may arise. Craving becomes a condition for appropriating the experience: "my feeling," "I want more." Thus clinging is activated and *bhava* is sustained.

Likewise, craving may be directed toward the continuation of existence (*bhavāsava*) or toward holding on to views (*diṭṭhāsava*). The influx of ignorance (*avijjāsava*) conceals the arising and operation of craving itself.

The darkness of ignorance is vast. Even after long practice, the influxes (*āsava*) can obscure clarity for a long time and again give rise to craving, clinging, and *bhava*.

When, through wisdom, ignorance is seen as ignorance, craving as craving, and an influx as an influx, they are neither appropriated nor held on to. Their natural fading can then be seen: every arisen process is impermanent.

Identification with these processes and clinging to them, by contrast, sustain their continuation and produce *dukkha*.

Clinging may also arise around practice itself: "my jhāna," "my insight," "I attained," "I absolutely must be liberated." In MN 1, appropriation is described even in relation to the conception of Nibbāna. Deep collectedness does not replace wisdom if clinging remains unrecognized.

How to Investigate Ignorance

The work begins with a particular process, not with an attempt to encompass all ignorance at once.

1. **See change.** A state arose, changes, and then ceases. What was happening before it appeared?
2. **Find the conditions.** Through what causes and conditions did this process arise, and through what causes and conditions is it sustained?
3. **See the blind spot.** What remains unrecognized: unpleasant feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, the cessation of the process, or the very absence of clarity? What conditions sustain this ignorance?

4. **Investigate appropriation.** If "I must gain insight," "I am in control," or "I do not want to cease" arises, how did this role come together, and for what purpose is it sustained?
5. **See interdependence.** What conditions give rise to the process, which ones perpetuate it, and what changes when those conditions cease?
6. **Apply the Four Noble Truths.** Where is suffering here, what nourishes it, what is its cessation, and what leads to its cessation?

22. Choice: the Buddha's Path or Māra's Path

The Dhamma is not separate from life. Jhānas and other practices do not by themselves determine the path. Its direction is revealed in the choice: to sustain *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, and the construction of "I", or to move toward abandoning them. This is the choice between Māra's path and the Buddha's path.

The choice is visible above all in action, not in words. One may regard the Dhamma as the main concern of one's life and yet, in a specific situation, sustain clinging, a habitual role, or becoming. It is in situations of life that the direction actually chosen becomes visible.

Choice arises as the meeting of different *saṅkhārā*: some lead to the continuation of the previous becoming, others toward letting go. It therefore does not stand outside dependent origination, but itself arises through conditions and becomes a condition for the subsequent process.

The path is not reducible to a technique. The material of practice is the experience of the five *khandhā* itself: what arises through conditions in body, feelings, perception, formative processes, and consciousness. What arises does not need to be blocked or forced; it needs to be recognized and investigated.

A fork arises: turn away from what has been seen and return to habitual *bhava*, or continue to see what is happening as it is. The mere appearance of this fork does not mean leaving the path. What matters is what is sustained next.

Choice cannot be postponed indefinitely. Conditions continue to change, and delay itself becomes part of the process. Until arahantship, new influxes and *bhava* can still arise regardless of the depth of *samādhi* and other attainments.

In SN 4.17, the bhikkhus listen to the Dhamma as a matter of vital importance, after which Māra tries to distract them. The path continues outside formal practice as well, in situations of life where a choice arises.

To see things as they are is not simply to distinguish the pleasant from the unpleasant, but to avoid deceiving oneself about what is happening. There is no need to embellish the unpleasant, disparage the pleasant, or convince oneself that everything should be perceived in the same way. Flowers are seen as flowers, and shit as shit.

But wisdom is not confined to recognizing the phenomenon itself. It is important also to see what happens in the mind: what feelings, perceptions, intentions, craving, and clinging arise. Where does direct experience end and its interpretation begin? Where does the pleasant become a desire to retain it, and the unpleasant an urge to get rid of it? Where does appropriation arise: "this is mine," "I want," "this should not happen to me"?

To see things as they are means to recognize every arising process, without exception, rather than fitting it to one's expectations, beliefs, or ideas of correct practice. Even one's own ignorance, self-deception, and desire to see things differently must be recognized for what they are.

Wisdom reveals the conditionality, impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and impersonality of processes. It is important to see how they arise, what sustains them, and how they cease, without appropriating or holding on to them.

Reality is what remains when you stop believing in it. Phenomena arise and cease according to their own causes and conditions, regardless of what we think of them.

To see things as they are means not replacing what is happening with one's own ideas, expectations, and judgments. These very ideas are also conditioned processes of mind, which need to be recognized without taking them for reality or clinging to them.

When a choice arises, it is already conditioned by the causes and conditions that have come together. In essence, it has already been made, even if the mind continues to waver.

Dukkha arises when clinging appears: wanting to obtain one thing without losing another and to avoid the consequences. The mind tries to sit on two chairs at once, unwilling to let go of either.

It is important to see the choice itself, doubts, craving, and clinging as conditioned processes. There is no need to hold on to incompatible possibilities or demand that what is happening be otherwise.

Where Māra Has No Place: SN 4.19

> **Māra:** "The eye is mine, ascetic, forms are mine, the field of consciousness connected with eye-contact is mine. Where will you escape from me? The ear is mine, the nose is mine, the tongue is mine, the body is mine…
> The mind is mine, ascetic, mental phenomena are mine, the field of consciousness connected with mind-contact is mine. Where will you escape from me?"
>
> **The Buddha:** "The eye is yours, Evil One, forms are yours, the field of consciousness connected with eye-contact is yours. But where there is no eye, no forms, and no such field of consciousness, you have no access. Likewise with the ear, nose, tongue, and body.
> The mind is yours, Evil One, mental phenomena are yours, the field of consciousness connected with mind-contact is yours. But where there is no mind, no mental phenomena, and no such field of consciousness, you have no access, Evil One."

Māra asserts that there is no escape for one who regards all of this as one's own. The Buddha replies that he regards it as neither "mine" nor "I," and Māra will not see even a trace of his path.

Mind is included among the six fields alongside eye and ear. Even thoughts and observation do not become a separate entity that owns the rest of experience.

Saṃsāra as a Bucket of Crabs

When one crab tries to climb out of a bucket, the others cling to it and pull it back. Similarly, beings themselves caught in ignorance, craving, and clinging can keep one another in saṃsāra.

When a person begins to relinquish former attachments, they may encounter expectations from those around them: "be like everyone else," "stay the way you were," "don't leave us." Fear of losing relationships, approval, or belonging to a familiar circle can also sustain clinging and hinder liberation.

On meeting someone, an old role may arise again: "everyone must like me," "I must not offend anyone," "I have to remain the same." Out of fear of losing approval, a person stays

silent, gives in, or continues inappropriate contact, then suffers from accumulated dissatisfaction.

One can calmly and directly say "no," set boundaries, or end a conversation without hostility. At the same time, it is important to see the feeling, fear, intention, and clinging to one's self-image. After the interaction, there is no need to sustain a new role: "I offended someone," "they misunderstood me," "I proved my point to everyone."

Seclusion can help practice. But the desire to isolate oneself is sometimes fed by fear of unpleasant encounters and the idea that "everyone around me is hostile." It is important to distinguish reasonable limits on contact from clinging.

This does not mean that all connections with people must be broken. What matters is relinquishing those relationships and forms of interaction that sustain craving and clinging and obstruct progress on the path.

Even the path itself can be used to reinforce *bhava*. "I am a practitioner," "I am virtuous," "I am an attainer," "I am a Buddhist" - these are the same forms of appropriation, only constructed around the Dhamma.

The path is directed not toward improving this construction, but toward the complete cessation of sustaining it. The intention to reach *Nibbāna* should therefore not turn into a new spiritual identity.

A False Fork: Layperson or Monastic

The choice between lay and monastic life does not by itself determine the path. Monasticism changes the conditions of life and discipline, but does not automatically eliminate *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, or *bhava*. Choices between clinging and letting go continue to arise there as well.

The same applies to lay life. Work, relationships, everyday affairs, and other circumstances do not stand outside the Dhamma. What matters is not whether a monastic way of life has been adopted, but what is sustained in concrete situations: further clinging or its abandonment.

A Calm Intention to Go All the Way

The intention to go all the way to the end of the path should remain clear, but without craving for the result. Practice should continue without haste, while arising choices should not be postponed.

Practice should not be postponed. Circumstances change, favorable conditions may disappear, and unrecognized tendencies continue to be nourished.

Changing one's home, surroundings, work, or way of life can make practice easier, but does not in itself eliminate *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, or *upādāna*. Unwholesome intentional actions have consequences; latent tendencies can manifest even after external circumstances have changed.

One should not wait for defilements or the consequences of past actions to "work themselves out." Practice should be undertaken now, while the opportunity remains, so that later one does not regret having squandered favorable conditions.

Interest and diligence are not in themselves *taṇhā*. Action can be energetic and attentive, without haste, self-assertion, or craving for a result.

Intermediate fruits do not replace complete liberation. After stream-entry, further development of the path does not cease. Until arahantship, uneliminated *āsava* and *avijjā* remain.

Stream-entry, *sakadāgāmi*, and *anāgāmi* are therefore not places to stop, but stages in the further movement toward complete liberation.

In MN 16, the aspiration to lead the holy life for the sake of rebirth among the gods is named as one of the five *cetaso vinibandha* - bonds of the mind. Such an aspiration does not lead to diligence, continuation of practice, or effort.

The aim of the path is not to make existence within *saṃsāra* more comfortable, but to free arising processes from "I" and "mine," so that they no longer become a basis for clinging and *bhava*.

23. Worksheets

Worksheet 1: the Unpleasant

1. What happened?
2. What was the *phassa*?
3. What was the *vedanā*?
4. What was the *taṇhā*?
5. What is wanted from the object or action: relief, control, aliveness, flow, belonging, fantasy, or escape from dissatisfaction?
6. What happens to the feeling, bodily impulse, and mental story if the pull is not given its habitual nourishment for a short time?
7. What is the *upādāna*?
8. What is the *bhava*?
9. What "I" was born?
10. What is the cost of this state?
11. Where can the chain be broken?

Worksheet 2: the Pleasant

1. What pleasant experience arose?
2. How did the body feel it?
3. Was there a wish to prolong, repeat, or secure it?
4. What self-image is forming?
5. Did dependence on recognition, taste, success, or a state arise?
6. Can the pleasant be allowed to end without residual hunger?

Worksheet 3: Desire

1. What does the desire promise?
2. What does it want to remove or obtain?
3. Are fatigue, anxiety, boredom, loneliness, or pain behind it?
4. What will happen if it is indulged automatically?
5. What will happen if it is suppressed?
6. What does the middle way look like: understand, do not feed, choose?

Worksheet 4: *samādhi*

1. Which hindrance was predominant before practice?
2. Did calming occur naturally, or was it achieved through tension?
3. Did pleasantness arise naturally, or through an attempt to reproduce it?
4. Did clarity remain together with calm?
5. Which conditions helped collectedness arise?
6. Which hindrances were absent, and which merely quieted temporarily?
7. After practice, did it become easier to recognize *vedanā* - *taṇhā*?

8. Did clinging to repetition, comparison, attainment, or status arise?
9. What should be developed next without turning practice into a hunt for a state?

Worksheet 5: Speech and Action

This worksheet follows the general logic of MN 61: examine an action before, during, and after it.

Before the Action

1. What am I about to say or do?
2. What intention is driving the action: goodwill, protection, irritation, the desire to win, to obtain approval, or to avoid the unpleasant?
3. Could the action cause harm to me, another person, or both?
4. Can a reasonable aim be achieved in a less harmful way?

During the Action

5. What is happening in body and mind right now?
6. Are craving, hostility, or confusion becoming stronger?
7. What consequences are already visible?
8. Should I continue, change the manner of acting, or stop?

After the Action

9. What are the actual consequences for me, other people, and relationships?
10. Did they match what the mind expected?
11. If the action was unwholesome, what should be acknowledged, repaired, or not repeated?
12. What condition should be changed before a similar situation in the future?

24. Short Reminders

Five Frequent Recollections

AN 5.57 lists five themes for frequent recollection:

- I am subject to aging and have not gone beyond aging;
- I am subject to illness and have not gone beyond illness;
- I am subject to death and have not gone beyond death;
- I must be separated from everything dear and pleasing to me;
- I am the heir of my actions: whatever I do, wholesome or unwholesome, will become my inheritance.

These recollections serve sobriety: they weaken heedlessness and help one choose actions of body, speech, and mind more carefully.

A *vedanā* Reminder

The pleasant is not mine.
The unpleasant is not mine.
The neutral is not mine.

But this is not a denial of experience. It is seeing that feeling arises through conditions and ceases through conditions.

A *taṇhā* Reminder

Taṇhā may manifest as:

- "I want";
- "more";
- "remove it";
- "hold it";
- "prove it";
- "become";
- "disappear."

An *upādāna* Reminder

Where is "mine"?

- being right;
- my image;
- my pleasure;
- my pain;
- my path;
- my realization;
- my opinion;
- my control.

A *bhava* Reminder

What mode of existence has switched on?

- "I, the offended one";
- "I, the defender";
- "I, the winner";
- "I, the victim";
- "I, the loved one";
- "I, the special one";
- "I, the controller";
- "I, the practitioner."

25. Glossary of Pali Terms

Adosa

Adosa is the absence of hatred, aversion, and hostile rejection. It is one of the wholesome roots, together with *alobha* and *amoha*. It is not weakness, submission, or a violation of personal boundaries, but a state of mind in which there is no wish to harm, humiliate, suppress, or destroy. It is the opposite of *dosa*.

Ahaṅkāra

"I-making": identification and the appropriation of experience as "this is me." It is close in meaning to the formula *eso'ham asmi*, "this I am."

Anattā

Not-self, impersonality. This is not the nihilistic assertion that "nothing exists." It means that no independent, permanent, governing self can be found in the aggregates or in conditioned processes.

Anusaya

An underlying tendency of the mind. It need not be present as an overt thought or emotion, but may manifest when suitable conditions arise. Pleasant *vedanā* can sustain the underlying tendency to passion, unpleasant *vedanā* the tendency to aversion, and neutral *vedanā* the tendency to ignorance.

Seven are distinguished: sensual attraction, aversion, views, doubt, conceit, attraction to becoming, and ignorance.

Anicca

Impermanence. Whatever has arisen changes and ceases.

Animitta

Signlessness. The cessation of grasping signs (*nimitta*) as supports for further clinging.

Appaṇihita

Undirected, non-aspiring. In the context of the three doors, this means wishlessness: the absence of an impulse to make the conditioned into a support for craving and further becoming. It does not mean suppressing desires.

Ariyasacca

A noble truth, noble in origin. It is not merely a proposition, but something to be fully understood, abandoned, realized, or developed.

Arūpa āyatana

Formless dimensions: boundless space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither-perception-nor-non-perception. These are subtle conditioned attainments, not identical with *Nibbāna*.

Asaṅkhata

The unmade, the unconditioned; not arising as a composite conditioned process.

Āsavā

Influxes through which ignorance and craving sustain the repeated arising of clinging and becoming (*bhava*). *Kāmāsava* is the influx of craving directed toward sensual experience; *bhavāsava* is the influx of craving for existence; *diṭṭhāsava* is the influx of craving directed toward views; *avijjāsava* is the influx of ignorance that conceals the conditionality and operation of processes. *Āsavakkhaya* is the complete exhaustion of the *āsavā*.

Ātāpī

Diligent, earnest, energetically applying effort. The term is associated with the image of heat or burning, but in practice this does not mean self-torment; it means alert energy: not becoming distracted, not feeding the unwholesome, and maintaining the conditions for clarity.

Attavādupādāna

Clinging to a doctrine or idea of self. This does not necessarily take the crude form “I am the body.” It can take subtler forms: “I am consciousness,” “I am pure knowing,” or “Nibbāna is my true self.” In practice, it is important to see not only what such an idea takes as its object, but also the craving for existence that seeks a new foothold.

Avijjā

Ignorance. In SN 12.2, it is not knowing the Four Noble Truths. Under ignorance, the arising and cessation of the five aggregates, dependent origination, recurring tendencies, the succession of former births, craving, clinging, and the appropriation of "I" remain unrecognized. Even the absence of clear seeing may itself go unnoticed.

Avippaṭisāra

Absence of remorse. It arises when conduct leaves no unwholesome trace in the mind and serves as a natural support for joy and collectedness.

Bhava

Becoming, existence. In dependent origination it is conditioned by clinging and conditions birth. Sensual, form, and formless becoming are distinguished. In present experience, the mechanism of becoming can be seen in how an appropriated and sustained coloration of *citta* becomes established as "I am such-and-such."

Bhāvanā

Development, cultivation, the practical nurturing of the conditions of the path. It is not the mechanical production of a result and not violence against the mind. Practice purifies conduct, directs attention, strengthens recollection, collects the mind, and develops wise seeing. As conditions change, the course of experience changes.

Cetanā

Intention or volitional impulse. It directs action through body, speech, or mind. In experience it may be noticed as: "now I will answer," "now I will achieve it," or "now I will hold on to this."

Citta

The current state of mind: with attraction or without it, with aversion or without it, collected or distracted, and so on. It is not a separate thought, but the way the mind is colored at a given moment.

Dhamma

The Buddha's teaching, truth, a phenomenon, or the lawfulness of experience. Practically, it is what leads toward the cessation of *dukkha*. The word may also refer to psychophysical phenomena; its meaning depends on context.

Dosa

Aversion, rejection, irritation, or malice. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *lobha* and *moha*. Under *dosa*, an urge arises to remove, suppress, strike, destroy, or reject an unpleasant object. This should be distinguished from clearly discerning what is harmful: one can see the danger, set boundaries, and stop an unwholesome action without hatred. *Dosa* feeds harshness, hostility, harsh speech, inner violence, and further *dukkha*.

Dukkha

Unsatisfactoriness, painfulness, instability of the conditioned, suffering. It is not limited to gross pain. It also includes the subtler unreliability of everything that arises through conditions, changes, and disintegrates.

Indriya-saṃvara

Restraint of the sense faculties. This is not closing oneself off from life, but wisely caring for which contacts gain access to the mind.

Jarāmaraṇa

Aging-and-death. In the standard formula of dependent origination, this is the aging and death of a being that has been born, together with sorrow, pain, dejection, and despair. On the small scale, every role loses its support and brings anxiety, fatigue, regret, and *dukkha*.

Jāti

Birth. In the standard formula of dependent origination, the appearance of a being, the manifestation of the aggregates, and the acquisition of the sense fields. On the small scale, the birth of a particular "I-state."

Jhāna

Meditative collectedness. The standard formula of the path describes four *rūpa*-jhānas. They are valuable for purifying and stabilizing the mind, but are not to be made into objects of clinging.

Karuṇā

Compassion; an immeasurable quality of *citta*: clear recognition of suffering and readiness to lessen it when possible.

Khandhā

The five aggregates: *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa*. They are objects of clinging when taken as "I" or "mine."

Lobha

Greed, avarice, grasping desire. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *dosa* and *moha*, and is closely related to *taṇhā* and *rāga*. Under *lobha*, attraction to an object manifests as an urge to obtain it, retain it, repeat it, or make it "mine." This should be distinguished from a wholesome wish to practice. The wish to abandon the unwholesome, develop the path, and understand the Dhamma may be part of right effort. *Lobha*, by contrast, feeds appropriation, clinging, and further *bhava*.

Lokuttara-paññā

Supramundane wisdom; wisdom that directly knows *Nibbāna* and the four *ariyasacca*. It is not a state of *citta*, but *paññā* through which conditioned processes are seen as they are.

Magga

The path. In the framework of the early suttas, this is the Noble Eightfold Path, cultivated through ethics, collectedness, and wisdom.

Mamaṅkāra

"Mine-making": appropriating experience as "this is mine." It corresponds to the formula *etaṃ mama*, "this is mine."

Māna

Conceit and subtle comparison organized around "I": "I am," "I am superior," "I am inferior," "I am equal," or "I understood." It is not limited to gross pride, but includes the subtle habit of relating experience to a center called "I."

Mettā

Goodwill; an immeasurable quality of *citta*, free from hostility, rejection, and the intention to cause harm. It does not require being directed toward a particular being.

Moha

Delusion, confusion, obscuration, or misapprehension. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *lobha* and *dosa*. It is not merely a lack of information, but a distortion in which the impermanent appears stable, the conditioned appears independent, and the impersonal is taken as "I" or "mine." It is closely related to *avijjā*. In this document, *avijjā* refers more broadly to ignorance of the Four Noble Truths and conditionality, while *moha* often denotes the concrete obscuration and confusion from which unwholesome intentions of body, speech, and mind arise.

Muditā

Appreciative joy; an immeasurable quality of *citta* in which the welfare and happiness of others are perceived without envy or comparison.

Nāma-rūpa

Name-and-form, the psychophysical complex. *Nāma* includes feeling, recognition, intention, contact, and attention; *rūpa* is material form.

Nibbāna

The realization of liberation: the cessation of clinging to the five *khandhā*. Arising processes are no longer appropriated as "I" and "mine."

Nibbidā

Cooling toward clinging. It arises when it is clearly seen that conditioned processes are impermanent, cease, and that clinging to them leads to *dukkha*.

Nimitta

A sign, mark, or characteristic feature by which an object is distinguished. Its meaning varies by context; in the section on the three doors, the important aspect is grasping a sign as a support for the further unfolding of experience.

Nirodha

Cessation. Depending on context, it may refer to the cessation of a particular link, the cessation of *dukkha*, *Nibbāna*, or, in a meditative context, the cessation of perception and feeling.

Pamojja

Joy, inspiration, or clear uplift born of a wholesome direction. It is not sensual euphoria, but a healthy enlivening of the mind.

Papañca

Mental proliferation, self-narrative, conceptual multiplication of experience. This is not every instance of thought, but proliferation around "I," "mine," and "for me": mental elaboration, fantasizing, arguing, comparing, defending a self-image, replaying scenarios, and constructing a world around appropriated experience. Such proliferation is fed by *taṇhā*, *māna*, *diṭṭhi*, and *avijjā*.

It may begin with a small association or assumption when gaps in clear knowing are filled in, and the story that has arisen is then taken as something directly seen.

Paññā

Wisdom; direct understanding of conditionality, the arising and fading of processes, and of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. It is not identical with a clear, pleasant, or collected state of *citta*.

Paṭinissagga

Relinquishment, letting go. In practice, it is not a volitional command, "I let go," but the weakening of grasping through seeing conditions, impermanence, and cessation. With clear seeing that what is held arose through conditions and cannot serve as a reliable support, clinging loses nourishment.

Phassa

Contact: the coming together of a sense faculty, its object, and the corresponding consciousness. *Phassa* is a condition for the arising of *vedanā*.

Rāga

Passion, attraction, coloration by attachment. With *rāga*, an object or state is experienced as especially attractive. It is closely related to *taṇhā*, but is not completely identical with it. *Rāga* is not limited to the sensual: *rūparāga* and *arūparāga* denote attachment to subtle form and the formless.

Saddhā

Confidence or trust. It is not blind acceptance, but the confidence that motivates practice and verification.

Sakkāya-diṭṭhi

Identity view based on the five aggregates: regarding body, feeling, recognition, formations, or consciousness as self, as belonging to self, as contained within self, or as containing self. In practice, this manifests as the appropriation of experience and the construction, on that basis, of "I" and "mine."

Saḷāyatana

The six sense fields: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, together with their corresponding objects.

Samādhi

Collectedness, unification of mind (*cittassa ekaggatā*). In MN 44, the four *satipaṭṭhāna* are called its bases, the four right efforts its necessary supports, and their repeated development the development of *samādhi*.

Sampajañña

Clear comprehension of what is happening: actions, intentions, appropriateness, the state of mind, and the conditions currently manifesting. In practice, it works closely together with *sati*.

Samudaya

The arising of *dukkha*. It is sustained by the interconnected *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna*.

Saṅkhārā

Formations. Depending on context, the term may denote formative activities that set conditions for subsequent experience, or formative reactions arising within an unfolding process.

In dependent origination, *saṅkhārā* condition *viññāṇa*; within the five *khandhā*, intentions (*cetanā*) are especially important.

Saññā

Perception and recognition. In coarse experience it distinguishes and recognizes an object, connects it with memory, and participates in labeling. In deep *samādhi*, *saññā* becomes refined to an elementary definiteness of experience without ordinary recognition and conceptualization. The expression *sukhuma-saññā*, subtle perception, is used for this level. In DN 9 the expression *sukhuma-sacca-saññā* is used for subtle forms: subtle, genuinely present perception.

Saññāvedayitanirodha

The cessation of perception and feeling. This is a particular meditative attainment, not an intellectual idea of emptiness or simple unconsciousness.

Sati

Recollection: returning to the object and framework of practice. It is not vague observation, but a quality that sustains clear knowing of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā*. Renderings include "awareness," "attentiveness," and "the capacity for self-awareness." *Sati* is recollection: the ability to retain in mind the Dhamma, the direction of the path, and the present task of practice. The rendering "awareness" is useful only in part, provided it is not reduced to neutral *mindfulness*.

Suññata

Emptiness: the absence in experience of "I" and what belongs to "I."

Taṇhā

Craving; saṃsāric fuel that sustains the formation of experience and clinging to the five *khandhā*. Not every desire or intention is *taṇhā*. In experience it may manifest as "more," "hold on," "continue," "obtain," "change," "remove," "do not lose," or "become."

Upādāna

Clinging, appropriation, holding on, "I need it." With *upādāna*, an object, state, opinion, rule, or idea of "I" is held and appropriated as "mine": my views, my pleasures, my being right, my image, my path. In some translations, the terms "attachment" or "striving" are used, but *upādāna* should not be confused with wholesome effort. Here the issue is grasping at an object, state, opinion, ritual, or idea of "I" that sustains further *bhava*.

Upanisā

A supporting condition or proximate support. In SN 12.23, *dukkha* can become an *upanisā* for *saddhā* when it is understood as pointing to the unreliability of the conditioned and the necessity of the path.

Upekkhā

Equanimity; an immeasurable quality of *citta* in which the pleasant and unpleasant are recognized without an automatic urge to retain the former or eliminate the latter. Clarity and discernment of what is beneficial, harmful, safe, and dangerous are preserved.

Vedanā

Feeling tone: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. It is not yet an emotion or a narrative, but it is precisely here that *taṇhā* often begins.

Sāmisa

With worldly, sensual nourishment. In contemplation of *vedanā*, this distinction is applied to pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling. For pleasant feeling, a clear example is pleasure arising on the basis of the five strands of sensual pleasure.

Nirāmisa

Without worldly, sensual nourishment; connected with renunciation. In contemplation of *vedanā*, this distinction is likewise applied to pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling. It does not simply mean "spiritual" as opposed to "bodily," and it is not limited to *samādhi*.

Vicikicchā

Doubt, uncertainty, or indecision that prevents confident continuation. As a hindrance it clouds the mind and weakens wisdom. In MN 16, doubt concerning the Teacher, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, or the practice obstructs diligence and persistence. As a fetter it is abandoned at stream-entry. The term does not cover every question or inquiry, but rather paralyzing doubt that keeps the mind in indecision and prevents action even when the direction of practice is sufficiently clear.

Vipallāsa

Distortion, inversion of perception, mind, or view. In AN 4.49: taking the impermanent as permanent, *dukkha* as satisfactory, "self" in *anattā*, and the beautiful (*subha*) in the unattractive (*asubha*).

Vimutti

Liberation. In practical terms, liberation of the mind from clinging, craving, hostility, and ignorance. It is not a status or self-image, but the cessation of the conditions that sustain *dukkha*.

Vinaya

Discipline, training, a canonical division, and a way of organizing life under conditions that support the path. In a broad practical sense it is not merely a collection of rules, but a form that protects practice from disorder.

Viññāṇa

Consciousness as the process of awareness of an object: visual, auditory, olfactory, gustatory, bodily, or mental. It arises dependent on conditions and, within the early-sutta framework, is not an independent bearer of experience, a hidden owner called "I," or a self.

Virāga

Dispassion; the fading of coloration and extinguishing of *taṇhā* toward conditioned experience.

Yoniso manasikāra

Wise direction of attention: seeing causes, conditions, arising, and cessation.

26. Supporting Suttas and Sources for Verification

The list below is not exhaustive. These are sources for checking the principal themes.

- SN 56.11 *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*: the Four Noble Truths; in the Pali version, knowledge-and-vision of the four truths is developed through three rounds and twelve aspects.

- SN 12.2 *Vibhaṅga Sutta*: the expanded formula of dependent origination, including the six classes of *taṇhā* and the three kinds of *saṅkhārā*.
- SN 12.15 *Kaccānagotta Sutta*: avoiding the extremes of existence and non-existence.
- SN 12.23 *Upanisā Sutta*: the liberating sequence of conditions from *dukkha* to *saddhā*, *samādhi*, *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*.
- DN 2 *Sāmaññaphala Sutta*: gradual training through *sīla*, sense restraint, *sati-sampajañña*, contentment, abandonment of the five hindrances, the four jhānas, and knowledge of liberation.
- DN 15 *Mahānidāna Sutta*: the mutual dependence of *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa*, and *nāma-rūpa* as a basis for *phassa*.
- DN 16 *Mahāparinibbāna Sutta*: the Dhamma and Vinaya as teacher after the Buddha's passing.
- DN 31 *Siṅgālasutta*: advice to the layperson Sigāla.
- MN 29 *Mahāsāropama Sutta*: *vimutti* as the heartwood of the holy life: not honor, morality, collectedness, or knowledge in themselves, but liberation of mind.
- MN 22 *Alagaddūpama Sutta*: the Dhamma as a raft for crossing over, and the danger of grasping the teaching wrongly, like taking a snake by the wrong end.
- SN 35.28 *Ādittapariyāya Sutta*: seeing the six sense fields as burning with passion, hatred, and delusion gives rise to *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*.
- MN 28 *Mahāhatthipadopamasutta*: internal and external elements, their impermanence and non-appropriation, and the conditions for the manifestation of the corresponding sense consciousness, *tajjo samannāhāro*.
- SN 35.23 *Sabba Sutta*: "the all" as the six sense fields of experience.
- SN 22.59 *Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta*: the five aggregates as *anattā*.
- SN 22.89 *Khemaka Sutta*: residual "I am" in relation to the five aggregates and the comparison with the scent of a flower.
- MN 148 *Chachakka Sutta*: the six sextets, contact, feeling, craving, not-self, and the relation of pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling to the tendencies toward passion, aversion, and ignorance.
- AN 6.63 *Nibbedhika Sutta*: intention as *kamma*; sensuality as passionate intention toward attractive objects.
- SN 51.13 / SN 51.20: *chanda* as one basis for developing collectedness and effort (*iddhipāda*).
- AN 8.53 *Gotamī Sutta*: criteria for what accords with the Dhamma and Vinaya (*Dhamma-Vinaya*).
- SN 45.8 *Magga-vibhaṅga Sutta*: the Noble Eightfold Path.
- SN 12.11: the four kinds of nutriment: physical food, contact, intention, and consciousness.
- SN 12.64: nutriment, craving, the establishment of consciousness, and conditions for new becoming.
- SN 12.12: the four kinds of nutriment; consciousness as nutriment for new becoming, not food for a separate "I."
- SN 12.38 and SN 12.39: intention, planning, and underlying tendencies as conditions for the establishment of consciousness and the continuation of dependent origination.
- MN 2 *Sabbāsava Sutta*: different ways of abandoning the *āsavā*: seeing, restraint, use, endurance, avoidance, removal, and development.
- MN 20 *Vitakkasaṇṭhāna Sutta*: practical methods for working with unwholesome thoughts.
- MN 5: honest diagnosis of stains in the mind, seeing a defilement when it is present and its absence when it is absent.

- MN 9 *Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta*: right view as understanding a phenomenon, its arising, its cessation, and the path to its cessation; the mutual conditionality of *āsava* and *avijjā*, and the three kinds of *āsava*.
- MN 18 *Madhupiṇḍika Sutta*: contact, feeling, recognition, thought, and *papañca*.
- SN 46.51: the nourishment and non-nourishment of the hindrances and awakening factors.
- SN 46.53: balancing the factors: investigation, energy, and joy are needed during sluggishness; tranquility, collectedness, and equanimity during agitation.
- SN 4.4: wise direction of attention and right effort as a concise statement of the path's working heart.
- SN 4.5: the Dhamma is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end.
- SN 4.7: an example of practice after walking meditation: the lion's posture, recollection, clear comprehension, and attention to the time for rising.
- SN 4.17 *Chaphassāyatanasutta*: the Dhamma as a matter of vital importance.
- AN 11.1 / AN 11.2: virtue, absence of remorse, joy, tranquility, collectedness, knowledge-and-vision, and liberation.
- AN 10.13: the ten fetters (*saṃyojana*) and their relation to the stages of awakening.
- MN 10 / DN 22 *Satipaṭṭhāna*: the four foundations of recollection, the five hindrances, and the seven awakening factors as part of contemplating *dhammā*; also the standard formula for seated meditation: a suitable place, *pallaṅkaṁ*, an upright back, and established recollection.
- MN 62 *Mahārāhulovādasutta*: internal and external elements and the development of a mind like earth, water, fire, air, and space, which is not seized by pleasant or unpleasant contacts.
- MN 118 *Ānāpānasati Sutta*: breathing, the four foundations of recollection, and the seven awakening factors.
- MN 119 *Kāyagatāsati Sutta*: recollection of the body and the description of the four jhānas in the context of bodily awareness and collectedness.
- Iti 43 / Ud 8.3: the unborn, unarisen, unmade.
- MN 26 *Ariyapariyesanā Sutta*: the noble search and the limitations of formless attainments as a final goal.
- MN 43 *Mahāvedalla Sutta*: the interconnection of feeling, recognition, and consciousness; questions concerning the cessation of perception and feeling.
- MN 121 *Cūḷasuññata Sutta*: gradual abiding in emptiness.
- MN 106 *Āneñjasappāya Sutta*: the path to the imperturbable and subtle meditative supports.
- DN 1 *Brahmajāla Sutta*: a broad survey of speculative views.
- MN 13 *Mahādukkhakkhandha Sutta*: gratification, danger, and escape in relation to sensual pleasures.
- MN 19 *Dvedhāvitakka Sutta*: two directions of thought and the mind's habitual inclination.
- MN 21 *Kakacūpama Sutta*: maintaining goodwill and freedom from inner hatred in the face of abuse.
- MN 36 *Mahāsaccaka Sutta*: the happiness of the first jhāna, which need not be feared.
- MN 38 *Mahātaṇhāsaṅkhaya Sutta*: consciousness arises dependent on conditions and is not an unchanging entity.
- MN 41 *Sāleyyaka Sutta*: unwholesome and wholesome conduct by body, speech, and mind.
- MN 61 *Ambalaṭṭhikarāhulovāda Sutta*: examining an action before, during, and after it.

- MN 64 *Mahāmālukya Sutta*: underlying tendencies, the lower fetters, and their abandonment.
- MN 75 *Māgaṇḍiya Sutta*: the image of scratching sores and liberation from sensual craving.
- MN 117 *Mahācattārīsaka Sutta*: right and wrong path factors, and right collectedness with its seven supports.
- SN 35.63 *Paṭhamamigajāla Sutta*: craving as a companion even in external solitude.
- SN 36.6 *Salla Sutta*: the first and second darts.
- SN 47.5 *Kusalarāsi Sutta*: the five hindrances as the mass of the unwholesome and the four establishments of recollection as the mass of the wholesome.
- AN 4.41 *Samādhibhāvanā Sutta*: four purposes for developing collectedness.
- AN 4.123 *Paṭhamanānākaraṇa Sutta*: clinging to jhāna and the rebirth conditioned by it.
- AN 4.162 *Vitthāra Sutta*: painful and pleasant modes of practice.
- AN 4.170 *Yuganaddha Sutta*: different relations between tranquility and insight.
- AN 5.177 *Vaṇijjā Sutta*: five kinds of trade a lay follower should avoid.
- AN 6.19 *Paṭhamamaraṇassati Sutta*: recollection of death and a sense of urgency.
- AN 6.61 *Majjhe Sutta*: craving as the seamstress that stitches becoming together.
- AN 7.11 *Paṭhamaanusaya Sutta*: the seven underlying tendencies.
- AN 8.29 *Akkhaṇasutta*: a favorable opportunity for practice.
- AN 9.35 *Gāvīupamā Sutta*: mastering an attained basis without moving on prematurely.
- AN 9.36 *Jhāna Sutta*: jhāna and the first three formless attainments as bases for liberating vision.
- Snp 1.8 *Mettā Sutta*: goodwill, freedom from contempt, and not wishing suffering upon another.
- Dhp 5: hostility is not calmed by hostility.
- Dhp 276: the Tathāgatas point out the path; one must practice it oneself.
- Dhp 334–336, 347: images of a creeping vine, grass growing back, and a spider in its own web.
- SN 11.3 *Dhajagga Sutta*: recollection of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha as a support in the face of fear.
- AN 11.11 *Paṭhama Mahānāma Sutta*: recollection of the Buddha, straightening the mind, joy, tranquility, and collectedness.
- Iti 50 *Mūla Sutta*: the three unwholesome roots: *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*.
- SN 35.82 *Lokapañhā Sutta*: the "world" as arising and ceasing sense fields, consciousness, contact, and feeling.
- AN 10.61 *Avijjā Sutta*: no beginning of ignorance can be discovered, but the conditions that feed it can be discerned.
- AN 10.72 *Kaṇṭaka Sutta*: sound as a "thorn" for the first jhāna.
- MN 135 *Cūḷakammavibhaṅga Sutta*: inheriting the consequences of one's own actions.
- MN 136 *Mahākammavibhaṅga Sutta*: the complexity of the ripening of *kamma* and the danger of mechanical conclusions.
- SN 12.38 *Cetanā Sutta*: intention, planning, and sustained tendencies as conditions supporting further becoming.
- SN 36.21 *Sīvaka Sutta*: not every feeling is conditioned solely by past *kamma*.
- MN 39 *Mahāassapura Sutta*: gradual training, abandonment of the hindrances, and the four jhānas.
- AN 6.55 *Soṇa Sutta*: tuning effort through the image of a string's tension.
- AN 9.7 *Sutavā Sutta*: actions an arahant bhikkhu is incapable of performing intentionally.

- SN 5.2 *Somā Sutta*: women's capacity for liberation and the distinction between a conventional designation and an appropriated identity.
- SN 22.1 *Nakulapitu Sutta*: the fourfold formula of *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* applied to each of the five aggregates.
- SN 22.87 *Vakkali Sutta*: the formula "one who sees the Dhamma sees me," followed by contemplation of the five aggregates through impermanence, *dukkha*, and non-appropriation.
- MN 95 *Caṅkīsutta*: the limitations of faith, preference, oral tradition, reasoning, and an accepted view, together with the path to direct knowledge.
- AN 4.180 *Mahāpadesasutta*: the four great references for evaluating a report attributed to the Buddha, the Saṅgha, or learned elders.
- MN 70 *Kīṭāgiri Sutta*: seven kinds of noble disciples, including one liberated by wisdom.
- Dhp 19–20: textual knowledge without practice, and a little knowledge embodied in life.
- AN 5.51 *Āvaraṇa Sutta*: the five hindrances as states that weaken wisdom and obstruct understanding one's own welfare, the welfare of others, and the welfare of both.
- AN 5.57 *Abhiṇhapaccavekkhitabbaṭhāna Sutta*: five themes for frequent reflection: aging, illness, death, separation from what is dear, and recollection that one is heir to one's actions.
- AN 7.65 *Hirīottappa Sutta*: *hiri* and *ottappa* as conditions for guarding the senses.
- SN 22.56 *Upādānaparipavatta Sutta*: the aggregate of *saṅkhārā* as six classes of intention.
- SN 45.2 *Upaḍḍha Sutta*: good friendship, companionship, and association as a condition for developing the Noble Eightfold Path.
- MN 16 *Cetokhila Sutta*: doubt concerning the Teacher, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and the training as an obstacle to diligence and progress.
- MN 109 *Mahāpuṇṇama Sutta*: the five clinging-aggregates and the error of searching for a separate "self" after recognizing the five aggregates as "not self."
- SN 16.9 *Jhānābhiññā Sutta*: the sequence of the jhānas and formless dimensions, including the transition from boundless space to infinite consciousness and onward to the dimension of nothingness.
- AN 9.41 *Tapussa Sutta*: attainment of and emergence from the nine successive meditative attainments in forward and reverse order.
- SN 36.11 *Rahogata Sutta*: the successive cessation of supports, including the cessation of the perception of infinite consciousness in the dimension of nothingness.
- SN 43.4 *Suññatasamādhi Sutta*: emptiness concentration, signless concentration, and undirected concentration as a path to the unconditioned.
- MN 44 *Cūḷavedalla Sutta*: the five *upādānakkhandhā* and the arising of *sakkāya*; *samādhi* as *cittassa ekaggatā*; sadness arising from aspiration toward liberation; and the three contacts after emerging from *saññāvedayitanirodha*.
- MN 137 *Saḷāyatanavibhaṅga Sutta*: the transition from sadness of renunciation to joy, and then to equanimity.
- SN 35.85 *Suññataloka Sutta*: the world is empty of "self" and what belongs to "self"; emptiness is disclosed through the six sense fields, consciousness, contact, and feeling.
- SN 12.67 *Naḷakalāpī Sutta*: the mutual conditionality of *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa*, compared to two bundles of reeds supporting each other.
- SN 40.5 *Ākāsānañcāyatanapañhā Sutta*: Moggallāna's entry into the dimension of boundless space and the instruction to become established in it.
- DN 21 *Sakkapañha Sutta*: the criterion for bodily and verbal conduct and seeking; the sequence *papañcasaññāsaṅkhā* → *vitakka* → *chanda* → *piyāppiya* → *issā-macchariya*

and the further unfolding of conflict.

- DN 9 *Poṭṭhapāda Sutta*: the progressive refinement of *saññā*, *sukhuma-sacca-saññā*, the limit of perception, and the cessation of new construction. It has a Chinese parallel, DĀ 28, which also contains the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.
- DN 33 *Saṅgīti Sutta*: various triads of craving, including *rūpa-taṇhā*, *arūpa-taṇhā*, and *nirodha-taṇhā*.
- SN 36.31 *Nirāmisa Sutta*: the distinction between *sāmisa* and *nirāmisa* for *pīti*, *sukha*, *upekkhā*, and liberation; the comparison between sensual pleasure, jhānic pleasure, and a deeper liberation.
- MN 140 *Dhātuvibhaṅga Sutta*: the six elements, the formless attainments examined as conditioned, and the principle of not forming intention toward either *bhava* or *vibhava*.
- SN 55.5 *Dutiyasāriputta Sutta*: the "stream" as the Noble Eightfold Path.
- MN 142 *Dakkhiṇāvibhaṅga Sutta*: one practicing for the fruit of stream-entry and one who has realized that fruit.
- SN 25.1 *Cakkhu Sutta*: *saddhānusārī* and *dhammānusārī* before the realization of the fruit of stream-entry.
- SN 40.9 *Animittapañhā Sutta*: signless collectedness through not directing attention to *nimitta*.
- SN 22.49 *Soṇa Sutta*: comparison as "I am superior," "I am equal," and "I am inferior" on the basis of the five aggregates.
- AN 4.49 *Vipallāsa Sutta*: the four distortions.
- SN 4.19, *Kassaka Sutta*: the six fields in the exchange between the Buddha and Māra, including the mind and mental phenomena.
- SN 4.14, *Patirūpa Sutta*: compassion without attachment or aversion.
- SN 12.51, *Parivīmaṃsa Sutta*: three kinds of formations under ignorance.
- SN 15.1, *Tiṇakaṭṭha Sutta*: beings obscured by ignorance and bound by craving continue to wander through saṃsāra.
- MN 79, *Cūḷasakuludāyi Sutta*: Udāyin cannot recall all the events even of his present life; the Buddha explains dependent origination.
- SN 15.3, *Assu Sutta*: tears shed over countless births.
- SN 15.10, *Puggala Sutta*: bones collected over one aeon.
- SN 22.27: the attraction, danger, and escape with respect to the five aggregates.

Useful Materials for Critical Comparison

YouTube channels

- ISKONNY BUDDHA: valuable analyses of the Buddha's original teaching 

Books

- Bhikkhu P. A. Payutto, *Good, Evil and Beyond: Kamma in the Buddha's Teaching*: an examination of *kamma* as intention, the distinction between *kusala* and *akusala*, the ripening of the results of actions, and the path to the cessation of *kamma*.
- Bhikkhu Anālayo, *Satipaṭṭhāna Meditation: A Practice Guide*: practical clarifications concerning the four foundations of recollection, contemplation of the body, feelings, mind, hindrances, and awakening factors.
- Ajahn Brahm, *Mindfulness, Bliss, and Beyond*: used selectively as a source of practical advice on letting go, the hindrances, sustained attention, and walking meditation. Its model of *nimitta* and the shutting down of the senses is best regarded as a highly specific interpretation.

Useful Later Texts

- Padmasambhava, *The Treasure of the Lotus Crystal Cave* (instructions of Śrī Siṃha; a chapter in *Treasures from Juniper Ridge*).
- Saraha, *Treasury of Songs*. Russian audio narration (incomplete text).
- *Prajñāpāramitāhṛdaya*, the Heart Sūtra.

Playlist with Russian audio narrations.